UNIVERSIDADE PRESBITERIANA MACKENZIE

CENTRO DE CIÊNCIAS SOCIAIS E APLICADAS

PROGRAMA DE PÓS-GRADUAÇÃO EM ADMINISTRAÇÃO DE EMPRESAS

EXPLORING ORGANIZATIONAL AGE NORMS IN A TECHNOLOGY STARTUP

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São Paulo, SP
2024

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EXPLORING ORGANIZATIONAL AGE NORMS IN A TECHNOLOGY STARTUP

Research project submitted to Universidade Presbiteriana Mackenzie as a requirement for the attainment of the title Doctor in Business Administration.

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São Paulo, SP

2024

A228e Adegbesan, Christiana Adebukola.
Exploring organizational age norms in a technology startup. [recurso eletrônico] / Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan.
3 KB ; il.

Tese(Doutorado em Profissional em Administração de Empresas) – Universidade Presbiteriana Mackenzie, São Paulo, 2024.
Orientador: Profa. Dra. Darcy Mitiko Mori Hanashiro.
Bibliografia: p. 149-160

1. Organizational Age Norms. 2. Age Norms. 3. Age Stereotype. 4. Age beliefs. 5. Younger workers. 6. Older workers. I. Hanashiro, Darcy Mitiko Mori, *orientadora*. II. Título.

Bibliotecária Responsável: Aline Amarante Pereira - CRB 8/9549

Folha de Identificação da Agência de Financiamento

Autor: Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan

Programa de Pós-Graduação *Stricto Sensu* em Administração de Empresas

Título do Trabalho: Exploring Organizational Age Norms in a Technology Startup

O presente trabalho foi realizado com o apoio de [1]:

☒ CAPES - Coordenação de Aperfeiçoamento de Pessoal de Nível Superior

☐ CNPq - Conselho Nacional de Desenvolvimento Científico e Tecnológico

☐ FAPESP - Fundação de Amparo à Pesquisa do Estado de São Paulo

☐ Instituto Presbiteriano Mackenzie/Isenção integral de Mensalidades e Taxas

☐ MACKPESQUISA - Fundo Mackenzie de Pesquisa

☐ Empresa/Indústria:

☐ Outro:

[1] **Observação**: caso tenha usufruído mais de um apoio ou benefício, selecione-os.

CHRISTIANA ADEBUKOLA ADEGBESAN

EXPLORING ORGANIZATIONAL AGE NORMS IN A TECHNOLOGY STARTUP

Tese apresentada ao Programa de Pós- Graduação em Administração de Empresas da Universidade Presbiteriana Mackenzie, como requisito à obtenção de título de Doutor em Administração de Empresas.

Aprovada em 20 de agosto de 2024.

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In loving memory of my dear brother Jacob Adetola Adegbesan.

Acknowledgement

To God Almighty, through His infinite mercy I was able to start and complete this journey.

To my dear research supervisor and advisor, Professor Darcy Mitiko Mori Hanashiro, whose expertise, patience and guidance has been invaluable throughout the course of this thesis and who has enlightened my now found love for academics and has provided me with a deeper understanding of this topic I value so much.

To Profs Diógenes de Souza Bido and Walter Bataglia, who, as program coordinators during my academic years, supported me through their teachings and inspiration to pursue research excellence.

To my professor, Maria Luiza Mendes Teixeira, who always took her time to give me insightful feedback during my quarterly research presentation. I truly appreciate these inputs.
To Tatiane Domingues Gonçalez, for her unwavering administrative support in the last four years.

To my parents, Col and Mrs. Adegbesan, for their love, dedication and support in this journey from start to finish.

To my brothers, Seun and Remi Adegbesan, who always pushed me to be the best that I could be.

To Alan Johnson, who with great affection and commitment, supported me throughout this thesis.

To Becky Johnson, whose encouragement has been a source of strength.

To my dear friend, Esther Bisiriyu, who constantly encouraged me to keep writing.

To the leadership of my research organization, who provided me with a base for my research and willingly participated in the research.

Abstract

Age norms, which pertain to the expectations and standards surrounding age and roles, exert significant influence within organizational settings. Within the context of an organization, age norms can give rise to stereotypes, particularly in relation to beliefs about the age of specific individuals. Moreover, these age norms can broadly impact recruitment and selection processes, promotions, retirement, and the overall work environment. Despite the relevance and impact of age norms for individuals in the organization, there are few empirical studies in the field of organizational studies. A systematic review of the literature revealed that there are literature gaps on how age norms in the organization are formed and the implications of organizational age norms for management. The primary objective of this research is to comprehend how age norms are created within organizations and to identify their effects within the organization and on employee behavior. We carried out qualitative research in a technology startup. Employing a netnographic approach, our data collection sources included observation, interviews, and secondary data. We conducted interviews with 15 individuals and observed the company for approximately 3 months. By combining these sources of data, and analyzing them through thematic analysis, we were able to ascertain how age norms were created within the organization and the impact they have on workers' behavior. Our findings show that age norms have an influence on recruitment and selection processes, hiring decisions, employee behavior and the intention to leave an organization.

Keywords: organizational age norms, age norms, age stereotype, age beliefs, younger workers, older workers

Resumo

Normas de idade, que são pertinentes às expectativas e padrões em torno da idade e dos papeis da idade, exercem influência significativa dentro dos ambientes organizacionais. Dentro do contexto de uma organização, normas de idade podem dar origem a estereótipos, particularmente em relação a crenças sobre a idade de indivíduos específicos. Além disso, essas normas de idade podem impactar amplamente os processos de recrutamento e seleção, promoções, aposentadoria e o ambiente de trabalho em geral. Apesar da relevância e do impacto das normas de idade para indivíduos na organização, há poucos estudos empíricos no campo dos estudos organizacionais. Uma revisão sistemática da literatura revelou que há lacunas na literatura sobre como as normas de idade na organização são formadas e as implicações das normas de idade organizacionais para gestão. O objetivo principal desta pesquisa é compreender como as normas de idade são estabelecidas dentro das organizações e identificar seus efeitos dentro da organização e no comportamento dos funcionários. Realizamos uma pesquisa qualitativa em uma startup de tecnologia. Empregando uma abordagem netnográfica, nossas fontes de coleta de dados incluíram observação, entrevistas e dados secundários. Conduzimos entrevistas com 15 indivíduos e observamos a empresa por aproximadamente 3 meses. Ao combinar essas fontes de dados e analisá-las por meio de análise temática, fomos capazes de verificar como as normas de idade foram estabelecidas dentro da organização e o impacto que elas têm no comportamento dos trabalhadores. Nossas descobertas mostram que as normas de idade têm influência nos processos de recrutamento e seleção, decisões de contratação, comportamento dos funcionários e a intenção de sair de uma organização.

Palavras-chave: normas etárias organizacionais, normas etárias, estereótipo etário, crenças etárias, trabalhadores mais jovens, trabalhadores mais velhos

List of Figures

Figure 1 – Organizational Age Norms Funnel……43

Figure 2 – Sources of Data Collection……..71

Figure 3 – 6 Phase Approach to Data Analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2012……..73

Figure 4 – Age Groups of Employees from January 2023 to May 2023……120

Figure 5 – Percentage of Leavers According to the Age Ranges……121

Figure 6 – Themes Derived from all Data Sources……122

Figure 7 – The Role of Culture in Age Norms……..123

Figure 8 – Age Norms in the Organization……124

Figure 9 – Applicant Feedback……125

Figure 10 – The Origin of Age Norms……125

Figure 11 – Age Norms Sanctions in the Organization……126

Figure 12 – The Role of Age Norms in the Organization……127

Figure 13 – Mind Map of how this Conclusion was Derived……129

List of Tables

Table 1- Search String by Base……38

Table 2 - Age Norms Context and Definitions……45

Table 3 - Beliefs Around the Expectations of Age Norms, Judgements and Behavior……55

Table 4 - Retirement……59

Table 5 - Recruitment and Retention……62

Table 6 - Respondents' Profile……84

Table 7 - Sources of Observation……88

Table 8 - Employee Nationality YTD……106

Table 9 - Comparison of Older and Younger Workers……111

Table 10 - Employee Leaving Reasons……118

Table 11 - Total Number of Starters from January 2023 to May 2023……119

Table 12 - Total Number of Leavers from January 2023 to May 2023……120

Table of Contents

Acknowledgement ***8***

Abstract ***9***

Resumo ***10***

List of Figures ***12***

List of Tables ***13***

Chapter 1: Introduction ***15***

Chapter 2: Literature Review ***18***

Chapter 3: Research Method and Methodology ***65***

Chapter 4: Results and Discussion ***77***

Chapter 5: Final Considerations ***141***

References ***149***

Appendices ***161***

Chapter 1: Introduction

The term "norm" encompasses various meanings, primarily revolving around regularity and appropriate group behavior (Paluck & Ball, 2010). Nichols (2002) asserts that norms are fundamental rules that dictate our actions and, to some extent, have been recognized as influential in regulating social conduct (Hechter & Opp, 2005). Norms are cultural constructs that prescribe and prohibit behavior in specific contexts (Hechter & Opp, 2005).

Frequently, we come across phrases such as 'act your age' which implies that individuals of specific age groups should behave in a certain manner. Essentially, this phrase means that there is the need to distinguish older individuals from younger ones based on their conduct or behavior (Lawrence, 1996a). In a professional setting, age norms are closely linked to age stereotypes and are sometimes normalized or taken for granted, particularly in terms of how individuals are managed or self-managed in relation to understanding the impact of their age in the workplace (Vickerstaff & Van der Horst, 2021). Moreso, in organizational settings, employees tend to compare, evaluate, and take note of others' ages to gauge their own career progress or potentially predict their future advancement within the company (Kidder, 1981).

Numerous events can serve as opportunities to gauge age norms. When we meet someone for the first time, we naturally assess their age, which in turn leads to certain expectations and potential to influence how we communicate with them. Consequently, age norms tend to shape behaviors. These behaviors may arise from the violation of our expectations regarding age, or even when these expectations of age are met by individuals. Lawrence (2004) highlighted instances where individuals are taken aback when a company's CEO is considered 'young' or when a flight attendant is perceived as 'old' and simultaneously a trainee. There are numerous examples of expectations and violations of age norms. Many of these age norms, which are socially constructed, can be created by organizations, particularly in relation to positions and career advancement. Often, individuals evaluate their own success based on the achievements of others in their age group or the positions they hold. Additionally, certain

phrases reflect the expectations we associate with age norms, such as 'how did she manage to secure that job, she is so young' or 'if he doesn't get promoted now, he may never have another opportunity, he is too old for it' (Lawrence, 2004).

There are various effects of age norms in organizations, which manifest as responses to different situations related to age. Some of these effects, as seen in literature, are associated with workplace behavior (Rhodes, 1983), job performance (Dalton & Thompson, 1971), hiring practices (Skuciene & Moskvina, 2019), retirement policies (Karpinska et al., 2013), internal advancement opportunities, and overall decision-making processes (Waldman & Avolio, 1993). A systematic literature review conducted for this study revealed a lack of research on the origins of age norms in organizations and the specific age norms prevalent in particular industries. Moreover, there exists a significant gap in understanding the implications of organizational age norms for management. Because of the relevance of age norms for management and the scarcity of empirical articles on this topic, and particularly to understand how these age norms operate in organizations, the following research problem was defined: “how are organizational age norms developed and their influence in organizations?”. This question will encompass the gaps we have when dealing with the definition, sanctions and group elements associated with the formation of age norms. The primary objective of this research is to understand the formation and influence of age norms in organizations in a technology start up. As secondary objectives, this research intends a) to explore how age norms are formed in a technology startup, b) to identify the implications of age norms on workers’ behaviour in a technology startup, c) to identify how age norms violations are sanctioned within the organization and, d) to analyze the extent to which age norms are shared or not within the organization. The main reason for choosing a tech start up is because of the perceptions and beliefs surrounding technology company startups, especially when it comes to the profile of the workers within the organization. Additionally, Lawrence (2004) argues that age distributions will depend on the organization and their industries. Furthermore, as highlighted in the literature about training and performance of a certain age group, it will be

important to see how organizational age norms transcend in a real technology environment. This is because of the lack of research showing how age norms are formed in certain industries as highlighted earlier. As startups are generally still in the phase of creating and forming structures, this research intends to capture the processes that will later become a firm standard for the organization. This research will therefore seek to close the gaps in the formation and practical influence of age norms in organizations. The major contribution to literature will be to advance the current knowledge on age norms in organizations within a practical context especially the influence of the subject matter to management especially in a technology startup environment.

This project is divided into four chapters in addition to this Introduction. Chapter two, which is the literature review, will compile all the theoretical references used in shaping the research. This will consist of the concept and background of norms and how age norms are generally formed. Furthermore, chapter two will look at the systematic review carried out on literature on organizational age norms and reveal the findings associated with the review. Chapter three will outline the methodology used for the research. This chapter will focus on the choice of research methodology, data collection method, data analysis and the justification for choosing these approaches. Additionally, chapter three will highlight ethical considerations. Chapter four will focus on data analysis and the discussion with literature. Finally, chapter five will focus on final considerations while highlighting our contribution to both practical and theoretical aspects of the study, the limitations of our research and our recommendation for future research.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

This chapter looks at the concept of norms, social norms, age norms and then organizational age norms. To conduct a comprehensive examination of age norms within organizations, it was crucial to undertake a systematic review of the existing literature on this topic. This chapter also emphasizes the notion that age norms are influenced by social norms and can subsequently be surpassed within organizational contexts.

2.1 Norms and Social Norms

The word “norm” has a lot of meanings, most having to do with regularity and the appropriate action to be taken in groups (Paluck & Ball, 2010). There is a theory of social norms that has been developed by Bicchieri (2006). This theory has been drawn from socio-psychological and economic approaches. According to this theory, social norms are centered around conditional preferences, normative expectations and empirical expectations while also reviewing descriptive and injunctive norms according to Cialdini et al. (2007). Bicchieri (2006) substitutes the descriptive aspect of norms for her empirical expectation conditions while the injunctive is replaced by the normative expectations condition. This gives a clearer view that social norms are built from desires and beliefs of individuals in reference to their groups (Legros & Cislaghi, 2019). This means that individuals prefer to conform to social norms on empirical and normative expectations and as such explains the following: (1) a norm is a behavioral rule that exists and applies to some situations and (2) norms are followed by individuals in a group if they are convinced that a sufficient amount of people follow the norms and that these people believe that these rules should be followed.

According to Nichols (2002), norms are those rules that form a central part of our lives as they tell us how to behave. Norms have also been argued as being responsible for regulating social behavior (Hechter & Opp, 2005). They are cultural phenomena recommending and forbidding behaviour in specific circumstances (Hechter & Opp, 2005). Furthermore, Ensminger & Knight (1997, p.2) define norms as the “informal rules that structure behavior” while Rutherford (1996,

p.182) explain norms as the “regularity of behavior or a rule generally accepted by members of a social group which specifies behavior in specific situation”, which could be either self-policed or policed by external authority. Finally, “A norm is a social rule that does not depend on government for either promulgation or enforcement” (Posner & Rasmusen, 2000, p.369). From the vast range of the definitions of norms, one can see that these definitions come with variations and wordings that could be specific to the preference of study. The classification of norms into four dimensions by Homans (1950) has helped group the norms definitions into certain elements. According to Homans (1950) these dimensions are oughtness, conditional, generally accepted, and sanctioned prescriptions.

Oughtness: This means that norms are expectations on behaviors that ought to be or not to be. It is easy to see this oughtness in most of the definitions adapted by various authors.

Conditional: A lot of definitions of norms show that there is a certain expectation for individuals to behave in a particular way in certain circumstances. This raises the question of norms being conditional. A very good example of this will be the rule on not killing ‘you shall not kill’. There are however some certain circumstances that apply or do not apply to this rule. For examples, during war, soldiers are allowed to kill (Opp, 2001). Although Homans (1950) posits that norms refer to behavior and not necessarily to attitudes or beliefs which means that the behavior supersedes the attitude.

Generally accepted and sanctioned prescriptions: A norm is shared by a group of members which means that obeying the norm may trigger praise while going against the norm may come with some sort of sanction from the group.

The behavioral element of norm is also something that can be seen in most definitions. This argues that norms are surrounded by behavioral regularities and any behavior outside of the regularities will be sanctioned. One important aspect here is that according to Opp (2001), behavioral regularity could mean that people keep promises and if the promises are not kept

and they are sanctioned. The rule/condition is then a norm. Although Opp (2001) further argues that if a norm thus exists based on behavioral definitions, the element of oughtness according to Homans (1950) will not exist.

Social norms are what people in a group believe to be normal, this can be seen as a typical and appropriate action to certain conditions (Paluck & Ball, 2010). A lot of understandings and definitions of on social norms converge of the following elements as compiled by Mackie et al. (2014). These elements have also been backed up by Gibbs (1965), when he posits that norms include the following: 1) collective evaluations of behavior in terms of what should be. This means that a group evaluates a behavior and accepts what it should be in certain circumstances, 2) reactions to behavior which includes the attempt to sanction (positively or negatively) depending on if individuals follow the behavior or not, and 3) collective expectations on what behavior will be which takes us back to the collective evaluation and sanctioning. To highlight Gibbs (1965) To highlight these elements by Gibbs (1965), it is important to note that these are emphasized around social expectation, reference groups, and social influence. Social expectation is when a social norm is built around an individual's belief on what others in the group do. Furthermore, this belief is about what others think the individual should do. While reference groups can be the expectations that are held by group members regarding the other members. Finally, social influence is what maintains social norms to some level. This means approval (positive sanctions), disapproval (negative sanctions), or an individual's belief on the legitimacy of the norms.

It is important to differentiate social norms from other related and similar phenomena. According to Elster (1989), social norms are different from moral norms in the sense that moral norms come from utilitarian ethics and can be seen as consequentialist. A lot of times, individuals follow moral norms regardless of their beliefs regarding what others say or think should be done. More importantly, moral norms have rules which are held generally and violations of them could mean that there is a victim in the situation. In moral norms, we see a

lot of human rights, injustices, and harm to others. An important aspect to highlight is that moral norms violations are usually more serious than violations of social norms. Religious norms which could be a bit like moral norms have their distinction because of the divine connection or command. This Judeo-Christian foundation like the 10 commandments is a representation of norms (Hechter & Opp, 2005). Although they can function as social, legal, or even moral norms. This means that there are some aspects of religious norms that can be picked up by these other norms and enforced through the umbrellas of the various norms (Mackie et al., 2014). Similarly, social norms are also different from legal norms which are enforced by specialists as seen earlier. When we look at social norms, we see that the enforcement of these norms is done by members of a general community and not necessarily specialists like the legal norms. Legal norms are more formal and are ordered or directed by the state. The main difference is that while social norms are conserved by approval and disapprovals through sanctions; legal norms can be enforced by coercion (Posner & Rasmusen 2000; Mackie et al., 2014). Legal norms are created through designs, deliberative process and written specifically in texts while social norms are rather spontaneous, unwritten, and enforced informally (Hechter & Opp, 2005). Furthermore, social norms are not private norms as private norms are those rules imposed on self that enable them to get over the weaknesses of will (see Ainslie, 1986). These private norms are not subject to approval or disapproval by a group as they may not necessarily be shared with others (Elster, 1989). This can also be called personal norms or personal attitude (Mackie et al., 2014). Personal norm is therefore motivated internally and in no way has external motivation (i.e., from members of a group or specialists) (Mackie et al., 2014).

A major element of a social norm is that they are held in expectation among a group of people. This group of people are thus known as a reference group. They are the individuals that have mattered expectations to an individual in any situation. When it comes to abiding by social norms, an individual will give reference to the group (Legros and Cislaghi, 2019). This raises the question of if norms are also shared non-social beliefs. According to Mackie et al., (2014),

shared non-social beliefs can be learned from individuals and could be a situation of a one-way dependence which could go ahead changing one person at a time. For these beliefs to become social, they must go through the process of change whereby a wider group starts to follow in this belief. Once there are many believers in the reference group, they can then transition from a one-way dependence to a many-ways interdependence (Mackie et al., 2014).

According to Opp (2001), there are two concepts of the definition of norms which could potentially distinguish the definitions or concepts. The first is the definition surrounding oughtness which is the definition of Homans (1974) that specifies that norms are statements which stipulate how a person or people are and, their expected behavior in each situation. This definition also focuses on the expectation of people and their oughtness to do or not to take certain actions. In this definition, there are four main criteria used to define norms. These are the target, oughtness, expectation and behavior. For Opp (2001), the target criteria focus on the individuals or actors that have their behaviors regulated through this norm, while the oughtness criteria focuses on the expectation held by people (this could either be individual or collective depending on the situation and even type of norm). The expectation is the demand relating to the norm and then the behavior. Through this definition, Opp (2001) believes that norms could potentially refer to attitudes or beliefs and there is the assumption that norms hold only in given circumstances.

Another concept of the definition of norm is the existence of behavioral regularity and the probability of sanctions when the expected behavior is not executed (Rutherford, 1996). Although this definition can be linked more towards the economic aspects of institutions which according to Rutherford (1996) can be defined as a group of norms or norm (Opp, 2001). Thus, according to Opp (2001), a norm exists when there is the regularity of behavior and sanction, should there be deviation from the expected behavior. He also adds that other definitions of norms can have the combinations of these two concepts of the definition of norms.

2.2 The Origin of Norms

The fact that norms form a central part of human lives has made it an even bigger concern for research in different fields. Most times, in these fields, one would wonder where these norms come from or why these norms exist in the first place. According to Ruse and Wilson (1986) in research on evolutionary ethics, moral norms can be seen as evolutionary adaptations. When looking into most accounts on the origin of norms, there is a huge focus on moral norms with the attempt to explain the origin of them while relating to cultural pasts (Nichols, 2002). The only problem is that there could be enough different accounts of their origin, but these accounts cannot necessarily be classified as historical evidence as there are too many to decide from. Although, from the different variations of norms one can relate them to a certain origin. However, it is important to understand that one origin story applies to all cultures or groups as norms could be created for a reason in a culture and for a different reason in another culture (Nichols, 2002). So even if we put together in detail, a story of the norm origin; this could never be a generalized origin story.

Whilst the notion of a social norm is not only central, but socially fundamental, there is a diversification of views on what it really is. In the area of economics and perhaps more broadly, the rational choice tradition, there has been a likelihood to define 'social norm' as a behavioral regularity that is characterized by conditions (shared expectations) according to this conformity or regularity and the sanctions that support the regularity (Lahno, 2009). The issue, however, according to Lahno (2009), with this definition is that it misconstrues the essence of defining characteristics of norms. Behavioral regularities themselves do not make the concept of a norm, regardless of their existence in a group as influenced by social norms. Instead, priority is placed on the specific source of that regularity. Furthermore, the core of any social norm is in fact rooted in the social standard being that it is based on, and acts as a guide, when necessary, in individual behavior (Lahno, 2009). To explain this better, it is important to understand that standard in this definition means the prescriptive attribute of a norm and the

oughtness of something to be realized. When we mention a social standard, this means that it is adopted by and for every actor in a group and potentially shared by many individuals. Finally, when speaking of condition, it means that this norm prescribes behavior in a way that conditions apply when met or not (Lahno, 2009).

Social norms are founded on and rooted in social standards. There are two relevant standards. Compliance with social standards of evaluation can be seen as goal-oriented behavior limited by external and internal sanctions. Compliance with norms points at specific ways of conduct. Even though norm-guided behavior may correspond with maximizing utility, there is never enough norm compliance within a rational choice framework, or any other framework entirely set on instrumental rationality (Lahno, 2009). One might ask why people adhere to social norms. As with methodological individualism, one is inclined to shed some light on individual behavior by ascertaining the motivating factors responsible people typically deal with. Contextually, sanctions, especially social sanctions, might appear to play a decisive role (Elster, 1989; Scott, 2000) Nonetheless, sometimes norm compliance in the absence of external sanctions, can be effective. Internal sanctions on the other hand perhaps suggest a way out of the problem. It might appear that the idea of 'internal sanctions' elucidates a credible account of the 'internalization of norms', thereby presenting a better appreciation of norm-guided behavior as it concerns behaviors which are goal-oriented (Lahno, 2009).

When we look at the emergence of norms, literature within the social sciences has many different propositions that are unrelated to each other. Most times, these propositions have their differences in the terminologies used and propose different orientations (Opp, 2001). However, one common proposition seen is the instrumentality proposition which states that norms are derived once they could be instrumental to the goal attainment of certain actors. In this proposition, there is the argument that norms are planned and on the other part, the aim is not to create a general norm however to provide some goods when it comes to situations of interaction (the evolutional emergence of norms) (Opp, 2001). For example, according to Opp

(2001), smokers can support non-smokers so as not to exposed to the desire to smoke (situational), however on the other hand, non-smokers may not want to propagate a non-smoking norm (not to create a general norm). Although the accumulated effect of this is the creation of a general norm. This idea, which is the instrumentality proposition argues that norms have their origin in the interest of a group of people (Ellickson, 1989). This group interest means that if there is not any interest taken as a collective, the norms do not exist. So, for example, how to solve money problems – if a group is not interested in solving their money problems, there would not be norms around reckless spending of money. Therefore, norms play a very instrumental role (Opp, 2001).

2.3 The Instrumentality Proposition of Norms

As previously mentioned, the instrumentality proposition of norms states that norms are most likely to be created if they are instrumental towards an actor's goals. This means that if norms could emerge if they are able to satisfy the needs of individuals. In this sense, a lot of research has also focused on the idea of emerging norms and how they could be efficient when meeting individual goals. When norms emerge, there is an assumption that some external factors are involved. Such externalities could be the actions of the individuals in relation to the costs or benefits associated with the norms. Costs in this sense would have a negative impact while benefit is tending towards positive impact. When there is a negative external factor, actors would usually be interested in creating norms that reduce or eliminate this external factor. On the other hand, should there be positive externalities, the interest in norm establishment or permanency will be increased. Although this is not directly linked to this research, Hechter (1987) links some theories that address the production of public good to the instrumentality proposition. According to him, certain groups are in existence for the supply of desired joint goods to members. These goods can only be gotten if members of the group comply with certain rules that guarantee the production of the goods. In this case, the surrounding norms

are instrumental to achieving the goals of the group which would be to get certain goods. This can also be linked to wealth/welfare maximization by Ellickson (1991). Similarly, when looking at institutional theories, we can see that norms are a huge part of institutions which are helpful when trying to solve problems or distribute and utilize resources (Ostrom, 2014).

Apart from economics, this proposition is also seen in sociology. According to Fine (2001), there are sociological norms restricting members from doing certain things. For example, mushroom collectors have norms restraining members from picking the same mushroom a collector has picked. The notion of 'first come, first served' is largely applied here and members of the group are very interested in building good interpersonal relationships which help in managing the competition in the industry. Other literatures can also attest to the instrumentality proposition (see Williams, 1968; Summer, 1906). According to Opp (2001), there are however two variants of this instrumentality proposition. The functionalist version and the individual version. Although he mentions that the functionalist version is relatively outdated; it is still used in a modified way. The functionalist version posits that if a norm that is not yet in existence is functional in terms of already establishing equilibrium in a social system; it will emerge at some point. Therefore, a norm has a huge part to play in the survival or equilibrium of a social system. This approach can also be called a classical functionalist proposition where the macro element is more evident. Additionally, this classical functionalist proposition will argue that even if the needs of the social system are not met at some point and a norm would have the effect the system needs, the norm will still nevertheless emerge. One major drawback with this approach is the fact that this proposition majorly talks about a norm that is non-existent but then the effect that this non-existent norm would have, if it existed. The mystery here is explaining how something that is inexistent causes its own materialization (Opp, 2001). A lot of approaches argue that norms exist because of their efficiency in solving problems of a group or actors however, a functionalist approach will counter this; arguing that inexistent norms have some attributes that cause or lead to their existence. This means that actors will work on creating norms that are deemed instrumental

to the achievement of certain goals or outcomes. A difference between the proposition of instrumentality and a functionalist view is that from a functionalist approach, norms would emerge if there were some sort of contribution to the survival, balance, or stability to a social system. However, this argument, according to Opp (2001) is flawed as it is impossible to explain something's existence by the effect they have if they existed. The individualist version states that any situation that threatens the realization of individual goals are the elements providing the motivation to create rules or norms with the intention of making the group (members) better. Therefore, there is this held view that the existence or emergence of norms is triggered by externalities which when they occur; have negative influences or on the other hand provide positive benefits to the members. When it comes to the negative influences, the idea for norm emergence will be to reduce such externalities and on the other hand, a positive one will be to maintain or compensate these positive externalities (Demsetz, 1967). The instrumentality proposition also argues that since groups exist for the beneficial good of members, this can only be accomplished if members follow the rules designed for these benefits (Hechter, 1987). Therefore, one can argue that norms play an instrumental part in achieving group goals (Opp, 2001). Furthermore, according to this theory, norms emerge to satisfy the demands and moderate negative externalities and of course promote the positive ones (Hechter & Opp, 2005). On the other hand, this norm has drawn a lot of criticism from Rawls (1971), Elster (1989) and others. They argue that this theory is sometimes too rosy and other times too bloodless. They argue it is too rosy because of the failure to predict the future of harmful norms such as feud, duel, and vendetta. On the other side, too bloodless because it ignores the emotional foundation that gives norms the exceptional regulatory power that critics argue norms have.

When a sociologist explains the concept of norms, there is usually the idea of socialization and the fact that norms are transmitted either spontaneously or planned (Boyd & Richerson, 1985). When looking at this proposition of socialization, we can see that an aspect this does not address is the conditions that people transmit these norms. Irrespective of the conditions

at which norms are transmitted, sociologists tend to argue that this is not a concise instrumentality of a norm for the groups that transmit these norms and as such; it can be suggested that norms could be dysfunctional but still spread (Merton, 1968). In this case, when one looks at how parents socialize their children, it can be assumed that this socialization is driven by the incentives to teach the children good manners which could be because they care about the children's good manners; or they want to be perceived as good parents. This incentive according to Opp (2001) could lead to a norm on the macro level. When comparing this proposition with a cultural approach, it will be obvious that there are some inconsistencies especially with symbolic interactionalism (Hall & Taylor, 1996). There is the argument that a cultural approach to norms does not rebut that member are goal oriented, rational, or even purposive. Instead, they argue that individual goals are much broader and focused only on material wellbeing; but they posit that individuals seek to express their identity in ways that are socially appropriate and accepted (Hall & Taylor, 1996).

2.4 The Importance and Efficiency of Norms

When looking at literature concerned with the emergence of norms, there is a general assumption that the creation of norms is based on needs or the advantages and disadvantages that actors have in common. This approach is somewhat based on rational choice by actors (Opp, 2001) which could be linked to interpretive and cultural sociology, which are potentially not so different from each other (Fine, 2001). According to Bates et al. (1998) and Rambo (1999), the approaches are not opposing but on the other hand balancing of each other (Opp, 2001). Unlike the sociologists' view of norms as not the product of "diffuse social forces," a norm rather projects an aforethought or purposive actions of discrete persons, particularly regarding individuals who are qualified to provide the new rule or those who want it adopted (Ellickson, 2001)

These new norms, however different in many ways, do share the same conception and methodological approach. Further identifying social norms as rules responsible for a person's behavior which is affected by third parties (excluding state agents) using social sanctions and violation of norms results in persons involved being the target of ensuing punishments like societal ostracism and bad gossip. As a result, the benefits of upholding these norms, albeit informal, range from greater esteem to better weighted opportunities for all parties involved (Ellickson, 2001). Individuals are prone to self-destruct with guilt as an after effect of internalizing a norm, which happens when they violate it, or 'pat their own backs' with pride when they uphold the most burdensome ones. It is worthy of note that norms will still exist even if not one person decides to internalize them as long as third parties fuel their enforcement informally. This view is also closely associated with Hobbes (apud Ellickson, 2001) when he argues that people are inept in coordinating with one another if there is no significant coercive assistance from authority.

When a norm comes into existence, one starts to wonder what effects these norms have on people's actions. Since rational action is only concerned with outcomes, social norms by their feature are not outcome oriented (Elster, 1989). Furthermore, Elster (1989) states that the simplest norms are the ones that advise to do something or not to do something, while the more complex ones have some conditions attached to them. Therefore, in the case of norms, rationality is important and is conditional and future oriented. An important part Elster (1989) brings here is that, for norms to be classified as social, they must be shared by others and fueled by people's approval or disapproval. This sustainability can also be through the feelings of embarrassment, anxiety, shame, and guilt. Norms in this case can also be seen as a mechanism for motivation, which means that this rational aspect of it cannot be denied, although some actions can be norm guided. Another importance of norms according to Elster (1989) is how they can be implored to justify self-interest which means that norms can be easily manipulated. For example, conditional norms can be easily manipulated to suit

someone's interest. Although this norm can also be compelled by the need of the action or sometimes the need for consistency in one's actions (Elster, 1989).

According to role theory, norms are organized based on the roles that the individuals take. For example, parental roles mean that parents must teach their children good manners. This theory posits that individuals must act according to the roles they take on (Biddle & Thomas, 1966). Opp (2001) argues that this proposition is quite problematic as behaviors that cannot be regulated are not able to be explained. Another reason for being seen as problematic is that people often stray from role expectations. The third problem is that role expectations, when in conflict, do not give an inclination for the expectation to be heeded. The major orientation this theory gives is that individuals are socialized into their roles and must follow them (Opp, 2001).

For norms to have taken so much interest in various research ranging from areas to areas, this phenomenon must have some sort of importance or effectiveness. It is however important to reemphasize that norm could bring about either positive or negative sanctions. According to Posner and Rasmusen (2000), the violation of norms can be classified as automatic, shame, guilt, informational, bilateral costly and multilateral costly. The sanctions are therefore related to the problems that creating or modifying norms bring about. Norms could either overlap laws or be independent of them. For example, while there could be norms against stealing, there are laws also against this sort of behavior. Norms are efficient and an attractive social control method. This is because rules may be necessary but too expensive for the state to assume when relating it to the benefit although some norms are more of a public good than laws (Posner & Rasmusen, 2000).

2.5 Sanctions of Norms

Automatic sanctions: Here, the action of the violator carries its own penalty as it is not coordinated with the actions of other individuals. For example, someone driving on the wrong side of the road and maybe crashes into other cars.

Shame: The violator in this case feels bad about his action that leads to a violation. Here from the action, the violator has a sense that such action has lessened himself/herself either. Sometimes this feeling could be for oneself or there is the action that others feel that way about the individual. An important aspect here is that even if this violation is not seen by others, the violator may still feel ashamed and there is a sinking feeling of knowing that others may discover or not discover the act.

Guilt: Almost like shame, the violator feels bad about the action. The prompt of feeling bad would be because of up brining or education. The thing here is, guilt does not necessarily come from external influences but from internal vices. For example, someone may feel guilty for stealing even though the individual is very certain that they will never get caught.

Informational: The action of the violator carries information about them that they would prefer others not knowing about. For example, dressing inappropriately to an interview may carry some information that the individual is not interested in the job.

Bilateral costly sanctions: In this case, the punishment for the violator comes from just one other person that is specifically linked to the norm that has been violated. For example, an adulterer is shot by the spouse of the partner or, a cheating husband is divorced by his wife or vice versa.

Multilateral costly sanctions: Very similar to bilateral costly sanctions, the violation affects many others, and punishment is not from just one other specific individual but more. For example, not being invited to hang out with a group of friends because of a divorce.

One norm violation can nonetheless be enforced by all these sanctions and these sanctions have reward equivalences for being followed. Rewards for norms can be in the sense of the feeling of a duty well done, signaling of desirable quantities, material gratitude (from one person or more), automatic coordinated interaction gain or good opinion of others (Posner & Rasmusen, 2000). At this point, it is important to note that a norm is a public good even though there are some exceptions to this especially when we go back to the types of norms as earlier mentioned. For norms to emerge, more people must use them although one cannot be excluded from a norm if they do not form part of the group that created them. Once a norm has been established, it is quite hard for it to be changed, (Posner & Rasmusen, 2000) however this does not mean that norms cannot be changed. When creating a norm, there is the need for endorsement and publicizing this norm. This is the same for when a norm is eliminated or changed. There must be an announcement or one way to publicize this. The thing about eliminating norms is that apart from the announcement it takes, there must be the annihilation of the expectations that the norm creates. When changing a norm, one must consider that destroying and creating a norm are very tricky aspects. How fast a norm changes depends on the value attached to it and nevertheless must be done gradually and without any centralized directions (Posner & Rasmusen, 2000). One way to change a norm according to Mackie et al., (2014) is to show that a harmful norm is offset by a different norm or series of various norms. Another is to show that an action that was perceived to be related to a norm is no longer linked to that norm. For example, foot-binding in China (Posner & Rasmusen, 2000). This is a social norm that means that a girl is fit for marriage and has achieved a certain level of building. This act breaks and tightly binds the feet of women to take some certain shape. More interestingly, there are a lot of social norms that are age related and can be seen in our everyday lives.

2.6 Age Norms

There is the existence of some timetables that determine some major life events. For example, when are men and women expected to marry, raise kids, and retire from work? This pattern is followed quite often by members of society and most times they fail to see that a lot of life occurrences and events are influenced by other life contingencies (Bernice et al., 1965). A lot of times there are not just age norms but age expectations which reflects on how people describe some certain events in their lives (Bernice et al., 1965). Some of these descriptions could be 'late, on time or even early'. For example, we can hear people say that an individual started childbearing late. This is because there is some sort of expectation that once an individual gets married, childbearing is usually the next and right after. Sometimes, one can hear phrases like being too old to work hard or being too young to go out. The normative timetable for age could however differ depending on status, region and even gender (Poppel & Nelissen, 1999). These norms surrounding age are either implicit or explicit and they are sustained and reinforced by sanctions. When someone marks the journey into becoming an adult, there are many things that change for the individual like their status and participation in the adult world (Poppel & Nelissen, 1999). These participations could be marriage, a full-time job, parenthood or even retirement. Before World War II, marriage was the steppingstone from youthfulness into adulthood (Modell et al., 1976). From historical research, it is noted that age plays numerous important roles in life. Apart from being a marker for chronological individual life, it also is a reference for significant biological events like puberty, childbearing, and even physical dependence. Furthermore, it shows the roles and statuses of individuals within a social system create demographic effects which influence the group, in terms of economic well-being, job opportunities and within organizations (Lawrence, 1996b).

Age is an individual attribute that influences behavior across all cultures that have been studied. This ranges from the way age is seen to play crucial roles, the behaviors surrounding age, duties, rights and even rewards that are distributed based on age groups (see Linton,

1936; Eisenstadt, 1956; Neugarten, 1968). To understand how this is deeply rooted in a social system, Neugarten et al (1968) found out that societies define the appropriate age norms such as “the best age to marry” and “attain some life accomplishments”. For example, from their research, it was seen that 80% of men and 90% of men feel that the best age for a man to be married is between 20 and 25 while for women will be between 19 and 24 years. Additionally, for life accomplishment, it is felt that men accomplish the most around the ages of 40 and 50, while women will be between the ages of 30 and 45 (Neugarten et al., 1965).

Age norms are a form of social norms which means that their characteristics are very similar to the social norms or any general norm. This also will suggest that age norms have the major components of norms such as the expectation, sanction, and group. Before diving into this, it is important to note that as seen with norms, age norms can also be defined as the shared judgement regarding the ages of individuals when it comes to a role or status in a particular context (Lawrence, 1988). When these judgements are shared, they become very influential in behavior and impact the everyday life of individuals (Eisenstadt, 1965; Riley et al., 1972).

2.7 Age Norms in Organization or Organizational Age Norms

In an organizational context, age norms can bring about stereotypes especially when it comes to the beliefs regarding the age of certain individuals. This could then become normalized or taken for granted, especially how individuals are managed or self-managed. As a result, leading to these individuals, and understanding the implications their age has in the work context or environment (Vickerstaff & Van der Horst, 2021).

According to Gibbs (1965), although there are many conceptions relating to norms, a lot of them including age norms will most likely comprise of expectation, sanction, and group. When it comes to expectation, age norms can be seen as what people ought to do or what seems to be appropriate or ideal for individuals in a particular age range (Neugarten et al., 1965).

With the component of sanction, individuals that violate their age-related norm could be punished one way or the other which could include mocking remarks within the organization (Lawrence, 1996a). Although, sanctions could either be positive or negative. For example, in an organization, a manager that is perceived as way ahead in their career schedule may receive higher performance evaluations than others. Those 'behind' their schedules could be punished with low performance rating which could potentially affect their employment life cycle (Lawrence, 1996a). Even outside of an organization, a younger individual achieving things 'really' fast is awarded with high status within the community unlike older people that 'take their time' to achieve things. Although it is vital to note that these outcomes may also differ in culture, the issue here is the fact that age norms violation will generate either negative or positive sanctions. (Lawrence, 1996a). The group component, which is the third, also signifies that there are certain members that are aware of the norm that believe in the expectation attached to the norm and carry out the sanctions.

A major issue of age norms based on the expectations component is that there is the assumption that individuals are aware of these expectations and if they are summoned, they can tell the certain behaviors that are expected of them at a given age. However, Lawrence (1996a) posits that many individuals are relatively unaware of the expectations surrounding their age and carry some level of subconsciousness on them. If this should be the case, it is easily argued that these expectations are not shared as per initially claimed. When relating to organizations, some studies have shown that some employers are unaware of the age aspect when evaluating applications and sometimes, they claim that age is quite an unimportant aspect of application screening (see Rosen & Jerdee 1976, 1977).

The thing about age norms is the fact that there could be different age norms in interdependent social spheres or systems. For example, a work environment could hold a certain age norm, while an ethnic group is holding another while the community holds one, then the country or nation as a whole holds another. An issue here could be the fact that these norms may have

a collusion when bringing them together or trying to compare them to know which to comply with in the organization (Lawrence, 1996a). For example, a scientist mentioned that to his community he was seen as slightly behind when it came to certain criteria and as such, while very successful at work, his friends and family were not so impressed with some other accomplishments. This gave room for conflicting ideas. Although there are some age norm expectations that go with an individual's biological advancement, some do not have anything to do with physical attributes or chronological ages but instead more on behavior (Lawrence, 1987).

To study age norms in organizations, we need to understand that there are theoretical and empirical approaches due to the variables present in the phenomena. For example, if age norms are defined as the view on standards for a given age in terms of role and status (Lawrence, 1996a); this means that we need to put into consideration that people will have judgements on what these behaviors should be in the organization. Thus, studies will be looking at social aspects with the aim of capturing the way a social system is viewed by members (Lawrence, 1996a). The idea of studying age norms will thus follow majorly on the definition that is chosen and the core elements in this definition. Furthermore, when looking at organizations and the roles, power and status related to the structure, it is important to note that the ages of people within this structure will change even though the role, power and status of that organization does not. An idea for research will be to understand how these changes could potentially violate the expectations relating to the role, power, and status (Lawrence, 1996b). A good example will be reactions when being interviewed by a 12-year-old to an organization or an 80-year-old coming up with startup ideas. When we think of this, we can figure out that scenarios like this dealing with age play a huge part in human interaction, and that the role that age plays is most times predetermined when it comes to outcomes.

2.8 Systematic Review on Age Norms in Organizations

According to Dempster (2011), a systematic review is the comprehensive review of all literature (traditional and non-traditional) to reconcile them as evidence. This systematic review carried out on age norms in organizations aims to review the current literature in the subject area and report on what the potential gaps in literature could lead to further research in the subject area. To review the literature on the subject matter, different searches must be done within many databases or journals. In this case, Scopus (Elsevier), Web of Science (Clarivate), ProQuest and unconventionally google scholar were used. The reason for the varying database is because there was limited number of literatures in the subject matter found in these databases. Although, initial search on google scholar brought about lots of literature in the area, there had to be a deeper dive into finding what journals or databases these literatures were in.

The Scopus and Web of Science databases catalogue a wide range of content using tools that help with precise search and analytics that provide detailed insights into the searches done. As one of the largest databases for reviewed literature, it also comes with content on conference proceedings, books, and magazines. Furthermore, there is a comprehensive field of subjects that can be found within these databases. With ProQuest, there is the option of choosing dissertations or theses, which was also very important for this literature review. The filter options are also helpful in ensuring that time is not spent on irrelevant articles to the subject area.

2.8.1 Data Collection

In collecting the data for this study, keywords were easy and pre-defined as “Age Norms” AND “organi*ation”. The use of “*” is because “organization” can also be spelt as “organisation” especially among British scholars. The “*” covers every word that would be in the place it has been placed. This way, we were sure of not losing out on any works that would have had a

different spelling. Additionally, the use of “AND” was to make sure that we captured everything that had to do with organizations. Although, we noticed some of the research had organizations in them and were not necessarily related. One thing we tried initially had these key words searched within the titles. This did not yield any results from WoS, Scopus and ProQuest. We then had to initiate a new search with the keywords to be searched in the entire document which brought about many results that needed to be filtered. From this stage, it was obvious that age norms can be found in any field or subject. Age norms are found in sociology, psychology, and medicine. Using these keywords and search criteria, data was collected and compiled from these databases. At the end of the search, a funnel of relevant articles was created using an excel sheet showing author names, article title, abstract, document type, journal, and year of publication. It is important to note that most of these documents were duplicated in different databases hence the idea to form a funnel. At the end of the search, 21 articles were deemed very important to this study.

2.8.2 Search String by Base

Table 1 shows the databases used and the search string. There were a lot of excluding criteria.

Table 1

Search String by Base

Database	Search String
Scopus	(ALL ("Age Norms") AND TITLE-ABS-KEY (organization)) AND (EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "MEDI") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "NEUR") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "NURS") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "DECI") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "BIOC") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "ENVI") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "AGRI") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "ENGI") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "IMMU") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "PHAR") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "EART") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "PHYS")) AND (EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "PSYC") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "ARTS") OR EXCLUDE (SUBJAREA , "ECON")) AND (EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Comparative Population Studies") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Demographic Research") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "International Journal Of Lifelong Education") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Journal Of Global Mobility") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Leisure Studies") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Loisir Et Societe") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Nonprofit And Voluntary Sector Quarterly") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Palgrave Handbook Of Volunteering Civic Participation And Nonprofit Associations") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE ,

	"Proceedings Of The National Academy Of Sciences Of The United States Of America") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Research In Social Stratification And Mobility") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Risk Power And The State After Foucault") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Royal Society Open Science") OR EXCLUDE (EXACTSRCTITLE , "Societies"))
Web of Science	"age norms" (All Fields) and Organization (All Fields) or Organisation (All Fields) and "age norms" (All Fields) Refined By: NOT Web of Science Categories: Pediatrics or Medicine General Internal or Ophthalmology or Family Studies NOT Web of Science Categories: Psychology Experimental
Proquest	age OR employment OR older people OR aging OR older workers OR careers OR employees OR behavior OR entrepreneurs OR retirement OR entrepreneurship OR norms OR attitudes OR organizational behavior OR age discrimination OR employers □ NOT (Evidence Based Healthcare AND Commentary AND Statistics/Data Report AND Editorial AND Review AND Case Study AND Front Page/Cover Story AND General Information AND News AND Report) □ □ NOT (Journal of Physical Education and Sport AND Demographic Research AND International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health AND European Journal of Population AND Frontiers in Human Neuroscience AND International Journal of Manpower AND Nordic Journal of Working Life Studies AND BioMed Research International AND BMC Psychiatry AND BMC Public Health AND Brain Sciences AND De Economist AND Frontiers in Aging Neuroscience AND Journal of International Migration and Integration AND Personnel Review AND Social Indicators Research AND The Journal of Personal Selling & Sales Management AND The Scientific World Journal AND African Vision and Eye Health AND Annual Review of Sociology AND Autism Research and Treatment AND Catalyst : Feminism, Theory, Technoscience AND Clinical Ophthalmology AND Comparative Population Studies AND Conflict and Health AND Corporate Governance AND Corvinus Journal of Sociology and Social Policy AND Ekonomicky Casopis AND Ekonomika Regiona = Economy of Regions AND eLife AND Indian Journal of Commerce and Management Studies AND Institute of Transportation Engineers. ITE Journal AND International Entrepreneurship and Management Journal AND International Journal for Equity in Health AND International Journal of Contemporary Hospitality Management AND International Journal of Emerging Markets AND International Journal of Entrepreneurship AND International Journal of Organizational Innovation (Online) AND International Journal of Society, Culture & Language AND Irish Journal of Management AND JMIR mHealth and uHealth AND Journal of Applied Psychology AND Journal of Enterprising Communities AND Journal of Entrepreneurship Education AND Journal of European Industrial Training AND Journal of Gambling Studies (Online) AND Journal of Housing and the Built Environment AND Journal of Innovation and Entrepreneurship AND Journal of Knowledge Management AND Journal of Medical Internet Research AND Journal of Social Policy AND Labour AND North American Journal of Psychology AND Personnel Psychology AND Professional Safety)

Source: Search string from search in databases.

2.8.3 Research Database

Web of Science: The web of science search was a relatively easy one as the first search keywords of “age norms” AND “organization” only yielded 24 documents. Documents came from subject areas like ophthalmology, family studies, medicine, pediatrics, and others including business and organizations. Upon filtering with both inclusion and exclusion criteria,

we got 18 relevant documents. Looking at these documents, 14 were classified under articles, two as editorial materials and two as proceedings papers. The publication year for the documents were also between 1996 – 2021.

Scopus: The Scopus database had more exclusion criteria to take into consideration. Just like the web of science base, we had documents ranging in different subject areas like those in the web of science base. Publication year was from 1997 – 2021 and initial search brought about 197 documents. After carefully filtering the data, there were 31 ‘relevant’ documents for the search. Of them, there were 22 classified under articles, three on books, three on chapter and three on review. All these documents were downloaded to proceed with the manual review. It is important to note that this manual review was important and possible due to the limited number of documents we were getting for the searches. These numbers were what prompted the search into other databases.

ProQuest: Source type were conference papers & proceedings, dissertation and theses, scholarly journals, working papers. The language and location filters were left open to see what other age norms in organizational articles that could be found. Initial search brought about 3,734 results but these included articles under subjects like developmental psychology, psychotherapy, clinical psychology, and other ones that would not have been relevant to this study. Excluding these irrelevant subjects to the study, articles in norms, labor relations, attitudes, careers, behavior, organizational behavior, management, and employees were included. It is however important to note that the classifications per subject on ProQuest are probably random words that have been put together. After taking these out, the search results brought about 403 articles which included both peer reviewed and full text articles. Filters by document type were carried out and the still included dissertation/thesis, feature, commentary, editorial, articles, conference proceeding and so on. Having a quick scan through these documents, commentary documents, editorials, conference proceedings, reports and others that were not relevant to the search were excluded. This exclusion brought about 342

documents in total with dissertation and thesis having 340 documents. Limiting the search to only peer reviewed and looking through the publication journals, our final filter brought about 58 journals which were manually looked at to be either discarded or added as part of the funnel for this research. The same search on ProQuest's database for just dissertation and thesis and came up with 70 thesis documents (with Management as our inclusion criteria). As there were not many extra filters to be used, going through the documents manually had to be done to filter the ones that were deemed irrelevant. The relevant documents were added to the table also.

2.8.4 Streamlining the Funnel

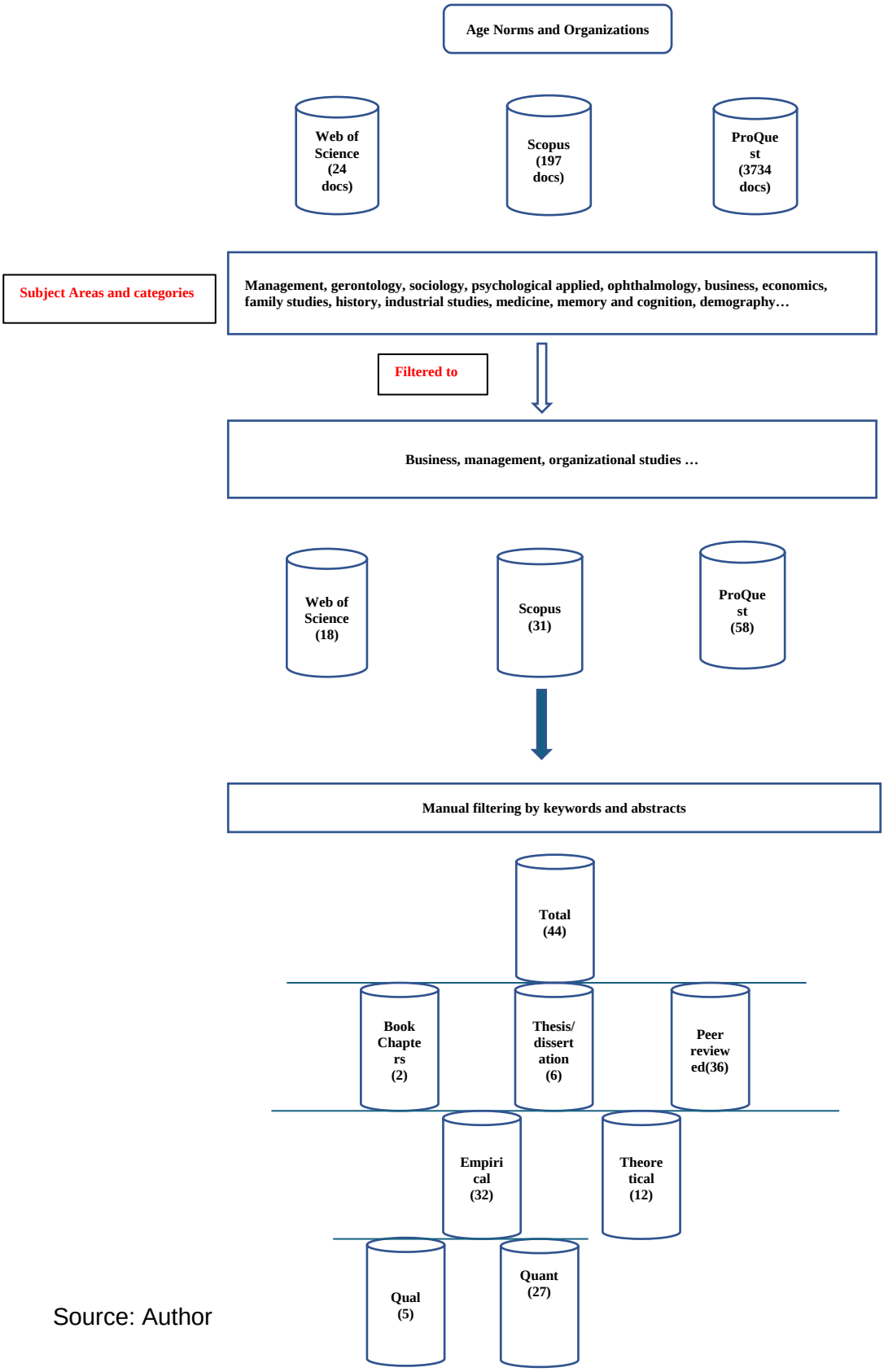
We initially had 44 articles and automatically took out some of them. All articles were also exported to an excel sheet to include the names of the authors, title of articles, journals of publication, abstract, year of publication, DOI and other minor extracts that we did not make use of. On the initial look at the abstracts, it was easy to tell if most of them were theoretical or empirical; and, to determine the ones that were carried out using quantitative or qualitative methods. After this selection, a proper literature review was carried out with the relevant documents (see below). From the initial review, we found 6 of them to be dissertations or theses. This is worth noting that these documents were got from the ProQuest base, and we left them, although not peer reviewed, but would count as part of what is needed for this systematic and bibliometric review. All six dissertations or theses were empirical studies carried out using quantitative methods. Additionally, we had two books or rather chapters from books; and we decided to keep them because the authors of these chapters are well-known authors in the subject area with also good contributions to what our research is currently on. The peer reviewed documents were a total of 36 and when we added them, we could highlight 32 empirical and 12 theoretical. We also got the chance to divide the empirical studies into quantitative or qualitative and with this, we noticed that most studies done so far have been majorly empirical with quantitative methods. We saw a lot of data samplings and surveys and

on the qualitative hand; we found observations and some interviews. Data analysis for these studies included factorial analysis, pooled regression, logistics regression, rhetorical and sequential analysis and so much more. After downloading all articles and reading them more carefully, we decided to take most of them out and ended with 21 relevant articles. The reasons for this varied from them not being peer reviewed, research on age norms part of a social norm and not necessarily within organizations, total irrelevance to the subject of interest, and most having to be duplicates of others encountered.

Figure 1 shows the search funnel with key words used. At the end of the search, relevant literature was divided into empirical or theoretical.

Figure 1

Organizational Age Norms Funnel



Source: Author

2.9. Literature Review Categories

In this part, we present the results from the systematic review carried out on age norms in organizations. The literature around age norms were grouped into four categories.

a) The concept of age norms in organizations: This category shows the main definitions and concepts around age norms in organizations. Additionally, this category also demonstrates major elements of age norms such as the violations and sanctions when age norms expectations are not met; and some organizational policies or procedures that could influence age norms.

b) The beliefs around the expectations of age norms, judgements, and behavior: This category demonstrates the beliefs, judgements and behaviour of individuals and organizations about age norms. From this category, one can determine whether age norms are shared beliefs or not.

c) Retirement: This category shows the relationship between organizational age norms and the intention to retire.

d) Recruitment and Retention: This category outlines the relationship between organizational age norms and recruitment, while also showing the relationship between organizational age norms and retention of workers.

Category 1: Age Norms Context and Definitions

Table 2 shows the categorization of the literature found to be within the context of age norms and their definitions. From this, one can see that there are a few research in this area. The most recent research carried out relating to age norms in organization was in 2020 and this research talks only about the context of age norms and relating it to ageism in a Brazilian context.

Table 2

Age Norms Context and Definitions

Year	Author (s)	Title	Journal and Location	Type of article (Conceptual or empirical)
1996	Barbara Lawrence	Interest and Indifference: The role of age in the organizational sciences	Personnel and Human Resource Management, USA	Conceptual
1988	Barbara Lawrence	New Wrinkles in a Theory of Age: Demography, Norms, and Performance Ratings	The Academy of Management Journal, USA	Conceptual
2004	Barbara Lawrence	How old you are may depend on where you work	AJS, book, USA	Conceptual
2006	Martin M. Greller, Sandra B. Richtermeyer	Changes in social support for professional development and retirement preparation as a function of age.	Human Relations, USA	Empirical
2007	Dorien Kooij, Annet de Lange, Paul Jansen, Josje Dikkers	Older workers' motivation to continue to work: five meanings of age: A conceptual review.	Journal of Managerial Psychology, The Netherlands	Conceptual
2011	Sanghamitra Chaudhuri, Rajashi Ghosh	Reverse Mentoring: A Social Exchange Tool for Keeping the Boomers Engaged and Millennials Committed	Human Resources Development Review, USA	Conceptual
2013	Guido Hertel, Beatrice van de Heijden, Annet De lange, Jurgen Deller	Facilitating age diversity in organizations - part II: Managing perceptions and interactions	Journal of Managerial Psychology, Germany	Conceptual
2019	Jelle Lossbroek, Bram Lancee, T.van der Lippe, J J Schippers	Understanding old age adaptation policies in Europe: the influence of profit, principles, and pressures	Ageing and Society, The Netherlands	Empirical
2020	Darcy M Hanashiro, Marie Pereira	Ageism at the Workplace: Evidence of Sanitation Practices of Older Workers	Revista Gestão Organizacional (Journal of Organizational Management), Brazil	Empirical

Source: Elaborate by the author, based on research databases

The General Concept

In all communities and societies, age has been shown to be the base for ascribing status and as a source of regulation for social interaction (Neugarten et al, 1965; Settersten & Mayer, 1997). Sociologists, anthropologists, and other scholars have studied age in different realms.

Some have looked at how it is graded in societies, relationships between age and generations, age, and other elements of adulthood and so on. However, what has not thoroughly or necessarily been looked at and raised by Neugarten et al., (1965) is the relationship between age, complex societies and what is deemed as age-appropriate behavior. Although this element becomes the basis of most research relating to age norms today, it is important to note that most theoretical papers that have appeared in the last twenty or more years are now referred to as classics and unfortunately not much has been done to develop this aspect of the sociology of age (Neugarten et al., 1965).

The role age plays in the corporate environment is one that depends more on the beliefs people have concerning them than the idea of age itself (Lawrence, 1988). Most times, when we compare people's ages and their significance to some aspects in their lives, it is done with an insignificant intention. In organizations, workers try to compare, assess, and observe the age of others to see where they are in their own careers or potentially make forecast for their career advancement or future within the organization (Kidder, 1981). These sorts of reactions and responses gotten from this assessment play a huge role in organizations such as hiring decisions, opportunities of internal growth and even hiring and firing decisions (Dalton & Thompson, 1971). Age being a relevant aspect of social and cultural dimensions gives proper room for reproduction in an informal form which brings about the expectations that will govern the behaviors associated (Settersten & Mayer, 1997). Thus, age norms are defined as the "prescriptions or proscriptions about behavior in the form of "should" and "should not"; they are supported by consensus; and are enforced through various mechanisms of social control, particularly social sanctions-positive, to keep people "on track," and negative, to bring straying individuals "back into line"" (Settersten & Mayer, 1997, p.242). Additionally, Lawrence (2004, p.991) define age norms as the 'widely shared judgments of the standard or typical ages of individuals holding a role or statuses. Moreover, age norms in organizations have also been defined by Krueger et al., (1995) as the shared assumptions regarding the milestones to be achieved relating to age, especially regarding the individual's career progress.

Although there is much research to support this definition, Lawrence (2004) mentions that age norms have huge influence in organizations and their workers in various ways. Age norms can create stereotypical images about what age is more suitable for certain roles in different organizational settings (Chaudhuri & Ghosh, 2011). Although age norms vary as mentioned previously, they may be likely to occur because of training (some roles require more training), appeal to a certain generation (e.g., programming jobs appeal more to the younger generation), stability (finance is an area that requires stability) (Chaudhuri & Ghosh, 2011). Although, it is not to say that companies in the same industry will have the same age distributions. Lawrence (2004) additionally posits that any event can be linked to someone's age whether directly or indirectly. The link could also happen within organizations where the company's age distribution could influence some strategic human resource planning and potentially the success of this business. As organizations require having the right people in the right places and at the right time, we start to question if this requirement has to do with the age of these people in the right places and at the right time. Although one can say that organizational success is related to the business planning and the resources out in place, Lawrence (2004) and many others argue that the diversity of people in terms of their age can be seen distinctively in their commitments, expectations, needs and even values.

Age means differently to various people and in occupations, organizations, and industries. Here, there are two things in play, how people view ages in various occupations and age distributions within these industries (Lawrence, 1988; Lawrence, 2004). For example, middle aged people can be seen in different ways in different career paths. A middle-aged Hollywood scriptwriter will be termed as 'over the hill' while on the other hand, the same middle-aged person as a proposal writer in the aerospace industry will be seen as having experience. This means that for some industries, a lot of people may not retire early as they are just arriving at the peak of their career. Apart from the fact that age distribution is deterring others from getting jobs, it could also increase frustration and turnover when it comes to career progression within the organization, which is an effect of age norm. As a result, Lawrence (2004) argues that

some age-related employment problems are indirectly created by the organization, instead of the lack of manpower. Furthermore, Lawrence (2004) argues that as a fact, many people expect contributions from employees to be age related. For example, young employees should have ideas, be energetic, enthusiastic, and even sometimes immature, arrogant, and inexperienced. On the other hand, middle-aged workers are expected to be mature, experienced and because they may be stuck in their careers; they should be resentful. Now, when it comes to the older workers, there is the expectation that they are top level decision makers, and also those that will be looking out their windows and imagining their retirement or with nothing much to do. These are stereotypes that show us how we unconsciously associate one's age with their productivity (Lawrence, 2004).

When looking at age related matters, there are so many loose ends, and there is a difficult task in conceptualization as the concept of age spans across different subject matters and can be seen and studied in numerous fields. On the other hand, it is important to start from the base of age. Age is strongly tied to what we call the concept of life. The concept of life is the way institutions try to shape individual lives towards connected domains such as family, work, and education. This means that life, educational, occupational, and social trajectories which are part of the life course are linked to age (Mayer & Tuma, 1990). Lawrence (1996) gave a detailed account of the history of research on age dating back to the early 1800s. From research, we could see that before sociologists and anthropologists visited the subject matter, research was already done within psychology and medicine. Research in this area, however, focused on individual phenomenon and what was likely to happen to a person when they grew older. It is thus concluded that age was a determined human feature. Following this discovery, research went on into the spheres of age and emotional stability, intellectual ability, and even mental illness (see Quetelet, 1834). Further down the line, it was seen that age associated behavior was not necessarily linked to biology but a social phenomenon rather than an individual one (Lawrence, 1996). This later changed the research questions to how age is embedded within societies or social systems. The change in research line brought about the

discovery by Neugarten et al., (1965) that society is what defines the appropriate norms, roles, and statuses that structure behavior when it comes to adulthood or certain ages. From their research, it was seen that 80% of men and 90% of women felt that the best age for marriage for men was from ages 20 to 25 while 85% of men and 90% of women felt that the best age for women to get married was around 19 to 24. With the same group of people, the age stipulated for the accomplishment of men was between 40 and 50 which was felt strongly by 82% of men and 71% of women. The age for women accomplishment was between the ages of 30 and 45 according to 94% of men and 92% of women. Due to the high levels of the percentage and level of agreement, the researchers suggested that society was very strong in creating the age norms specific behaviors. This could easily be explained by how the society or people could make it more difficult for a man more than 50 years of age to be acknowledged as a top accomplisher or producer.

The study of age has brought around different elements. Birren and Cunningham (1985, p.8) consider three kinds of age: biological age, social age, and psychological age. Biological age is expressed as the “present position with respect to his or her potential life span”. Social age is also defined by the roles and habits associated to an individual by other members of the society or community. For example, an individual may be deemed as young via his biological age but with the social age, there could be more expected from them (Settersten & Mayer, 1997). The psychological age however is the behavioral capacity that helps in adapting to certain demands relating to the age. The authors argue that the psychological age is obviously linked and yet independent to the biological and social age as the psychological age is one that makes use of adaptation, learning, intelligence, feelings, motivation and control or regulation which are capacities of both the biological and social age. Furthermore, Kooij et al. (2007) further distinguishes the following types of age.

Chronological age is the age that indicates an individual’s calendar age which is counted after 365 in the calendar year. In an organization, there is a clear distinction between some workers that fall under certain ages. For example, the term older workers may refer to those ranging

from 40 years to 75 years of chronological age (Kooij et al., 2007). Functional or performance-based age is based on the individual's performance which argues that there is a difference between their functioning ability at work when they attain some certain ages. For example, it is argued that when a worker increases in chronological age, they go through biological and physical changes that could be reflected in the health, physical, mental, and cognitive abilities that one way or the other influence or affect their performance or functions. While psychosocial or subjective age looks at the individual's self and social perception of age which can influence how they feel, look and act within the groups they identify with. In this aspect, we can raise the age norms that are linked with an individual's society or even occupation. One aspect to note is that there are three issues this element has focused on. The age by which the society sees the individual to be and the social attitudes that are related to the certain age and how it carries implications for them at work (Kooij et al., 2007). Finally, organizational age refers to how the individual ages within their job or the organization. In most literature we will find that this is mostly termed as seniority level or organizational tenure and could also refer to the stage the individuals are in their career, their skills and more generally, the norms surrounding age within the organization (Kooij et al., 2007).

Normative and Demographic Approach to Age Norms in Organizations

As earlier mentioned, the definition of age norms should include behavior as this shared belief about age tends to influence people's behavior. The normative approach identifies and measures the relationship between these norms and behavior, while the demographic approach demonstrates how age distributions can be used as instruments for age norms (Lawrence, 1988) which means that there is a link whether directly or indirectly between age distributions and behavior. It is important to note that the normative age group is that which defines the standard age for roles and statuses (Lawrence, 1988) while the demographic age group are defined by calculating the age range standard deviation around the mean age of a given population for the given career levels or positions. The most important aspect here is, whatever approach is taken, the constant variable is age and how humans are grouped into

an age group. When looking at the relationship, there is the attribution of either positive or negative behavior and even social pressure to age norms. When looking at social pressures as an example, orchestra members believe their chances of moving into top-ranked orchestras decrease after they reach their early 30s (Faulkner, 1974). These sorts of pressure are seen mostly in some ages within certain careers, and they unfortunately define the success or failures within that career field (Lawrence, 1988).

The normative approach outlines the shared age judgements (age groups or age grades) (Radcliffe-Brown, 1929). To support that normative age groups, exist in organizations, Sofer (1970) carried out research or an examination on two British firms. From this examination, it was seen that there were some shared beliefs amongst managers in their mid-careers. These beliefs were centered around ages for career development. Similarly, Faulkner adds that American and Canadian hockey player showed clear awareness of the fact that major league success was ‘short and fateful’ (Faulkner, 1974, p.142). Moreover, in 1956, Martin and Strauss showed managers shared judgments of timetables relating to career while in 1977, it was observed by Kanter in his research that employees have some age norms that they use when defining fast track and benched employees. Furthermore, there are studies showing that there is a relationship between demographic age groups and their generated age effects and understanding that these age effects are generated socially. In a longitudinal study, Rosenbaum, (1984) showed that workers who are ‘behind’ in age-based career patterns have minor opportunities for future promotions. In this study, it was suggested that there was a high attribution to anxiety, ambition and even motivation by young people which could be because of these age norms and not necessarily the characteristics of their jobs. One good example as seen by Hogan (1981) is the identification of the ‘typical’ ages for finishing education, getting a first job, getting married and having kids. In this study, American men who stray away from the order these ‘achievements’ are arranged tend to experience lower earnings and potential marriage disruptions. Age norms are thus responsible for how these roles are ordered and this could be represented demographically (Hogan, 1981).

While these two approaches (normative and demographic) have been able to contribute to the understanding of these socially generating age effects, they also have their limitations (Lawrence, 1988). For example, although there is various research even as cited earlier about the effects of age norms on careers (Faulkner, 1974; Kanter, 1977); literature at this point have not been able to show a systematic examination of the normative age groups which leaves a lot of gaps in the literature and many questions thus unanswered. There are questions like the age boundaries of normative age groups, where and how the boundaries arrive, how these normative age groups are linked with role and status within careers, and the implication of straying away from age group role and status (or not meeting the expectations) etc. (Lawrence, 1988). On the demographic side, since it is argued that the measures of demographic age groups are what represent age norms, there is the assumption that there are correspondences between the tendencies of an age distribution and the age norms created especially by the employee's shared judgements about age (Lawrence, 1988). Nevertheless, there are indications that as a result, employees often 'misperceive' the reality of the organization (Rosenbaum, 1988). This misperception potentially creates the discrepancy that carrying out demographic research may not be sufficient to explain socially generated age effects. According to Lawrence (1988), in an organization that is in favor of promotions for younger managers; the age distribution in each career level will determine the demographic age group that detects managers that are ahead of the schedule, on their schedule and even behind their schedule for promotion in their careers. Now, if the managers start to note these demographic age groups and understand how they work, the age norms developed because of this is likely to motivate young managers into responding with either more involvement or less depending on what schedule they are on (Lawrence, 1988).

There are other limitations to these approaches and according to Hogan (1981), demographic age transitions especially for roles and status are not even included in this picture. This means that the age norms transitions which are also important variables in this field of research are less known. It is therefore difficult to know and understand how the timing and synchronization of these roles and the transitions are used (Elder, 1975; Hogan 1981).

Elements of Age Norms in Organizations

Every organization has different policy implementation that directs them towards achieving organizational goals. Apart from this, organizations and employees are usually motivated by the idea of having a principle to go by. For example, the behaviors that seemed appropriate and so on. As a result of this, most employees would want to live up to these principles outlined by the organization and in most cases, the age norms created through these policies or principles (Lössbroek et al., 2019). Although, if there are no sanctions existing in the organization, norms are still able to guide behavior which also includes the decisions made in the workplace (Radl, 2012). This is because age norms are implicit rules that are followed most of the time.

When it comes to these principles, Lössbroek et al., (2019) carried out research on the policies associated with whether younger workers should be prioritized over older workers and the age that older workers should retire. This research showed that external or social pressures on organizational managers can contribute to the implementation of policies around old age adaptation within the organization. Furthermore, in another research carried out by Skuciene and Moskvina (2019), employer practices are based on stereotypes (either positive or negative) which are associated with the notion of older workers. These stereotypes also depend on previous experiences, the size of the company and the sector the company belongs to. For example, the labor market in Lithuania is still heavily characterized by older workers, these workers however face obstacles when trying to enter the market once they have reached the limit or span for employment. The obstacles unfortunately are created by both the legal and socioeconomic norms in the country. Although employers claim to have a positive attitude towards older workers, these norms seem to have a stronger influence on the practical aspect (Skuciene & Moskvina, 2019).

Violation and Sanctions

From literature, we can see that an individual can violate the expectation on them when it comes to age norms within the organization. Due to this, Chaudhuri and Ghosh (2011) investigated how organizations create mentorship programs to support the junior employees regarding what their expectations of them are, in the organization. Reverse mentoring is one that shows more of age norms violation especially within older workers. This is when a senior worker is placed in the role of a protégé as opposed to the junior workers.

The sanctions and communications of age norms have however not been thoroughly studied although from what research has shown, age norms sanctions are not necessarily applied to those that do not follow the plan. For example, Settersten (1998) shows that there are no sanctions for those that do not retire at the 'appropriate' age. There is also no evidence of sanction for those that have 'off schedule' careers. Although there is evidence of dissatisfaction especially when it comes to the behavioral aspect of individuals (Lashbrook, 1996). Therefore, it could be said that these shared beliefs of age norms are potentially just observations of what should be achieved or attained when individuals reach certain ages. This could mean that age norms are just a common behavior and not necessarily norms as we think they are, however, it will be important to see the changes or experience an individual undergoes when they violate the age norms expectations in the organization (Greller & Richtermeyer, 2006). Hanashiro and Pereira (2020) also posit that there is the existence of age norms in the organizations that denote the certain appreciation of younger workers including those in managerial positions. The older workers are thus forced into being a part of a minority group and as a result, there tends to be stereotypes when it comes to the older workers in general. Furthermore, these older workers, as constrained by age norms are considered as a resource to be managed by the organization. This means that there is an assumption that the organization's finances will also go into managing and sustaining these workers which at the end of the day, puts the older workers at a higher risk of dismissal (Hanashiro & Pereira, 2020).

Category 2: Beliefs Around the Expectations of Age Norms, Judgements, and Behavior

This category explains the beliefs that individuals have relating to what is expected of them when it comes to age norms. Additionally, this category shows how these beliefs influence judgment and behavior.

Table 3 shows the distribution of research around age norms in organization when it comes to the expectations and beliefs. In this area, most of the research carried out was within a UK context. The most recent work seen was done in 2019 and looks at the impact of age norms and discrimination within the labor market.

Table 3

Beliefs around the Expectations of Age Norms, Judgements and Behaviour

Year	Author (s)	Title	Journal and Location	Type of article (Conceptual or empirical)
2011	Teemu Kautonen, Erno T. Tornikoski, Ewald Kibler	Entrepreneurial Intentions in the Third Age: The Impact of Perceived Age Norms	Small Business Economics, Finland	Empirical
2013	Amy E Hurley-Hanson, Cristina M. Giannantonio, Richard Sudek	High-Tech Entrepreneurial Careers: A Model of Stages, Phases, and Ages	Journal of Business and Management, USA	Conceptual
2015	Nick Llwellyn	'He probably thought we were students': Age norms and the exercise of visual judgement in service work	Organization Studies, UK	Empirical
2019	Slay Ferraro, Prussia G, Mehrotra S	The impact of age norms and discrimination in employment markets: Psychological factors influencing midlife	Human Resource Management International Digest, UK	Empirical

		workers' career mobility choices		

Expectations, Judgements and Behavior Surrounding Age Norms

Age norms are socially accepted assessment of someone's age in each position. In most cases, this assessment causes resilience or even frustration in individuals (Ferraro et al., 2019). In research on career youth norms (CYN), Ferraro et al., (2019) found that workers aged 35 and above felt frustration and uncertainty which was caused by the discriminatory attitudes relating to their age. For example, the technology industry is somewhat known for favoring applicants that are less than 30 years of age. Mark Zukerberg of Facebook clearly states that 'Young people are just starter'. With this belief or perception, older workers or those older than the young people bracket will feel hindered and even daunted when it comes to applying or moving to a technology environment. On the other hand, when it comes to starting a business from scratch, research shows that older individuals are more likely to be on top than younger ones (Singh & DeNoble 2003). Although Lévesque and Minniti (2006) argue that when it comes to entrepreneurship and the time and cost it takes, older individuals are less likely to invest in activities that they presume will not yield instant results or profits like starting a new business. However, in a Finnish research, individuals aged 50-60 made up 16% of new business owners (Kautonen, 2008). A factor that has a huge impact on entrepreneurship is social norms and how they entail individuals having to constantly justify their actions and the actions of others in the group (Giddens, 1984). For age norms in the context of entrepreneurship, there is a shared understanding of the kinds of behavior that will be appropriate for those taking on this role (starting a business). Kautonen et al., (2011) research was carried out to show how these age norms are perceived when it comes to starting up a business and how their perception influences their interest in proceeding within the entrepreneurship intention. The research thus found that if individuals perceive starting a business as socially acceptable at any given age, there is a positive influence on the intention to start a business. This and many other perceptions regarding age are partially arbitrated by

precursors of intentions according to the theory of planned behavior which is attitude, subjective norm, and perceived behavioral control (Kautonen et al., 2011). So, in this case, one can argue that perceived age norms not just directly influence the formation of entrepreneurial intentions but can also indirectly influence them through how entrepreneurial-interested the individual's attitude towards work is.

Apart from behavior, age norms have implications on image (Giannantonio & Hurley-Hanson, 2006). This is impacted by how people assess whether their occupation can be seen as appropriate to their ages. Physical attraction characteristics such as age; in certain occupations and organizations reveal occupational and organizational stereotypes and these stereotypes can be linked to image norms (Giannantonio & Hurley-Hanson, 2006). Image norms are defined as the belief that people must possess certain physical attractiveness for them to work in certain industries, occupations or even companies (Hansel et al., 2013). For example, Steve Job's image while he was in his twenties is said not to have fit the image of those that started their companies or even worked in the tech industry. According to others, he did not look like a 'serious businessperson' that started a company and became a billionaire before reaching the age of thirty. Although Steve Jobs ultimately created his own unique image, he was an excellent example of someone that violated these norms (Issacson, 2011). Now linking this image norm to age norms in organizations and even entrepreneurial intentions as seen above; such age norms can unfortunately reflect on how the organization operates (Hansel et al., 2013). Although others following in the steps of Steve Jobs will claim that this norm is radically changing in the entrepreneurial world (Hansel et al., 2013).

On the other hand, in the service industry, workers treat age as a 'problem' due to its relevance for the consumption of goods and services. For example, the police, employees of nightclubs, security institutions, bus drivers, supermarket and other related goods and services areas will view the disparities of age when customers order things. For example, staff will hear orders such as 'one adult and a child please' and mention things related to physical appearance

(Llewellyn, 2014). Research in an art gallery where customers paid for themed exhibitions showed how workers apply and link age norms to physical appearance. As there are different types of tickets (concessionary for over 60s and unwaged students; child price or free entry and the adult tickets which was full priced). With this, when a customer asks for 2 tickets, the worker would have to determine what category they fell according to their physical appearance (Llewellyn, 2014). Deciphering this is called 'professional vision' according to Goodwin (1994); which means their ability to draw conclusions on qualities and course of actions from how people and certain things look. Although Llwellyn's (2014) research is not necessarily focused on internal workers but the customers; it was important to see how employees draw out conclusion on the type of tickets to sell to individuals based on how they looked or even behave. Strauss (1985) argues that age norms are not just important for conversations around work; but also important for how individuals perform their work. For example, some jobs like seen above involve workers having to classify customers into age categories to enable them act in professional and bureaucratic manners (see Packard, 2009 on health sector classification of older people). Additionally, according to Skuciene and Moskvina (2019) survey on 216 managers and middle managers; it was found that there was a general positive attitude towards older workers however with little encouragement from the workplace to ensure that these older workers had prolonging working careers.

Category 3: Retirement

This category looks at the relationship between age norms and retirement or the intention to retire. A lot of countries have changed their laws on the retirement age. However, age norms have been seen to influence the decisions of individuals to go into retirement. Table 4 presents the literature on age norms relating to retirement.

Table 4

Retirement

Year	Author (s)	Title	Journal and Location	Type of article (Conceptual or empirical)
2010	Amy M Warren, Kevin E Kelloway	Retirement decisions in the context of the abolishment of mandatory retirement	International Journal of Manpower, Canada	Empirical
2016	Jaap Oude Mulders, Kene Henkens, Joop Schippers	European Top Managers' Age-Related Workplace Norms and Their Organizations' Recruitment and Retention Practices Regarding Older Workers	The Gerontologist, UK - Europe	Empirical
2019	Daiva Skuciene, Julija Moskvina	Employers' Policies and Attitudes Towards the Performance of Older Employees in Lithuania.	Business: Theory and Practice, Lithuania	Empirical
2020	Jaap Oude Mulders	"Employers' age-related norms, stereotypes and ageist preferences in employment",	International Journal of Manpower, UK	Empirical
2021	Sarah Vickerstaff, Mariska van der Horst	The Impact of Age Stereotypes and Age Norms on Employees' Retirement Choices: A Neglected Aspect of Research on Extended Working Lives	Frontiers in Sociology, UK, The Netherlands	Empirical

Age Norms and Retirement

In many cases and countries, we have seen that discrimination based on age is highly prohibited; however, there is still evidence of ageist practices in many organizations (Gordon and Arvey, 1986; Mulders et al., 2016). According to Marcus and Fritzsche (2016) could be based on the norms on retirement and stereotypes that are deeply associated with organizational culture. Therefore, one of the most common elements of studying age norms in organization is the relationship between these norms and retirement. For example, in Lithuania, there is an upper age limit for employment and a maximum age limit for those applying to certain positions. There is also a maximum age limit for some positions like we have perceived in age norm theories. In Lithuania, the age 50 (years) is the lower age limit although under certain circumstances for those applying for a position in the intelligence

service. When looking at a position for Notary, Special Investigation Services or the Internal Service, it is 60 years. While the retirement age for men is 62 years and 6 months. Although it is said that this has been gradually increasing and will probably reach 65 years for both women and men in the year 2026. It is safe to say that applicants within the public service have not been more than 65 years of age (Skuciene & Moskvina 2019). According to Skuciene and Moskvina (2019), the retirement age has deprived older individuals of still being involved in the labor market. Although the demand for labor in the Lithuanian market is constantly increasing and on the other hand, older workers still as interested and active in the market; the national document still opposes the employment of these older workers because of the age limits. From an internal employer perspective, stopping older workers careers were mostly because of the following reasons: “exclusion from training, pension/tax system, absence of gradual retirement schemes as well as the view of employers” (Skuciene & Moskvina 2019; Pg. 480). The view of employers in this case is mostly because employers mostly refer to retirement as a reason for older workers to leave the labor market (Skuciene & Moskvina, 2019 elaborated from 2014 survey in Lithuania). Additional reasons included health problems or problems with the work being ‘too hard’. According to the authors, these employer responses confirmed the spread of age norms because of the official retirement age as stipulated by the government. Although this means that even though an individual does not have any of these health problems, the norm attached to their age already signifies that it is time for them to retire. According to the research it is because the employers are not willing to take on the responsibility of the supposed health problems or workload issues attached to these older workers.

However, on the other hand, the survey in 2014 also showed 26% of employers claiming to encourage their older staff of about 55 years+ to pursue their professional career paths longer. Although the question remains on how the age norms within the organizations will be affected. On the contrary, 55% of employers do not actually motivate their older workers to extend their career journey while 17% of employers do this partially. When asked to elaborate on the sort of encouragement given to older workers to continue in their professional paths, there were

no indicated measures of integration of older workers into the labor market. Measures could be how they combine work and retirement, flexible working, and lifelong learning opportunities which according to Conen et al., (2012) apud (Skuciene & Moskvina, 2019) have been initiatives picked up by foreign enterprises. Even in Canada, although the law changes because of the abolishment of mandatory retirement, the context of retiring has also changed with it (Warren & Kelloway, 2010). Although looking back in 2004, most of the retirees had retired voluntarily with only 26.9% forced into it. Older workers in most cases have been seen to desire to still be in the labor market due to proper incentives like flexible work etc. (Warren & Kelloway, 2010). Thus, it is argued that, to some extent the perceived control of retirement is not only made up of the decision to retire but also because of other external circumstances like finances, social/policy influences according to a study by Warren and Kelloway (2010).

On the other hand, in a Dutch context, there is the preference for younger workers especially when it comes to hiring new employees. Although the ageing population has created the necessity for longer working lives because of the increasing life expectancy and declining fertility rates (Mulders, 2020), which can be seen by the need for older employers to relax or postpone their retirement from the labor market. Although as seen as above, other countries have also implemented changes in the labor market and retirement ages or decision, however, most literature on social norms and stereotypes will show that this still has a negative impact on employment opportunities and behavior towards older employees (Warren & Kelloway, 2010; Karpinska et al., 2013; Mulders et al., 2018; Skuciene & Moskwina, 2019; Mulders, 2020). On the other hand, there are many negative stereotypes associated with older workers that have been seen to affect their job opportunities negatively. For example, older workers are most times perceived to have some physical and mental capacities that can be termed as diminishing. Additionally, there is the assumption that they have a minimized willingness and capacity to learn new things. They are also deemed to be less productive in their work than the younger workers (Posthuma & Campion, 2009; Van Dalen et al., 2010; Harris et al., 2018). However, there are also positive stereotypes associated with older workers such as their

reliability and commitment; and often possessing better social skills than the younger ones (Harris et al., 2018). The thing about these stereotypes is the fact that they may be true in only some certain cases. However, one can see that they do have a strong influence on real life behavior and attitudes towards those involved (Ng & Feldman, 2012). As a result of these behaviors and attitudes, there will be preferences and potentially norms associated with hiring and keeping older workers which in turn influence the outcome and opportunities for these older workers to remain active in the labor market (Henkens, 2005; Mulders, 2020).

Category 4: Recruitment and Retention

This category looks at the relationship between age norms and retirement or the intention to retire. Additionally, the decision to retain older workers that fall under certain age groups or norms are investigated. A lot of countries have changed their laws on the retirement age however, age norms have been seen to influence the decisions of individuals to go into retirement. Table 5 presents the literatures on age norms relating to recruitment and retention

Table 5

Recruitment and Retention

Year	Author (s)	Title	Journal and Location	Type of article (Conceptual or empirical)
2013	Kasia Karpinska, Kene Henkens, Joop Schippers.	Hiring retirees: Impact of age norms and stereotypes	Journal of Managerial Psychology, The Netherlands	Empirical
2014	Jaap Oude Mulders, Hendrik Dalen, Kene Henkens, Joop Schippers.	How Likely are Employers to Rehire Older Workers After Mandatory Retirement? A Vignette Study Among Managers	De Economist, The Netherlands	Empirical
2020	Silvia Dello Russo, Emma Parry, Janine Bosak, Maike Andresen, Eleni Apospori, Silvia Bagdadli, Katharina	Still feeling employable with growing age? Exploring the moderating effects of	The Gerontologist, UK - Europe	Empirical

	Chudzikowski, Michael Dickmann, Sonia Ferencikova, Martina Gianecchini, Douglas Tim Hall, Robert Kase, Mila Lazarova, Astrid Riechel.	developmental HR practices and country-level unemployment rates in the age – employability relationship		

Recruitment

As previously mentioned, most organizations have shared beliefs about what the appropriate age for some given positions are (Lawrence, 1988). These shared beliefs about age and specific positions within organizations have shown to have negative influence on the decision during recruitment (Mulders et al., 2018) and retention (Karpinska et al., 2013). It is easy to argue that older workers have fewer opportunities when it comes to recruitment and retention (Russo et al., 2020). For most employees in certain ages in their lives, there is the perception of being less employable and can be proven through ageist practices during hiring (Riach & Rich, 2006 apud Russo et al., 2020). Apart from these perceptions, there is the chance of having lower beliefs when it comes to certain employers which can bring about negative judgements concerning the employers this Russo et al. (2020) argue that age will negatively relate to individual external employability. From empirical research, Russo et al. (2020) found that their respondents had less faith in being employable due to the assumption of certain age norms perceived by them. Furthermore, in a vignette study by Mulders et al. (2014), Dutch managers were most likely to decline or rehire workers that have reached their retirement age. Although, they are likely to rethink this decision for the workers willingness to take on a lower wage. Although organizations will differ in their preferences or attitudes towards the ages of workers. Mulders et al. (2014) argue that these differences will be because of personal or organizational values and the extent to which these job seekers or workers are able to fit into the spheres.

Retention

When it comes to retention, the decision is always based on the organization in question and what systems or goals they have (Karpinska et al., 2013). As an influence on the attainment of the goals, the organization will try to maintain qualified employees that will contribute positively to the organizational goals (Karpinska et al., 2013). From research, management is most likely to retain older workers than recruit them, if the cost is lower and if these older workers have a strong impact on the attainment of the organizational goals (Daniel & Heywood, 2007 apud Karpinska et al., 2013). They argue that working with internal employees lowers the uncertainty that comes with hiring older workers. Although this also depends on how significant the older workers are within their roles. On the other hand, when it comes to retention, Karpinska et al. (2013) found that managers are more likely to recommend the retention of workers that are willing to participate in training and re-training initiatives. Furthermore, employees are classified as being easy to manage or difficult to manage based on their perceived age norms. There is a lower chance of retention for those that are classified as difficult to manage, based on their ages or norms that surround their ages (Karpinska et al., 2013).

Chapter 3: Research Method and Methodology

This chapter on research methods and methodology focuses on how the research on age norms in organizations was conducted within a tech start-up. This segment will delve into the concept of research methods and methodology, encompassing the chosen technique for data collection. Furthermore, we will examine different philosophies, paradigms and methods related to the selection for this research. Finally, areas such as ethical considerations, reliability and validity of data will be discussed as well as challenges faced throughout the course of this research.

3.1 Research Approach

An inductive approach looks at the various views to build standpoints and interconnecting theories (Creswell, 2009). In deductive approach, the validity of assumptions or hypothesis in hand are tested while inductive approach contributes to the development of new theories and generalizations (Bryman & Bell 2015). The deductive approach is usually considered to be suited to align with the positivist approach which authorizes the formulation of hypotheses and the statistical testing of expected results to an accepted level of probability (Snieder & Larner 2009). Considering this, this research took on an inductive approach as it sought to explore different points of view from an interpretivist's point of view. From this approach, variables will not be linked, and the context goes deeper and will not be quantified.

3.2 Philosophical Stances

According to the research onion, research philosophy is the outermost and first layer of the steps to be taken during research (Saunders et al., 2007). Research philosophy according to Flick (2011), helps in understanding the various concepts that are critical in the research process; it creates assumptions that provide an explanation of not only how the research would be carried out but also, how it fits the chosen methodology. Research philosophy is also defined by Bryman (2012) as a set of beliefs that concerns the nature of an investigated reality. It is also one of the series of choices that must be considered by a researcher which shows

the alignment of thoughts that must be connected back to the research problem (Blaikie, 2010). Since there are various research philosophies, it is observed that philosophies may vary in line with research objectives and how to achieve the research goal (Goddard & Melville, 2004). However, May (2011) argues that such variations will not necessarily be at odds with each other but rather, be individually determined by the type of knowledge being pursued. As a result of this, it is argued and cautioned that individual research preferences may shape the research design and philosophy which could be seen as a bias in the research (Partington, 2002). Therefore, it is important that researchers understand deeply the research philosophies and underlying assumptions and how the chosen philosophy will fit into the methodology and research (Saunders et al., 2007). It is important to reemphasize that understanding research philosophies will assist researchers or writers in evaluating and choosing methods and methodologies while avoiding incongruous use and futile efforts by identifying limitations and challenges that may affect research at an early stage (Easterby-Smith et al., 2006).

There are therefore three main research paradigms namely ontology, epistemology, and axiology. They can also be known as research axioms (Saunders et al., 2007). According to Blaikie (2010), Ontology is defined as the system of belief that reflects how an individual interprets what is known as fact. In simpler terms, ontology is focused on the question of if social entities need to be perceived as objective or subjective. Phillimore and Goodson (2004) explain that ontology is associated with the concept of reality and its perception by individuals and how it influences everything in the world. Additionally, ontology can be defined as the study of existence and its representation of reality which is more concerned about the nature of reality and how the world functions (Gray, 2014). According to Phillimore and Goodson (2004), researchers should be able to understand the difference between what reality is and how reality is perceived or constructed by humans or society.

Epistemology is defined as the philosophy of knowledge and its justification (Audi, 2000). It is argued to be the study of the principles by which a researcher organizes what does and does not constitute acceptable knowledge and how it is constructed (Hallebone & Priest, 2009). Epistemology produces assumptions about the best possible ways of inquiring into the nature

of the world (Crotty, 1998; Saunders et al.,2007; Easterby-Smith et al., 2008). Epistemology is also centered around how researchers find out the truth is also deals with ways by which the knowledge of truth is acquired (Gray, 2014). Epistemology deals with 'nature and forms of knowledge' in other words, the kinds of knowledge and where this knowledge is acquired (Cohen et al., 2007, p.7) and how it is acquired (Scotland, 2012). Furthermore, this axiom is mostly concerned about how data or 'evidence' is researched and deciphered to get the truth (Easterby-Smith et al., 2008). Additionally, epistemology enquires into how the researcher and the topic are related (Guba & Lincoln, 1994). Interpretivism on the other is the philosophy that assumes that access to reality (given or socially constructed) is only through social constructions such as language, consciousness, shared meanings, and instruments (Myers, 2008). This research therefore took an interpretivist approach to investigating how age norms are formed in technological startup. Axiology, the third paradigm is more concerned about values and ethics (Mingers, 2003). The term axiology refers to the values and ethics in research. In research, how researchers deal with their values and that of the environment is very important as the credibility of results will be questioned (Saunders et al., 2007). Heron (1996) contends that human values are what determines the kind of action to be taken. For researchers, values are the basis of making judgements on what to research and how it should be done. In other words, axiology investigates what is good and bad, right and wrong and other ethical circumstances (Hart, 1971).

Axiology primarily focuses on the 'aims' of the research which is the branch of the research philosophy that attempts to elucidate if the researcher is either trying to explain or predict the world, or only seeking to understand it. Specifically, axiology is engaged with assessment of the role of researcher's own value on all stages of the research process (Saunders et al., 2007).

3.3 Research Methods

Research methods can be divided into two major parts, and they are quantitative and qualitative research (Yilmaz, 2013). The quantitative method as the name suggests deals with

numeric data (Flick, 2011). The numerical techniques are quantified using statistical inferences which include but are not limited to numbers, tables and graphs (Mauthner, 2002). Quantitative research can be defined as a form of research that explains occurrences according to arithmetical data which are analyzed mathematically (Yilmaz, 2013).

However, qualitative data construction methods according to William (2005), were developed after it was observed that quantitative data collection techniques could not express human feelings and emotions. Qualitative method is regarded as obtaining data about real life situations from people and being able to make sense of such experiences and a wider context (De Vaus, 2002). For interpretivists, using quantitative methods is not sufficient to get the in-depth conclusion of an issue and as such cannot understand social phenomena. Therefore, a qualitative approach is derived where human beings and their views and perceptions are the main aim of research (Shar & Al-Barji, 2013). In this type of research, conclusions and findings are not derived through mathematical or statistical means (Strauss, 1985), rather by various viewpoints. Data is majorly collected through case studies, interviews (open ended interviews), questionnaires (open ended), focus groups and other ways that participants can share their various insights and viewpoints. This research thus gathered data using qualitative data collection methods.

3.4 Netnography

Ethnography is a practice characterized by its open-ended nature, involving participation and observation in specific fields (Kozinets, 2002). In addition to this, the quality of data obtained from ethnographic research and its adaptability to different contexts are key elements of this method. For over a century, ethnography has been utilized to gain insights into human and non-human behaviors (Kozinets, 2002). Notably, each ethnographic study is unique, as the method is continuously tailored to suit the field, research questions, time frame, preferences, and environment. The online community serves as a research environment where individuals interact socially and share common goals, making it a valuable subject for research (Preece,

2000). The term "netnography," introduced by Kozinets (1998), refers to the ethnographic approach applied to the study of online communities. This approach is also known as online ethnography (Markham, 2005) or virtual ethnography (Hine, 2000). Netnography is a research method that utilizes social science techniques to introduce a novel strategy for conducting ethical and comprehensive ethnographic studies. This method integrates archival and online communication work, active participation and observation, along with innovative digital and network data collection, analysis, and research representation (Kozinets, 2010, p.1). In various academic disciplines, netnography has proven to be highly beneficial in uncovering interaction styles, communal exchanges, personal narratives, as well as forms of organization and collaboration within research settings (Kozinets, 2010). Unlike traditional ethnographic approaches that focus on identifying shared patterns of beliefs, values, and behaviors through immersion in the daily lives of a group (Creswell, 2007), netnography follows a similar path by engaging in fieldwork, data collection, and material gathering through observations and interviews (Kulavuz-Onal, 2015). The primary distinction between ethnography and netnography lies in the fact that netnography gathers data through online interactions, allowing for a wide range of field sites due to technological advancements (Kulavuz-Onal, 2015). This research was therefore carried out using Netnographic because the research organization is purely online based.

3.4.1 Netnography Data Collection

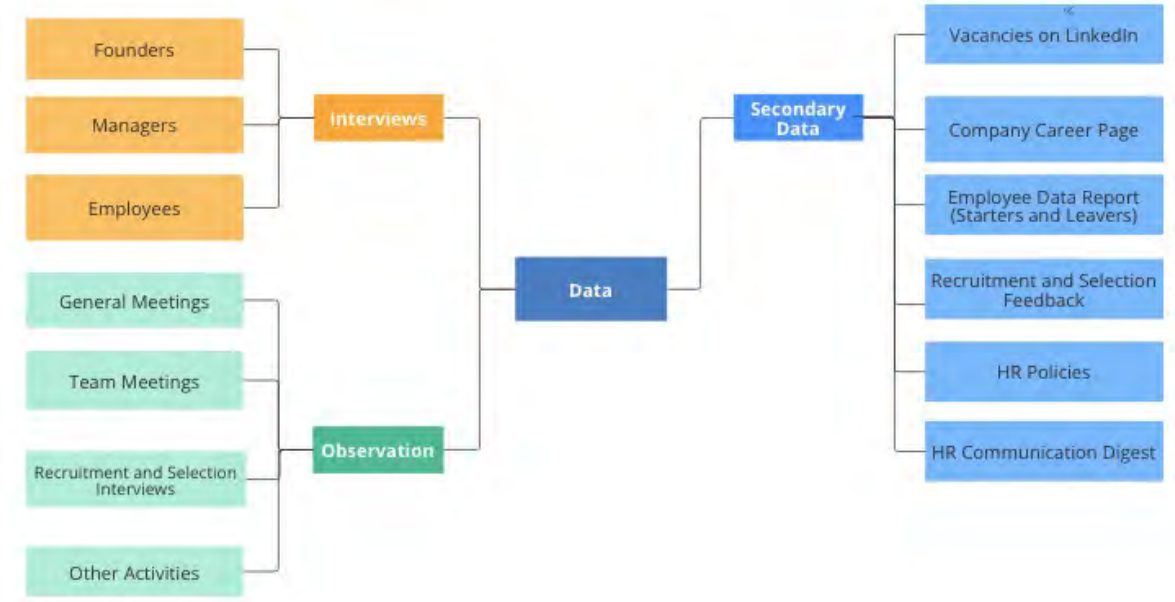
In netnography, data is derived from various sources, including interviews, fieldnotes from observation, elicited data, and archival data (Kozinets, 2010). Archival data, such as webpages and archived textual communication, remains unaltered by the researcher (Kozinets, 2010). Elicited data, on the other hand, can take the form of asynchronous communication like email exchanges and online comments (Kozinets, 2010). For our study, we utilized interviews, observation, and archival data (secondary data) such as online job postings on platforms like LinkedIn, the company's career page, employee data, interview

feedback, HR policies, and HR communication materials. Netnographic data can be voluntarily shared or protected, and it can be created by individuals, groups, or even with the assistance of machines or software (Kozinets, 2010). Our observations encompassed general meetings, team meetings, recruitment interviews, and other company events or activities. Moreover, netnographic data can encompass various forms such as words, images, drawings, sounds, photography, audiovisuals, or any other digitally generated content. In our case, we also gathered images from the online slack community used for collaboration within the company.

For the interview aspect of data collection, Merriam (1998) recommends employing qualitative interview techniques. In this research, a semi-structured interview approach was adopted, wherein the questions were carefully crafted to elicit detailed responses. This type of interview strikes a balance between being overly rigid and excessively flexible, and it serves the common objective of comprehending reality from diverse perspectives (Qu & Dumay, 2011). Consequently, three distinct groups were interviewed: the founders, the managers, and the employees. The interview questions are attached to our research document as an appendix. Figure 2 shows all sources of data collection.

Figure 2

Sources of Data Collection



Source: Elaborated by the authors.

3.4.2 Netnography Data Analysis

In analyzing data, researchers may choose to classify their data as either primarily social and informational or primarily on topic or off topic (Kozinets, 2002). Data analysis, as defined by Merriam (1998, p.109) “consists of examining, categorizing, tabulating, testing, or otherwise recombining both quantitative and qualitative evidence to address the initial propositions of a study”. In this research, a thematic analysis approach was employed, which entails describing, identifying, and analyzing themes within the data (Braun & Clarke, 2006). This process involves the selection of codes, and the development of themes based on the data (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Categorization, on the other hand, involves interpreting textual information by organizing the data collected into categories. This method involves searching for coherence and central clusters of meanings, ultimately leading to the creation of meta categories.

Following Braun and Clarke (2012), we used a 6-phase approach to analyzing our data. Each phase highlights the various elements in thematic analysis.

- Phase 1: Familiarizing yourself with the data

  During the initial stage, it is essential to acquaint oneself with the data. This involves thoroughly engaging with the data through reading, re-reading, and listening to all audio recordings. Alongside reading, it is crucial to take notes on significant aspects and areas of focus for the research. Additionally, field notes should be reviewed, particularly those detailing the participants in each interview and the specific roles they play in the research.

- Phase 2: Generating initial codes

  During this phase, the objective is to implement the codes derived from the data. The development of these codes will facilitate the identification of crucial components pertinent to the research inquiry. Codes are formulated through the examination of transcripts, continual addition to the existing codes, and the generation of new codes as the researcher progresses through the reading process.

- Phase 3: Searching for themes

  Phase 3 involves the exploration of themes by examining all the codes that have been generated. The aim is to uncover overarching topics that are linked to these codes.

- Phase 4: Reviewing potential themes

  During Phase 4, the focus shifts to evaluating potential themes and determining whether there is a correlation between the codes and the themes they represent. Additionally, the relevance of the codes to the identified themes are questioned.

- Phase 5: Defining and naming themes

Phase 5 involves the process of defining and assigning names to the themes that will be utilized in the ultimate report.

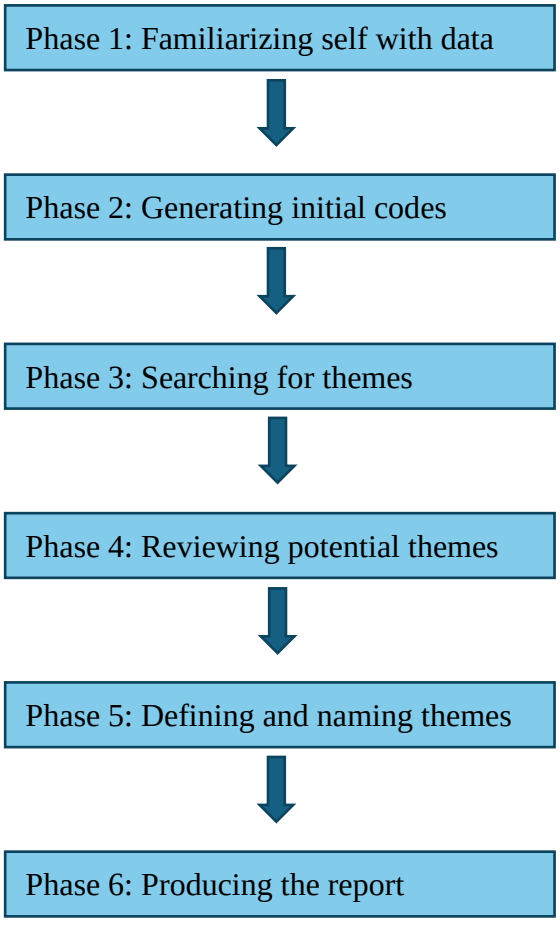
- Phase 6: Producing the report

  This phase focuses on the creation of the report. Once all the codes and themes meet a specific standard of excellence and fulfillment, the researcher will then proceed with outlining the structure and content of the report.

Figure 3 below shows the 6-phase approach to data analysis as suggested by Braun and Clarke (2012).

Figure 3

6 Phase Approach to Data Analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2012)



Source: Elaborated by authors from Braun and Clarke (2012)

3.4.2.1 Observation Method Process of Data Analysis. According to Kozinets (2015), the analysis of netnographic data can be approached through either hermeneutics or deep reading. To analyze our observational data, we employed certain aspects of thematic analysis while adhering to the 7 analytic steps outlined by Kozinets (2015).

- Step 1: Imagining

  During this initial step, the focus is on developing reflective ideas. The researcher should engage in an imaginative process, envisioning the type of data and themes that may emerge from the analysis.

- Step 2: Re-memorying

  In this step, documenting all the information and experiences that were recalled during the field work should be done.

- Step 3: Abduction

  As Kozinets (2015) suggests, the primary objective of this step is to identify patterns or connections within the data.

- Step 4: Visual abstraction

  During this stage, the researcher should strive to extract broader abstractions from specific moments within the data.

- Step 5: Artifying

  According to Kozinets (2015), this step involves visually presenting the data through creative means such as collages or visual webs.

- Step 6: Cultural decoding

At this point, the researcher should attempt to organize their data based on any cultural codes or influences that may be present.

- Step 7: Tournament play

  For the final step, the idea is to consolidate all the ideas derived from the data and categorize them into themes that have emerged from the data set or themes that have been identified through interviews.

3.5 Research Context

The study was conducted in a technology company established in Brazil by three young individuals who met while attending college in São Paulo. The company officially commenced operations in 2013, with the founders aged 20, 22, and 23 respectively. Initially, the company aimed to dominate the market in Latin America. However, due to changes in the business environment, they had to expand globally to cater to clients worldwide. This expansion led to significant changes and potential growth in various departments within the organization. Presently, the technology startup is incorporated in the United States and prides itself on recruiting talent from diverse regions. The company comprises seven departments: Product (IT), Sales, Inside Sales, Marketing, Customer Success, HR, and Cadet, with a workforce of over 140 individuals collaborating from different corners of the globe. Specializing in Software as a Service (SaaS), the company focuses on developing solutions for hybrid, virtual, and in-person events. Their primary clientele consists of businesses, necessitating a 24-hour technology team to continuously innovate and enhance software features. Currently, the company operates entirely on a remote and virtual basis, with no physical offices worldwide. Team members utilize online platforms such as Zoom, Google Meet, Slack, Trello, and other virtual workspaces for collaboration. The interview participants are categorized into three groups: founders, managers, and employees. Conducting interviews with the founders provided valuable insights into the establishment of age-related norms within the organization,

while interactions with managers and employees shed light on any existing age-related practices within the company.

3.6 Ethical Consideration

Research ethics is a crucial aspect to consider in the field of netnography. It is important to adhere to ethical guidelines when conducting netnography, especially considering the growing concern surrounding ethics in the online realm (Kozinets, 2002). In the context of netnography, the concept of "informed consent" becomes significant, as netnographers can be perceived as professional lurkers (Kozinets, 2002). While the potential harm of netnography should be acknowledged, Kozinets (2002) provides four steps that researchers should follow to ensure ethical research practices. Firstly, researchers should fully disclose their presence, including their affiliations and intentions, to all participants involved in the study. Secondly, researchers should guarantee confidentiality and anonymity to the participants. Thirdly, researchers should actively seek feedback from the online community members being studied. Lastly, researchers should exercise caution in determining what constitutes a private or public medium, as certain data may not be usable or directly quoted during transcription. Additionally, obtaining permission is necessary before utilizing any online artifacts or publications. It is imperative for researchers and their studies to uphold ethical standards and methodologies throughout the entire research process. Therefore, our research underwent the appropriate ethical approval process by the University and the Brazilian educational board prior to commencing field work. In accordance with the university and educational board's guidelines, informed consent was obtained from all study participants. Although our research did not delve into sensitive issues concerning the organization and its employees, we acknowledged the possibility that interviewees may feel uncomfortable with certain interview questions. Consequently, participants were notified of their option to revoke their consent for research participation at any time. The free and informed consent form (TCLE) attached as an appendix in this study was provided to interviewees with relevant information and instructions, along with contact details for the university and researchers in case of any inquiries. While there were no

immediate advantages for participants in the research, they are aware that they have access to the complete thesis through the university library once it has been successfully defended and published in August 2024.

Chapter 4: Results and Discussion

The aim of this chapter is to analyze and discuss the data obtained from the three sources of data collection (founders, managers, and employees' interviews, secondary data, and observations). The chapter starts by giving a brief introduction to the company of research. We describe the company operations, the departments and their responsibilities. We will then explain the process of data analyses for each source of data. Finally, the chapter will show the results of the data collection, triangulate all results from the various data collection sources, and discuss these results in relation to the literature. The decision to divide the results section from the discussion section arises from the observation that discussing our literature at the end of each data set may seem redundant given the presence of similar data themes and categories in our datasets. Therefore, to avoid repetition in each data set, we opted to integrate our themes and discuss them with the literature towards the end of the chapter.

4.1 Company Profile

This research was carried out in a SaaS (Software as a Service) events technology company that was founded in Brazil by three men who met in a college in São Paulo, Brazil. The company started operations in 2013 with the 3 founders being 20, 22, 23 years old at the time. When the company started, the goal was to become the leader in their field in Latin America. Due to environmental changes and internal growth, they started supporting clients around the world. This company is headquartered in the United States and recruits their employees from all over the world while ensuring that their global clients' needs are met and satisfied.

The main business operation of the company is creating events management solutions for hybrid, virtual, and in person events. With 1.1 million events created 67 million registrations over their platform, and 182 countries reached, SaaS is looking to change the concept of event management solution. Some of their core solutions embedded in their website for managing events are:

1. Registration software for events: This simplifies and integrates the end-to-end flow for any event registration. This software includes components for integrating flights, hotel bookings, transportation, etc.
2. Dynamic landing pages: The company's solution gives the opportunity for users to build an interactive website landing page which does not require any complex coding from the client's end. The landing pages can include all the essential information for events as well as any events updates. Furthermore, the company also provides white labels for their clients.
3. Powerful forms: The company provides event forms that could be customized to have as many questions needed. A unique aspect of this is that these forms could be generalized for every attendee or specific to each attendee.
4. Tickets Sales: The company provides integration with financial companies to enable the sale of event tickets via their website or the client's landing page. All tickets sales are verified using their access control solution.

Other products within the company's solution range are grouped into the following categories and depending on the plan purchased, clients can have access to most of them.

1. Registration: Ticket Management, Event Marketing, Landing Pages, Sponsor Management, Speaker Management, Event Appointments, and Scheduled Meetings.
2. Pass: NFC Scan, Badge Kiosk, and Lead Retrieval.
3. Integrations: CRM and Data Analytics, Native Integrations, App Marketplace, and Artificial Intelligence.

4. Live: Mobile App, Virtual Lobby, Live Studio, Gamification, Event Management, Accessibility, and Event Map.
5. Compliance: Analytics and Reports, Budget and Suppliers Management, projects Management, and Inventory Management.
6. Hospitality: Booking Management, Travel Management, and Housing Management.

The company has sold their solutions within industries such as pharmaceutical, financial services, government, technology, education, investor relations and the fashion industry. Additionally, some of the event types that have been carried out by clients include conferences, webinars, awards, fundraising, tradeshows and political campaigns. These event types are either in person, virtual or hybrid.

From an internal standpoint, the organization has six core departments namely, Product (IT), Sales, Inside Sales, Marketing, Customer Success, and People and Culture. There is an additional department called the Cadet department that is specific for interns, apprentices, or trainees. This department is built as short term because interns, after a year will either be dismissed or moved to the main departments. The organization operates in a fully remote and virtual mode. There are no physical offices in any part of the world and teammates collaborate using online tools like their platform, zoom, slack and Jira.

The Sales process start by the customers/clients discovering the company through referrals, organic searches on the internet, marketing campaigns and or calls and emails sent by the inside sales department using major databases to prospect for external decision makers. The Sales process is thus broken down by the role that each department plays. Additionally, the description of each department is included below along with the candidates they would usually seek and an average age range for the team members.

4.1.1 Marketing Department

The marketing department's main function is to potentially convert a lead into an opportunity using events, campaigns, social media, and data analytics. The marketing department consists of roles such as social media analyst, events specialist, partnership specialist, paid media specialist, video maker, content specialist and so on. The marketing department is challenged with knowing the profile of the clients or potential clients. This could consist of the client's background, decision maker profile and if there is a potential fit for the company. Once the details have been acquired by marketing, the next step is to constantly and permanently execute content tracks to guide the potential clients through the sales process. Marketing tends to place "baits" on or offline to capture the leads whether directly or indirectly. The department also ensures that the company and promotional content are placed in strategic places for potential clients. They make sure the company is present in networking events, tradeshows, conferences and so on. The marketing department will usually recruit and offer those who are very social media inclined and have innovative ideas of campaign strategies. The average age range for team members in this department is 30.

4.1.2 Inside Sales Department

The inside sales department consists of sales development specialists and business intelligence specialists. Their primary responsibility is to reach out to potential clients using emails, calls, or social media messages. The inside sales department uses terminologies such as prospecting, lead (qualified and unqualified). Prospecting is the act of speaking to a client about the potential services the company can offer. A lead is anyone in a potential client company that the company has contact information for. A lead can come from marketing campaigns, through networking, or on social media.

Qualified and unqualified leads will be the leads that have been spoken to and identified if the company's solution will fit or not. The process of qualification entails speaking a bit to the lead to find out details about using the company's solution or not. In the process of qualifying a

lead, the sales development agent will try to presell the company's solution and book an official meeting with the prospect. The inside sales department is usually interested in candidates that have business intelligence profiles, can prospect online, and those that have a vast social media presence especially lots of followers on LinkedIn. The average age range for members of this department is 30.

4.1.3 Sales Department

The main function of the sales department is to convert the prospect to a client by closing and finalizing a sales deal. To close this deal, the sales account executive must speak to the client, answering their many questions and demo-ing the platform or solution to the client. The sales process is not usually an easy one as there are always back and forth with prospects. The average time for a sales process to be completed is about 1-2 months, while some may take even longer. A sales account executive is usually patient, consistent and most times relentless. The company will usually go after profiles that are experienced in the sales process, ambitious candidates, and those that have experience with SaaS or B2B sales (business to business sales). Additionally, profiles that are tech savvy will be a good fit for the department. The average age range for members of this department is 32.

4.1.4 Customer Success Department

The Customer Success department is more of a support department for customers. The department takes over from when a sale has been completed and the prospect has become a client. Their main responsibility is to provide support to customers or clients when needed. They are available 24/7 and speak different languages to provide support to customers all around the world. They render their support through chats, emails, telephone calls, and video conferencing calls. An additional responsibility is creating the FAQs that are used by customers and even members of the company. As soon as a product or feature has been created or updated on the software, the customer success team creates a manual on how to

use the new feature. This manual is also translated by members of the team to ensure that they reach a wider range of customers or users. The team also serves as a major link between the production team (product team) and the customers. Most times, customers give their feedback on the software and this feedback is related through the customer success team to the product team. The ideal profile of a customer success representative is one that is very flexible in terms of working hours, tech savvy, and customer service oriented. They measure team members' efficiency and productivity through CSAT Surveys (Customer Satisfaction Surveys) which are mostly determined by the time it takes the member to respond to the customer and the quality of response given. The average age range for members of this department is 30.

4.1.5 Product Department

This department is commonly known as the IT department in other companies. This is the department that has all the tech minds like IoS developers, Front end developers, Full stack developers, QA Testers and so on. The department deals with creating the entire product that the company is known for and sells. As the product is software, there is heavy reliance on the product team to always come up with innovative solutions. Apart from the creation of solution, there is also the need to constantly test and ensure that the product or features of the product are 'bug' free. The main responsibility of the product team, apart from creating the solution, is to continuously test what is being created. They are always attentive to the needs and feedback of the customers. A common day in the product department is fixing issues that could be caused by anything ranging from both internal and external interference in the user's computer. The department relies on the knowledge of some PHP (programming language) and this knowledge has an enormous part to play in how the recruiting process is carried out in the company. The ideal profile for this department is also someone that is flexible to changes and happy to work in a fast-paced environment. The average age range for members of this department is 29.

4.1.6 People and Culture Department

The people and culture department formerly known as the Human Resources department comprises of six different sub teams: Talent Acquisition, Core HR, Learning and Development, Compliance, Finance, and Employer Branding. The department focuses on the 360º life cycle of the employee right from the inception of their career in the company to the end of it. The People and Culture Department is very well versed in all the activities of the company and ensures that those coming in are aware of and agree with the company culture and values. Additionally, their responsibility is to ensure that members are kept happy, satisfied, and continuously motivated to stay in the company. The major issue the department constantly faces is the workforce turnover and this can be caused by many internal and external reasons. An ideal profile for this department is anyone that is willing to work in a startup environment and open to having the rules and policies changed constantly. The average age range for this department is 29 years old.

4.1.7 Cadet Department

The cadet department consists of interns or trainees that spend about 12 months learning the core business. The aim of this department is to train young people to prepare them for the job market. After 12 months, cadets are either given a full-time role within the company or ‘graduated’ outside of the organization.

4.2 Process of Data Analysis

Following the methodology chapter of this research, data was collected using three major sources. These sources were interviews, observation using netnographic methods, and secondary data which captured HR policies, recruitment and selection documentation or feedback, Job postings online, company’s career page online other relevant documents that will be discussed.

4.2.1 Interviews Process of Data Analysis

4.2.1.1 Respondents' Profile. Table 6 shows the profile of respondents for the interviews. Respondents were grouped into three categories according to data collection method. The three groups were founders, managers, and employees. These three groups had different question sets (see appendix) and the objectives for interviewing these groups have been highlighted in the methodology aspect of this research. For anonymity, respondents were given codes and numbers according to how they were interviewed. The age range for respondents ranges from 21 years to 55 years. All interviews were done online via Microsoft Teams and Zoom, and participants were in various parts of the world such as Argentina, Brazil, United Kingdom, USA, and Nigeria. Total interview time for all participants was 532 minutes and 29 seconds; with the lowest time spent per individual as 28mins 15 seconds and the maximum time per individual 82 minutes.

Table 6

Respondents' Profile

Category	Respondent Code	Age	Nationality	Location	Start Date	Department	Mode of Interview	Interview Total Time
Founder	F1	30	Brazilian	Atlanta, USA	NA	C-Level	Online – Zoom	82.00
Founder	F2	29	Brazilian	Piracicaba, Brazil	NA	C-Level	Online - Zoom	28.15
Manager	M1	34	Irish	São Paulo, Brazil	June 2020	Customer Success	Online- Zoom	28.00
Manager	M2	28	Brazilian	Maringa, Brazil	January 2020	Product	Online - Teams	30.37
Manager	M3	37	Swedish	Travelling (Argentina)	November 2021	Sales	Online - Zoom	32.00
Employee	E1	26	Nigerian	Manchester, UK	September 2021	Customer Success	Online - Teams	29.12
Employee	E2	34	British	Barueri, Brazil	January 2019	Customer Success	Online - Zoom	31.16
Employee	E3	24	Brazilian	Coimbra, Portugal	August 2021	People and Culture	Online - Zoom	40.26

Employee	E4	30	Nigerian	Lagos, Nigeria	January 2021	Customer Success	Online - Zoom	36.42
Employee	E5	28	Brazilian	São Bernardo do Campo, Brazil	October 2020	Product	Online - Zoom	34.37
Employee	E6	21	Brazilian	São Paulo, Brazil	February 2022	Product	Online - Zoom	29.12
Employee	E7	31	Nigerian	Lagos, Nigeria	November 2021	People and Culture	Online - Zoom	32.15
Employee	E8	22	Nigerian	Lagos, Nigeria	September 2021	Marketing	Online - Zoom	29.53
Employee	E9	30	Argentinian	Buenos Aires, Argentina	February 2022	Marketing	Online - Zoom	30.15
Employee	E10	55	British	London, UK	April 2022	Sales	Online - Zoom	39.49

From all interviews, it was noticed that participants locations and workstations varied. Some had virtual backgrounds on while others were seen in locations varying from their bedrooms, living room spaces and home office spaces. All participants were very happy to have the online interviews as this is a work model they are used to. Due to time zone differences, some participants were happy to interview outside of their working hours but for others, the researcher had to make time at some odd hours.

Following Braun and Clarke (2012), we used a 6-phase approach to analyzing our data. Each phase highlighted the various elements in thematic analysis.

- Phase 1: Familiarizing yourself with the data

  In this phase, we tried to immerse ourselves in the data by reading, rereading and listening to all audio recordings. While reading, we also made notes of key elements and areas of interest to the research. Field notes were also compared at this point, especially notes where we described the participants of each interview and the roles each of them had to play in the research.

- Phase 2: Generating initial codes

  This is the stage where we started introducing the codes based on the data. Creating these codes helped us identify key elements that are relevant to our research question.

Although additional codes were included which also helped us in covering some aspects and loopholes found in the literature review. Our codes were created in different ways. In some cases, we picked out codes verbatim from our respondent's answers and in other cases, our codes were based on our interpretation of the data. We generated codes by reading the transcripts, adding to our codes and generating more codes as we kept reading. We used different colors on Microsoft word to highlight each code and differentiate between codes. At the end of each interview, we revisited our codes to ensure that all relevant data had been coded and that codes made sense to the researchers and to the research question.

- Phase 3: Searching for themes

  In this phase, we reviewed all the codes we had generated and ensured that some of them did not have overlapping meanings. While doing this, we tried to identify any broader topics related to the codes. In doing this, we noticed some key elements around codes. These elements were what we used in the creation of our themes and sub themes. In our data, we had wider themes that had to be split into various subthemes and in some other cases, simpler themes that stood alone. Additionally, we noticed that some of our codes were not sufficient to form a theme or that some of them did not necessarily fit into any of the themes. In these cases, we grouped them aside for a while and created a miscellaneous theme according to Braun and Clarke (2012). After a review of the data analysis and with a deeper understanding of our data, some of these codes either formed new themes, were added to previous themes or saved up which will be added to our recommendations and areas of future research.

- Phase 4: Reviewing potential themes

  After searching and generating our themes, we had to review them in relation to the codes we had initially generated. In this aspect, we tried to see if there was a connection between codes and the themes they were allocated. In some cases, we

had to move codes to different themes and in many cases, we had to question if our codes were relevant to the themes. In other cases, we checked our themes and the number of codes we had in them which raised the question of if the codes were enough to generate a theme.

- Phase 5: Defining and naming themes

  In our analysis, we decided to name our themes right from stages 3 and 4. This is because some of the theme names came naturally from the type of codes we had grouped. For some themes, we had to change the names numerous times after review. We changed some theme names because we did not want any confusion in relation to literature and concepts that have already been defined. For some of our sub teams, it seemed important to use some of the quotes from the data. Such quotes defined the essence of our themes in depth.

- Phase 6: Producing the report

  After ensuring that all our codes and themes have reached a certain level of quality and satisfaction, we began to design how we would write the report. In our case, we had two other sources of data that would be combined and triangulated, so we used the themes created from our interviews as a base for the analysis of our observation and secondary data. It is however important to note that these data sets stand alone, although having similar themes, we had some elements that stood out according to data type.

4.2.2 Observation Method Process of Data Analysis

As our observation took place purely virtually, we observed the company's general meetings held every Tuesday at 2pm EST, some departmental meetings that also occurred at specific times, slack interactions, interviews for recruitment and selection processes, and special

events held by the company once in a month. Our total observation time was 13 hours and 9 minutes.

Table 7

Sources of Observation

Observation source	Number of times observed
General meeting	3
Departmental meeting	3
External interviews	2
Special event	1

According to Kozinets (2015), analysis from netnographic data could either occur through hermeneutics or deep reading. In our case, we opted for deep reading especially from data gotten from our field notes and major occurrences during the observation period. To analyze our data, we used some aspects of thematic analysis while focusing on some steps in the 7 analytic steps outlined by Kozinets (2015). We skipped some steps as we found them a bit redundant for our data.

- Step 1: Imagining

  In this step, we focused on building on our reflective ideas. In this stage, we imagined the sort of data and themes we would get from the data. This was easy to do as the researcher had been submersed in the community and had firsthand experience in working in the company.

- Step 2: Re-memorying

  In this step, we tried to write down all the things we remembered during the field work. This was triggered by looking at the data again and adding elements that we remembered.

- Step 3: Abduction

According to Kozinets (2015), the main aim of this step is to find patterns or links within the data. In our case, we started looking out for patterns within the occurrences and comparing them with some of our codes and themes from the interviews.

- Step 7: Tournament play

  In our case, we skipped some of the steps as outlined by Kozinets (2015) and arrived at the final step 7. For step 7, we positioned all the ideas and got from the data and put them within themes that were developed from the data set or themes that we got from the interviews. This step took almost the same process as we went through during our qualitative data analysis.

4.2.3 Secondary Data Process of Data Analysis

Our sources for secondary data were: 1) vacancies posted online via LinkedIn; 2) the company's career page, employee data (starters and leavers) which was downloaded fortnightly for a period of 22 weeks, interview feedback from recruitment process, HR policies and HR communication digest. We used different ways to analyze these data. The starters and leavers report were more quantitative, so in this case we used an excel sheet to create formulas and pie charts. We started out by defining what we wanted from the data. For example, we wanted to know the average age of employees' year to data (YTD), average age of leavers and reasons for leaving in relation to their age and departments. All these questions were defined before delving into the data and creating the ways that the data could be visualized. For other data sources, we used the same way our observational data was analyzed and merged with some thematic analysis from the interviewees. Our major aim in analyzing this data was to see if there were any age norms or age norms elements in the documents. We looked through job vacancies to understand the language used. We also tried to relate this language of job posting to our interviews and some of the observations we had. Thus, major elements that we analyzed here were the language of use in various documents,

any inference to age norms, age preference or even age stereotypes. While reading and rereading the documents, we created and set aside codes that were meaningful to the objective. After setting aside numerous codes, we created themes from these codes and rechecked if the themes and the codes were correspondent. All the themes came from the data set, but we found that some themes were very similar to the themes that were gotten from the qualitative interview. In this case, we used similar themes from the interviews and maintained fresh themes from the secondary data set.

4.3 Founders' Interview Results

In this topic, we will delve into the findings derived from analyzing the interviews with the founders. Along with examining these findings, we will present and contrast the results obtained from observational data and secondary data. The aim of this section is to consolidate these findings and highlight the similarities and differences identified in these datasets. Through our thematic analysis of the founders' interviews, we identified four themes that will be elaborated upon below.

4.3.1 Theme 1: The Role of Culture in Organizational Age Norms

The concept of culture was prominent in this interview group. Based on the interviews with the founders, it was observed that organizational culture could either support or hinder age norms.

Culture as a facilitator: When culture serves as a facilitator, we observe that individuals within the organization derive pleasure from and partake in specific aspects of the organizational culture. These aspects of the organizational culture may pertain to age norms and the way age norms are created and shared within the organization. One of our founders, F1, characterized their organizational culture as "young and vibrant, or vibrant and exciting." Through this characterization, we discerned that some of the company's activities revolved around the interactions among team members and the types of activities that enthused them.

For instance, F1 mentioned that " People post different things about movies, music etc. We celebrate every little achievement and make everything a big deal. We play lots of games and have various happy hours for different themes activities.”

Throughout our observation, it became evident that departmental meetings consistently kicked off with engaging games and ice breakers. Moreover, general meetings were characterized by discussions revolving around movies and music. In each of the three general meetings we monitored, one of the founders consistently initiated the session with songs sourced from YouTube. Taylor Swift and Beyonce were among the artists whose songs were shared and appreciated by the employees. As the songs were being played, many employees expressed their fondness for the music and often shared personal anecdotes related to the songs. Notably, during these musical interludes in the general meetings, most employees actively participated by using emojis to convey their admiration for the songs or by engaging in the live chat with comments. Furthermore, it was observed that employees would suggest similar songs or recommend tracks to be featured in the upcoming meetings. During the brief moments dedicated to sharing songs, the discussions in the live chat predominantly revolved around entertainment and the music industry. At other times, conversations veered towards recounting experiences at concerts attended and encouraging colleagues to partake in such events to “feel the thrill”.

The comments exchanged during the general meeting had a casual tone, with employees using slang and abbreviations like "this is lit", "it is giving", "I stan", etc. Additionally, in line with the culture outlined by F1, we observed numerous employee accomplishments being shared on the company's internal slack channel. Birthdays and work anniversaries were publicly acknowledged, and there were posts about collecting animated figures from franchises like Star Wars, Marvel, South Park, and more. In November 2022, employees were encouraged to watch and celebrate the World Cup. F2 emphasized in his interview that the company's culture shapes their work environment and expectations. Therefore, it is expected that individuals who would thrive in this company are interested in these activities and expressions.

However, this same culture could be a hindrance for certain individuals, particularly those belonging to specific age groups.

Culture as a barrier: During the interview, the founders conveyed that their youthful and energetic culture might be perceived as a hindrance by certain individuals. F1 shared an incident where a candidate declined an offer due to their perception of the company's work culture. According to F1, the candidate expressed dissatisfaction with the fact that their potential supervisor lacked seriousness and that everyone seemed to be engaged in playful activities. This perception was based on the company's physical workspace before transitioning to remote work. When asked about the office location, F1 described it as somewhat informal, featuring amenities such as a hammock, popcorn maker, and a foosball table. F1 also mentioned that the candidate appeared disappointed with the atmosphere upon visiting the office. Subsequently, the candidate emailed the founder to express that the company's culture did not align with their preferences. In this case, the physical appearance of the company served as a representation of its culture and acted as a barrier for the candidate's interest in joining the organization. F1 emphasized that the decision to join the organization ultimately rested with the candidate and their acceptance of the organizational culture. According to the founder, " our culture consists of what we do and those that make up the team." Additionally, F1 noted that for some candidates he had encountered, age, either of the candidates themselves or the founders, could deter them from joining the organization. He mentions that “…if an older person does not want to report to a younger person, then here wouldn’t be a fit”.

4.3.2 Theme 2: Age Norms in the Organization

Age norms in the organization can be attributed to either beliefs and stereotypes or certain age norms practices prevalent in the industry and an organization itself. Our research on age norms beliefs and stereotypes revealed that age norms originate from various sources.

Age Norms Beliefs: We specifically examined the beliefs and stereotypes held by the founders, as well as those attributed to them by others. For instance, F1 shared that his parents did not believe he could successfully lead a 150-person company as its CEO. This perception stemmed from the prevailing belief that young individuals lack the ability to effectively manage a company. Additionally, F1 mentioned receiving occasional strange looks when introducing himself as a CEO in public. As a result, he altered his attire to project a more professional image that aligns with his position. Despite his preference for casual clothing like round neck t-shirts and shorts. These age norms stereotypes also influenced the founders' decisions during the early stages of recruitment and selection. F1 stated that “so, our major concern was having people that would take us seriously”. Consequently, the founders primarily hired individuals within their age range or younger, thereby establishing a specific age norms structure within the company. This structure was subsequently passed down to recruiters, who sometimes express concerns about the age of potential candidates and their fit within the organization's environment. F1 mentioned that “sometimes, the recruiters worry about the age of people and how they will fit in the environment”. In comparison to this data, when we analyzed the starters and leavers report got from the company fortnightly, we saw that the average age of employees’ year to date (YTD) was 30 years old. Additionally, we also calculated the average employee age during our period of data collection, and this was also 30 years. Although, this belief of having employees that “took them seriously” did not impede the company from hiring older workers. However, having older workers also came with stereotypes that we found also in the employee interviews. From a founder perspective, firstly, F1 had initial concerns that older workers would not respect him as their CEO. Secondly, when it came to fitting in the organization, both founders believed that younger workers had more fit in the organization.

F2 stated that “if I am to be honest, I would prefer people within the 25-35 at the maximum” while F1 says that “I think here, younger people tend to be better because they are more flexible to change”. The change in this case, as both founders described, is relating to the type

of industry of their business i.e. a tech startup. F2 mentioned that from a product department perspective, they always need people that would easily adapt to the changes in the environment especially when dealing with programming languages and technical abilities. F2 also stated that the company utilized a newer programming language, which could pose challenges for older employees who may struggle to adapt to it. F2 expressed a preference for younger workers, as they tend to have an easier time transitioning and adapting due to the fast-paced nature of the company. In F2's words he preferred "the younger ones for smoother transitioning and adaptation" and this is because "things moved pretty fast" in the company.

Age Norms Practices: Most of the age norms practices we found in our data are related to practices within the industry. When it comes to a tech startup environment, we find that most of the workers are generally young. F1 mentioned that in some tech environments, when it came to age, he found that they quite fitted in well. In most cases, when they went for startup tech competitions, they found many young people. For example, F1 says "…at that point, I was 23 and it seemed like a norm for the hackathons to have young people participate". In this case, we believe that practices relating to age norms would most likely come from the industry and what the industry proscribes.

4.3.3 Theme 3: The Origin of Organizational Age Norms

From some of the secondary data, we found that certain elements that F2 had mentioned were reiterated in the job postings. For example, F2 mentioned in some part of his interview that older workers are usually not flexible to change, and that they do not usually have the time to work in various time zones because of their family commitments. In the job posting, we saw that there is a desirability for those willing to work in different time zones.

From the founders' interview, we gained insight into the origins of age norms within the organization. The decision to hire younger employees stemmed from concerns the founders

had about how older workers would perceive and respect them in the organization. F1 explained, So, our major concern was having people that would take us seriously and automatically, we start to include the age aspect with this." While the founders never specified an age range preference in recruitment documents, they did occasionally discuss whether a candidate's age would align with the company's culture, especially if the candidate was significantly older. Some of the points mentioned by F2 in the interview were reflected in the job postings. For instance, F2 noted that older workers might struggle with adapting to change and balancing work with family commitments. This was mirrored in the job postings, which emphasized the importance of flexibility and willingness to work in different time zones. The company's career page also highlighted the need for candidates to embrace change and continuous learning, as well as previous experience in a startup, as desirable qualities. The page says, “our project changes as our company strategy evolves”, “we are always learning something new”. In the process of shortlisting candidates, F1 notes that even if candidates omit their ages from their resumes, they can discern their age based on their past experiences. Conversely, F2 contends that due to the founders' age, it is more favorable for the company to recruit individuals within the founders' age bracket or younger.

4.3.4 Theme 4: Age Norms Sanction

Age norms sanction is divided into positive sanction and negative sanction. However, there is limited information on what constitutes positive sanctions from our interviews. Although F2 mentions that internal promotion is one example of a positive sanction for individuals who conform to age norms and meet expectations such as adaptability to change, flexibility and knowledge of programming language as seen earlier. F2 also suggests that certain employees may outgrow these expectations as they age, get married, and start families. According to F2, individuals who are married and have children may struggle to meet job expectations such as working in different time zones or meeting deadlines outside of regular working hours. However, F2 fails to mention what the negative sanction would entail when certain individuals

do not meet these expectations. On the other hand, F1 states that older employees often leave the company due to a lack of culture fit. Interestingly, F1 reveals that he does not disclose his age in most client meetings, possibly due to the fear of violating age norms associated with his role as a CEO. F1 explains that people may have certain age expectations for someone in his position.

4.4 Managers' Interview Results

Within this topic, we will delve into the outcomes derived from analyzing the interviews conducted with managers. like the interviews with the founders, we will present and contrast findings from both observational and secondary data. Furthermore, we will combine these findings to examine any commonalities and differences across all data sources. Through our thematic analysis of the managers' interviews, we have identified three themes that will be thoroughly examined.

4.4.1 Theme 1: The Role of Culture in Age Norms

Like the founders' interview, we discovered that culture can either hinder or facilitate the formation and sharing of age norms.

Culture as a Facilitator: In terms of culture as a facilitator, the managers in the company actively embrace and contribute to the company's culture. When asked about the company's culture and what they appreciate about it, M1 expressed enthusiasm, stating, "I love the energy and flexibility we have. There's always something new to do, and that keeps me excited." Similarly, M3 mentioned enjoying the company's happy hours, games, and the practice of recognizing birthdays with a day off. These descriptions align with the founders' interview, reinforcing the importance of culture within the organization.

Furthermore, our observation of the company's Slack channel revealed numerous posts celebrating members' birthdays. These posts garnered many comments from colleagues, showcasing a sense of camaraderie and shared celebration. It is worth noting that the

managers, in addition to their departmental responsibilities, also play a crucial role in the recruitment and selection process. This role is vital for ensuring the alignment of candidates with the company's culture. During this process, managers assess various characteristics of potential candidates to determine their fit within the department and the overall company. M1 emphasized the importance of assessing if a candidate aligns with the company's activities and if they will actively participate, stating, "Do they fit in the company? In the things we do. Will they stay once they join us? Will they participate in some of our activities?" Similarly, M2 highlighted the significance of cultural fit, stating, "The first thing I look for is a similar culture fit... I check if this person aligns with the team." Interestingly, when we asked one of the founders to describe the company's culture, they mentioned it being "young and vibrant." This description resonates with the experiences shared by some of the managers. This description of the culture is also what some of the managers have used as a benchmark to hire some of their candidates. For example, M3 mentions that:

> I also look for young and driven people. From experience, the younger the better and this is because of the internal culture we have. Vibrant people will also be something to look out for. Although you tend to see this manifest more in the younger folks – M3

Likewise, M3 highlights the importance of technical skills and compatibility with the team. They mention that their team consists of young individuals, which means that older candidates may not fully grasp certain jokes. This indicates that cultural elements can serve as both facilitators and barriers. For instance, actively seeking and hiring younger employees can facilitate the integration of the team's culture. Conversely, the decision to hire or not hire older workers can potentially hinder the sharing of the team's culture.

Culture as a Barrier: It has been mentioned that culture can act as a hindrance, which contrasts with its role as a facilitator. Most of the shared cultural beliefs within certain age groups will most likely become a barrier for those that do not fit in these groups. For example, M1 shared that “sometimes they will play around during team meetings, some members get frustrated by

this. They want to get straight to the point. Sometimes even 1:1s, the teammates will express this immaturity of the leaders to me".

Upon reflection of the founders' interviews, commencing the company's general meeting with songs is favored by certain members of the company. It was noted during the fieldwork that not all members will show enthusiasm towards the songs or other general meeting activities, such as the quizzes conducted at the end of the meeting. During one instance of observation, 72 out of 98 members took part in the quiz during the general meeting. Furthermore, in the customer service meeting, only 14 out of 20 members participated in the Kahoot games.

4.4.2 Theme 2: Age Norms in the Organization

In a similar manner to the founders' interviews, age norms, beliefs and stereotypes were identified within the organization. Regrettably, the managers' interviews did not provide sufficient data on age norms practices. Within this dataset, it was evident that the managers' personal age norms beliefs often align with stereotypes. While it can be challenging for individuals to acknowledge holding stereotypes, their beliefs may inadvertently support such stereotypes. For instance, M2, the product manager, expressed the belief that individuals with extensive experience in a specific programming language may be less inclined to learn a new language like Java.

> People that work 20 years with PHP normally are those that are already married, have a family and will not have the time to keep studying and getting updated (on new programming languages). Those that change their programming language easily are the younger ones that just work and do not have any other fixed responsibilities - M2

Due to the company's fast-paced nature and tendency for changes, the manager prefers to recruit younger employees without "fixed responsibilities". M2 also highlighted her preference for hiring younger workers because "…the younger workers always want to discover something new and apply it to their work…they are more open to discovering new things". Conversely, older workers are "usually more comfortable with what they already know. They

do not want to create something new" – M2. Similarly, within the CS department, the specific job roles have resulted in the formation of stereotypes between older and younger employees. One of the key responsibilities of CS team members is to address customer queries via chat on the company's website. The team members' key performance indicators include the quality of chat responses and the average response time. M1, the CS Manager, provides a comparison between older and younger employees. M2 mentions that the older workers are slower than the younger workers. She describes further saying:

> I think the older workers are usually slower in their requests because they want to make sure everything is perfect. So, they take their time to read and re-read their responses to clients before sending. They are generally more focused on ensuring that the clients are happy and sometimes take their time to respond to these requests because they are gathering loads of information to support the requests. The younger ones usually jump right into it. Their response time is way faster…they focus on the average response time instead of the satisfaction – M2

During our observation of the CS department meeting, one of the managers emphasized the significance of maintaining a shorter average response time over client general satisfaction. According to her, when clients must wait for an extended period, their satisfaction level tends to decrease. Therefore, it is more important for the team to convey their immediate availability to the clients rather than the actual response given by team members. However, it should be noted that belief on average response time does not necessarily indicate a preference for younger workers over older workers in the CS team. Other factors, such as team leadership, may strongly suggest a preference for younger workers. In the CS department, the manager stated a preference for candidates who can be easily managed or "those that I think will fit the current team leader's capabilities", according to M2. When questioned further, she expressed a preference for candidates within the age range of the team leaders. The significant age gap among team members has led to some conflicts within the team. Despite the limited occurrence of conflicts within the team, M2 emphasized that:

> Yes, a lot of times, I feel like the conflict had to do with age. We've had 25-year-old team leaders that had to lead a team of people older than them. Sometimes because of their age, the team leader somehow acts immaturely towards some certain aspects of team management - M2

M1 referred to "the current team leader's capabilities" as the age element in conflict. This implies that younger team leaders can effectively manage individuals of their own age group or younger. Additionally, M3 highlighted the distinction between younger and older individuals in the sales department in terms of sales performance.

> Culturally, I think young people have been exposed to being able to talk to people from different walks of life. I'm not so young myself but when I get demos from younger people, I like how they go about it…For example, we used to do sales face to face, now people do it 100% online. You have to share your screen or mirror your phone with your computer. In our industry, you need someone that can think fast. Someone that is comfortable with our systems and when they sell this to others, you can tell how comfortable they are and how adaptable they have become with the system. This is what most of our clients want to see - M3

Apart from being comfortable and versatile, M3 additionally drew comparisons between younger and older employees in the sales environment. Initially, when it comes to recruiting team members, M3 typically seeks out individuals who are focused on achieving financial targets. According to M3, these individuals are usually money-driven and goal-oriented. A money-driven and goal-oriented individual is typically a good match for the sales department due to the commissions they receive on each sale. For instance, a salesperson, in addition to their base salary, earns a 10% uncapped commission on every sale. If the company sells its services for a minimum of 10,000USD, a salesperson earns 1,000USD on that minimum sale. According to M3, "A salesperson will prioritize their commission over their base pay," therefore, a successful salesperson is usually motivated by "an immediate financial plan or need," which implies that a stronger focus on money leads to more sales. Consequently, younger individuals are potentially more inclined to excel in sales. The reason for the success

of younger individuals, as per M3, is that "most older individuals simply seek a certain level of stability in terms of payment, as they already have their lives planned out and just want to ensure that their pay is sufficient to maintain their current lifestyle," whereas “in younger workers, you tend to see zeal, there is hunger in them. They are usually more motivated…a lot more ", M3 mentions.

4.4.3 Theme 3: The Role of Age Norms in the Organization

In this theme, we found that age norms play significant roles within the organization. Specifically, age norms have an impact on the hiring decisions, internal organizational conflict, and the intention to leave the organization (triggered personally or organizationally).

Hiring Decisions (espoused age norms): Upon reviewing interviews with the founders, it becomes evident that their experiences and beliefs regarding older and younger workers shaped their preference for hiring younger individuals. These beliefs served as a foundation for the recruitment and selection processes within the company. However, it is worth noting that managers may still choose to hire older workers on occasion, but there is a general preference for younger candidates. For instance, M3 highlights the importance of young and driven individuals, stating that "From experience, the younger the better, and this is because of the internal culture we have." Additionally, M2 emphasizes the significance of vibrant individuals during the hiring process.

In general, age norms exert a significant influence on various aspects of the organization, such as hiring decisions, internal conflicts, and individuals' intention to leave the organization. Additionally, M2 emphasized this point by stating, “Vibrant people will also be something to look out for. Although you tend to see this manifest more in the younger folks”. It is crucial to highlight the term "vibrant" used by one of the founders when describing the company culture. Similarly, M1, when it comes to hiring for the CS department, also tends to prefer younger workers. M1 mentioned that “age is an element I consider when hiring CS teammates or how

I think or understand that they will react to management". When we further inquired about this, M1 explained that besides having young CS team leaders, she believes that hiring younger workers would not pose any issues for the company. On the product side, due to the founders' choice of programming language, younger workers are likely to be preferred.

> Many times, this (choosing the right candidate) has an influence in age because people working with Java do not want to work with other languages. They just want Java. In this case, the age has a huge influence because older people do not want to change the programming languages they are already used to - M2

Conflict: Although we have not delved deeply into this topic, it is crucial for us to analyze it and make space for future research. Within this specific area, we discovered that conflict within the organization is intergenerational. Previous discussions have shed light on why the organization tends to favor hiring younger employees. Moreover, we observed that age-related norms have been unconsciously created within the organization, leading to intergenerational conflicts. Specifically, in the CS department, there have been instances of conflicts arising due to age differences among team members. M1 asserts that these conflicts primarily stem from young team leaders who struggle to effectively manage such situations. Additionally, M1 strongly believes that age plays a significant role in fueling conflicts within the team. "I feel like the conflict had to do with age. We've had 25-year-old team leaders that had to lead a team of people older than them. Sometimes because of their age, the team leader somehow acts immaturely towards some aspects of management". Likewise, M2 encountered a conflict with another manager in the company. In this instance, M2 was uncertain whether the lack of respect from the other manager was due to age or gender.

Intention to Leave the Organization: In this subtheme, we examine the factors influencing employees' decision to leave the organization. We investigate whether this decision, particularly in relation to age, is driven by personal factors or by the organizational structure and policies.

One of the primary factors contributing to managers' intention to leave is the issue of age compatibility within the company. Furthermore, there is a concern that the company may potentially outgrow its startup status. According to M2, "…I have been here for a few years and my age group is the same as leadership. If the company continues to mature, I will fit in, but if not…no". The manager perceives that her age is suitable for the company's present needs, however, she intends to leave due to no longer falling within the company's age range. Similarly, M3 does not envision the company as a place for aging, as she articulated. "There are some companies you can tell that you want to grow old with them or stay there with them but here I don't see that if I am being totally honest". The absence of this clear vision for the organization, as observed, can stem from various factors. Certain factors are rooted in the absence of enticing incentives that encourage employees to remain with the company for an extended period, such as pension and retirement plans. M2 highlighted the lack of retirement benefits as a contributing factor. "I am structuring myself outside the company to have my retirement, you know? I personally organize myself to have retirement". The absence of such perks offered by the company compels us to examine the inclination to leave, which may be instigated by the organizational framework or policies.

Initially, in our examination of secondary data (HR policies), we observed a dearth of documentation regarding retirement benefits or any strategies for the future of employees or an aging workforce. We did come across certain health insurance schemes that catered solely to the employees, yet it was noted that employees deemed them inadequate. Despite the existence of career advancement schemes within the company, we were unable to determine the duration for which these progression plans would be in effect. When inquired about the organization's retirement plans based on any observed policies, M2 indicated that... "to retire you have to stay at least 20 years and people are staying here for only 2 months". During our analysis of secondary data, it is crucial to mention that we discovered the average duration of employment for the team members is 11 months. Additionally, M3 sheds light on a more distinct understanding of the factors leading to employee departures.

> It (company) doesn't seem like a place to be for that long. At some point, you just get tired of doing the same thing over again. I don't think my team will grow more than it is. I also do not think I will get promoted more than I am already, not because I am not good at my job nut because there is no structure for it… - M3

M3 also believes that this "short term" structure and individual plan within the company is because of the company being a start-up "A startup environment will most likely remain as one".

4.5 Employees' Interview Results

Like the interviews carried out with the founders and managers, we will delve into the outcomes derived from analyzing the interviews with ten employees. Additionally, we will incorporate select findings from our secondary data and observations. The analysis of the employee interviews revealed three themes that will be discussed.

4.5.1 Theme 1: The Role of Culture in Organizational Age Norms

Culture as a Facilitator: Prior to joining an organization, employees may be influenced by the perceived culture from an external standpoint, which could impact their decision to accept a job offer. Once they are part of the organization, they become integrated into the beliefs and values of the culture. Through platforms like LinkedIn, other job posting sites, social media, and the company's career site, we can gain insights into the company's culture, particularly in relation to age. Some employees may even form opinions about the culture before joining. For instance, E1 based her decision to join the company on her observations of LinkedIn posts: "I checked out the company on LinkedIn and saw that they had a lot of young and vibrant employees, and it seemed like a fun culture". Furthermore, E1 says that:

> I saw pictures and videos of different people in the company with different themes. But it looked like a very young group you know, because the company is pretty much a startup…so most employees are not very old when they join… – E1

Similarly, E3 says “they (company) had many posts on social media and showed how active they (company) were…it felt like many young people were given a chance…” and E6 mentioned that “they (company employees) were young and lively…”. For E2 he was interested in joining the company based on the physical appearance he had seen. It is important to note that the same physical appearance is what potentially posed as a barrier to a candidate in our analysis of the founders’ interview. E2 mentioned “…there was a hammock, a popcorn maker and so many cool things. I initially thought to myself that damn, this is what it feels like to work in a tech environment”. Moreover, E2's decision to accept the job was also influenced by the age of the founders. E2 expressed that “they (founders) all looked like around the same age range; my age range, and then they talked about happy hours, activities and yearly summits that seemed like fun and all of that”.

Upon becoming a member of the organization, culture then begins to play a role in promoting and sharing of age norms. Additionally, we could highlight manifestations of culture through our observation and analysis of secondary data. E2 mentioned that he loved the way everyone dresses in the company and expressed admiration for the type of clothing everyone wore in the company. “I never liked dressing too formal so when I knew I could wear a t-shirt and trainers then I was good…”. Apart from the dress, many employees emphasized enjoying the happy hours, summits and activities that take place in the company.

When we inquired about the employees' perspectives on the company culture, E3 expressed their appreciation for the sense of unity within the organization. They mentioned enjoying the various activities, such as happy hours and game nights, that foster a strong bond among colleagues. Similarly, E5 highlighted their satisfaction with the company's fully remote setup, emphasizing their enjoyment of virtual social events like happy hours, team building activities, and summits. Additionally, E7 praised the teamwork culture within the company, specifically mentioning the positive impact of team building activities like happy hours. They also appreciated the synchronization of efforts among team members and the fact that remote work is embraced by all. From a marketing department perspective, E8 says “…I like our team building activities, I love our marketing team meetings…we also have happy hours…I like how

we banter on slack, and everyone is just being playful". Fortunately, we were able to witness firsthand the dynamics of the "banter on slack". By observing various activities that occurred after work hours, we discovered that while not all team members participated, there were regular attendees who engaged in conversations primarily centered around games, music, and other interests. Additionally, we observed that team members often shared pictures on slack, sparking numerous comments and discussions. This routine of sharing and interacting on slack, seemed to mark the beginning and end of each day within the company. Typically, many workers would characterize the organization as fostering a culture of togetherness; however, E3 describes the company as being multicultural, having "vibrantness" and being fast paced. Hence, any person who lacks interest in such a group of people is likely to view this culture as a hindrance to their participation and shared belief of any age-related norms present in the organization. From our secondary data, we confirmed that the company has hired at least 38 different nationalities.

Table 8

Employee Nationality YTD

Nationality	Number of Employees YTD
Argentinean	6
Australian	1
Austrian	1
Brazilian	125
British	5
Bulgarian	1
Colombian	8
Congolese	5
Costa Rican	1
Cuban	1
Ecuadorean	1
Egyptian	3
French	1
German	1
Ghanaian	4
Indian	2
Indonesian	8
Irish	2
Italian	2

Ivorian	1
Jamaican	1
Kenyan	2
Mexican	2
Nigerian	46
Pakistani	7
Peruvian	2
Portuguese	4
Russian	1
South African	10
Spanish	2
Swedish	1
Swiss	1
Tunisian	6
Turkish	1
Ukrainian	1
USA	7
Venezuelan	3
Zimbabwean	6
Unknown	35
Total YTD	317

Culture as a Barrier: We were able to highlight some employees that did not feel that the culture of the company was a facilitator to the sharing of age norms. For example, E10, who is one of the oldest employees, does not partake in any unnecessary activity. He says “I feel like sometimes, I just don’t want to participate because I already feel like I wouldn’t fit in. Additionally, the fast-paced culture within the company may pose a challenge for individuals belonging to certain age demographics. It is worth noting that there are stereotypes in place that suggest older individuals may struggle to thrive in such an environment. However, the organizational framework and policies are designed in a manner that ensures that individuals who are unable to acclimate to the fast-paced nature of the company are let go. E7 who works in HR mentions that “…they (founders) always say we don’t have time to put someone on a performance improvement plan. The company is very fast and if you can’t meet the pace then you go”. In our observation of one the departmental meetings, we noticed that the subject of performance appraisal was mentioned. In that meeting, the manager in charge of the meeting explained what the performance appraisal would be like. The manager also informed us that

employees lacking in performance could face disciplinary actions which could lead to the termination of the employees' contract with the company.

4.5.2 Theme 2: Age Norms Beliefs and Stereotype in the Organization

In this topic, we have consolidated age norms beliefs, and stereotypes. This approach was necessary as employees exhibited reluctance in acknowledging their possession of certain stereotypes towards specific groups of individuals. Consequently, we have categorized these beliefs and stereotypes into two distinct groups: one pertaining to older workers and the other concerning younger workers, which we have labelled as "work hard, play harder". "Work harder, play harder" is a phrase one of the employees said in the interview, during their description of younger workers.

Before delving into the subject matter, it is crucial to highlight that, as per the employees within the organization, older workers are individuals aged 30 years and above, whereas younger workers are defined as those who are below 29 years of age.

Older workers: According to the employees, there is the 'belief' that older workers are "less fun" and that they do not participate in any of the fun activities. Based on E2's report on the summit held at a coastal resort in Brazil, all company employees gathered for meetings, with the older employees exclusively participating in seminars and refraining from engaging in any additional recreational activities. "Oh yes, during the summit, there were some people that only partook in the official activities like seminars and all. After that, we never saw them in the pool and all" E2 mentioned. Furthermore, E3 says that "…maybe she is 40, I don't know but she acts like she is really old. She just has a way of not participating in most of our activities…". Although, E5 thinks that older workers are not "fun to hang out with"; they however are "really good at keeping schedules and doing their jobs to the fullest". Another reason why older workers may not be fun according to E6 is that "they are very serious; they take everything seriously like work which could be very "annoying". E3 also asserts that certain positions, such

as management roles, are more effectively carried out by older individuals. Similarly, E4 maintains that leadership roles should be assumed by individuals with a more advanced age due to their experience and maturity. “Older people are more experienced and know how to deal with situations, conflict, communication etc.”, E4 said.

On a positive side, employees believe that older workers tend to work harder because “they have a lot at stake. They also have a different work value”, E5 mentions. Furthermore, according to E7, the older workers are “more independent and do their work…they always strive to do more”. E9 also believes that older workers “always push to strive for more. They are constantly working and wanting to reach the highest form of achievement”. However, E10, who is one of the oldest workers in the company believes that while he wants to do his job, he is not allowed to it “well” due to his “old school way”. E10 who is a salesperson says that his colleagues and management say that his ways are old. “They keep telling me what I do is old school sales. They don’t trust that I can do it the way they would do it”, affirms E10.

Younger workers (work hard play harder): Younger workers in this organization, according to the analysis we carried out, form a majority in the organization. They are of the opinion that, while some roles like marketing are better off with younger workers, for some other roles like management, older workers will do a better job. E3 says in respect to this opinion that:

> For some other departments like marketing etc., they can get younger people because in this day and time, marketing is more creative, designing is more creative…they don’t need as much experience, but you just must be aware and in sync with what is going on in the world today – E3

Similarly, E7 believes that while the younger workers are creative, they lack certain management skills “They (younger workers) are creative and that’s fantastic. But when it comes to management skills, I cannot really vouch for them (younger workers)”.

Apart from being terrible at management roles, E4 believes that young people deal with conflict differently. E4 posits that “Well like I said, my team leader was very bad at conflict resolution

and communication because of her age and the age of those in her team". Furthermore, E4 believes that the lack of experience in managing conflict came from the age factor. E4 affirms that "I would say her (team leader) age and lack of experience and the lack of experience came from her age".

When it comes to experience in certain organizational elements, E4 further mentions that "most of the team leaders are too young for their roles. I won't say the owners are too young, but I will say maybe they (founders) should have got more experience in certain areas". Additionally, E5 mentioned that the younger workers do not typically go above what they are required to do "They do not want to do 101% or even 100%. Their 50% is good…". According to E5 "the younger ones typically do not put all their efforts in. They do the barest minimum and that's it. They don't have anything to lose". One could say the reason younger people have nothing to lose is because of the lack of responsibility that we have looked at from responses on older workers. For example, E4 mentions that:

> As a young graduate, you are probably still living with your parents. Most of my teammates live with their parents. They don't pay bills or must feed anyone. Their salary is very sufficient for them, no matter how small it is, because it is most likely their first jobs - E4

Furthermore, E5 mentioned that "…they work hard but because they are young and just starting life, they lack some responsibilities". However, apart from being good at creativity, younger workers have been said, according to E3, to be "chilled, relaxed and willing to learn and be flexible". Furthermore, E5 mentions that the younger workers are "good at interaction, team activities and happy hours".

One thing we noticed during our observation is that younger employees tended to collaborate more frequently in group settings. It was noted that they often joined impromptu meetings to work collectively. E7 also mentioned that "I think the younger ones like to work in groups. They prefer to work in a community. They chat, play around, do a bit of work, go on breaks, and come back...". E9 thus summarizes their findings on younger workers:

> I will say the positive is that they know what they are doing. They have different ways of getting the job done. On the other hand, they can be very lazy. They don't like to stay more than the required hours. They like to play around and then work. For example, if you have 8 hours in a day, they work for 4 or 3, they do the job well, but they play around a lot. I like that but sometimes I need more, and they don't really like to give more – E9

Table 9 displays a selection of the comparisons on older and younger workers that we gathered from our interviews.

Table 9

Comparison of Older and Younger Workers

Younger workers	**Older workers**
We (are) more fun.	A bit less fun.
The younger ones are more chilled, relaxed and willing to learn and be flexible.	The older workers are used to a certain standard…their work value is different.
Younger ones cannot take feedback properly. You have to thread carefully when you speak to them…	Older colleagues are very respectful…they are good leaders…they each by example.
The younger ones typically do not put all their effort in. They do the barest minimum and that's it. They don't have anything to lose.	I think older people tend to work harder because a lot is at stake. Their work value is different.
The younger guys are good at interaction, team activities and happy hours.	I think the opposite, they are not fun to hang out with.
They are terrible at doing the job, attending meetings on time and keeping to schedules.	They are good at keeping schedules and doing their jobs to the fullest.

4.5.3 Theme 3: The Role of Age Norms in the Organization

In this subject matter, we have identified four distinct subtopics that will be discussed in the subsequent sections. Based on our analysis, it has come to our attention that the established age norms within the organization exert a significant impact on various aspects such as the recruitment and selection procedures for potential candidates, the hiring decisions of recruiters and managers (as evidenced by the interviews conducted with managers), and the inclination

to depart from the organization. It is worth noting that this inclination to depart can be instigated either personally or due to the influence of organizational policies and structure.

Recruitment and Selection Process: When a job applicant submits their application, they often have already identified aspects of the company that attract them to the position. Even after receiving a job offer, candidates may still need to consider whether the company is a good fit for them. In the case of employees at the research company, we inquired about why they believed the organization suited them, and many responses were linked to the company's age norms and culture. While age norms were not explicitly mentioned by the respondents, we found that the organizational culture, which many cited as a determining factor, did seem to align with certain age norms discussed in theme. Additionally, some employees were drawn to the company based on the engaging conversations they had during their interviews. E3 mentioned that “we talked about lots of parties…this made me relax…I felt so easy and calm, and I felt like I belonged there”. When we delved deeper into the matter, E3 provided details about the hiring manager at that time, and the factor of age became relevant. E3 opined that if the manager had been slightly older, the conversation would have taken a different course. Additionally, E8 stated that her decision was solely influenced by her friend who was employed in the company. “She (friend) kept on yapping about how she was working remote…and had amazing colleagues…she told me about their activities etc.”, says E3.

Hiring Decisions: Even though this theme was previously discussed during the managers' interview analysis, it is crucial for us to reiterate it here as we have discovered additional evidence to reinforce its importance. E3, a recruiter, highlighted that as he progresses his candidates through the selection process, he pays attention to certain aspects. While age is not a determining factor in candidate rejection, he collaborates with other recruiters to assess whether certain candidates would be a good fit for the company. E3 says “Yes (when we asked if age matters), and this is because sometimes, I believe that if they are older, they may not fit into the team or they may have difficulty working in the team”. Additionally, E3 highlighted that

specific teams have established an internal standard, aiding recruiters in identifying the ideal candidates for those teams. “For example, the manager in sales is a bit older than everyone else so maybe if I am recruiting for her team that (age) wouldn’t be any problem…”, E3 added. This implies that older managers may be more adept at managing older team members, whereas younger managers may struggle with older candidates. Notably, the oldest employee in the company is part of the sales department, this could indicate that the age standard in relation to the sales manager's preference could potentially be a practice in the organization. Conversely, E3 pointed out the benefits of having older employees, noting that they bring valuable experience that is beneficial for management and leadership roles. However, E3 also acknowledged that some managers may feel uncomfortable supervising individuals with more experience than themselves. Consequently, E3 prefers to recommend older candidates for management positions, emphasizing the importance of this approach expressing that:

> I think for some roles, the management must be older because of the experience, and for some they have to be younger because of the mix of the team. For example, in sales, management and salespeople can be older because they have more experience and can sell the product to help the company move forward. When you get a young and new person in sales, maybe it will take a longer time for them to pick up the experience and then ramp up their sales to start making profit. Many times, the company cannot wait for the salesperson to pick up the experience, so they end up firing them. For some other departments like marketing etc., they can get younger people because in this day and time, marketing is more creative, designing is more creative, so you maybe do they don’t need a lot of experience, but you just must be aware and in sync with what is going on in the world today – E3

However, specific departments such as marketing may favor younger candidates because of the creativity that is required within the team. One question that arises is whether older workers are incapable of being creative. Another question that comes to mind is whether certain departments have age requirements. For instance, in our research, according to interview sources, we have observed a preference for younger workers in the marketing department

based on their creative abilities. On the other hand, older workers are preferred in the sales department due to their extensive sales experience. Additionally, we have noticed that younger workers are favored in customer service because of their quick response time to clients and their potential for internal leadership “capabilities” or preferences. In the product department, younger workers are preferred due to their adaptability to changes in the environment and their proficiency in various programming languages. However, it remains uncertain how other departments within the company view age preferences, and whether this preference is widespread across the industry.

Intention to Leave (Triggered Personally): Like the managers' interviews, it was observed that employees harbor personal reasons for wanting to leave the organization. Most of them expressed their intention to leave based on their age and whether they would still be a good fit for the organization in the future. A few employees mentioned their concern that their age might not align with the company's preference for hiring younger individuals. E4 said that “of course in the next five to ten years, I would not fit here anymore. Maybe sooner because they (company) will keep hiring Gen Z”. E6 shares a similar sentiment, primarily driven by the desire to avoid being bothersome, as the employees have labelled the older workers as bothersome. “I think maybe when I get to 30. Because I don’t want to be annoying to people maybe if they have younger people” – E6. The decision to depart is also influenced by the employees' belief that as they age, their needs will evolve, leading to a demand for additional benefits that the employer may not be able to meet. For example, E4 believes that:

> The company always hires younger people, so they don’t pay them much because young people have no responsibilities financially. As you get older, you start to cost more. So, every time there is a fresh person out there, they hire them and pay less money – E4

E4 continues to say that:

> As a young graduate, you are probably still living with your parents. Most of my teammates live with their parents. They don’t pay bills or feed anyone. Their salary is

> very sufficient for them, no matter how small it is, because it is most likely their first jobs – E4

Therefore, the employees believe that once they get to a stage where they start to have bills to pay, they would prefer to seek other opportunities outside of the company. According to E4, there are responsibilities such as buying a house which young people will usually not have to worry about.

> Either they fire me, or I leave, because I will soon start to ask for more money. Things have changed in my life now...I'm buying a house, I send money to my parents, help with my siblings' school fees and all that -E4

Similarly, E7 feels that they would also want to get married and have children. They believe that their role in the company will not help them focus on these plans. Furthermore, they believe that the current benefits they receive in the company do not give room for them to have dependents.

> … I work almost 24hours in a day due to different time zones and the fact that they expect you to be always available. I wouldn't be able to provide insurance for my kids when I have them. We have health insurance but it's not fantastic and they don't cover dependents. I believe this is a job or place for single people with no attachment – E7

Therefore, some employees want to leave at some point because they will get older and once this happens, the responsibilities that they have attached to the older people will start to manifest, and since the organization does not provide for such age group, there will be a misfit in the company.

Intention to Leave (Triggered by the Organization): The organizational policies, procedures, and structure may lead an employee to consider leaving. As a startup, there appears to be a lack of clear structure regarding the future roles of employees. For example, E7 from the Human Resources team says that the company has no plans for what will happen in 10 years. She further mentioned that "we have no plans to support our best workers when they get

older". Additionally, E7 posits that being a startup environment, it may be too early to start thinking about planning for older workers or any retirement plans. E7 therefore believes that many employees will not have the intention of staying in the company till they reach their retirement age. E7 postulates that "I highly doubt that people will want to retire here…We have no benefits that help with that. No pension or insurance that will help". In addition to the planning and benefits, E9 believes that when it comes to the structure, there are no plans for career progression in the company.

> I will want to be in a different place in the next two years...because I think after 3 years of working here, you just get stuck. I know there are one or two people that have been 3 years here, apart from the founders anyways. I don't see them doing anything more. They are doing the same job, having the same responsibilities and all. Nothing has changed for them, and I don't want that - E9

Furthermore, E2 is of the impression that logically, employees are generally young in a tech environment so there is the chance that in 10 years he will not remain in the company especially if the company chooses to remain within the startup parameters. E2 reflects: "What will happen to be in 10 years? Will I still be working here?". In the same thought, E2 believes that if the founders remain in the company, then there is a chance he will remain with them.

> On a second thought…I am around the same age with most people including the founders. I think I am older than them by just a few years. So, when their age does not fit anymore, I guess mine wouldn't fit anymore too – E2

There is a certain level of assurance that an employee will continually fit in with the organization when they believe their age aligns with those who founded the company.

From our analysis of the secondary data provided by the company. We compiled the following reasons employees left the company. We were able to secure this data because, when an employee chooses to leave the organization, the HR department carries out an exit interview where they get information regarding the exit of the individual. In this interview, feedback is also received and escalated to various departments or hierarchy. On the other hand, when an employee is dismissed, no exit interview is carried out. Through the exit interview, the

company is able to find out more information about the employee leaving and then categorize them into the following leaving reasons.

From data, we highlighted the various reasons for leaving the company and the company defined these reasons as below:

Leaving Reasons

- Career Change: This is when the employee decided to follow a different career path than what they were doing in the organization. For example, someone moving from customer service to pursuing a career in healthcare.
- Career Progression: This is when the employee has been offered a higher position than what they have in the organization. This could also signify an increase in compensation.
- Change of personal circumstance: This is when the employee has mentioned a change in their personal circumstance i.e. moving to a new location or life changing decisions that will no longer be a fit in the company.
- Dismissal: This is when the company initiates the dismissal. The company initiating dismissal could be a result of many factors such as redundancy, performance issues, cost reduction and others.
- Dissatisfaction: This is when the employee has categorically stated dissatisfaction as a reason for leaving. This could be dissatisfaction of contract, working hours, working model and so on.
- Monetary: In this case, the employee has stated money as a reason for their exit. This is when the employee mentions that better pay is the only reason they are leaving. In this case, the employee could be taking the same role or a less role with more pay in a different organization.
- Performance related: This is when the organization dismisses an individual purely based on their performance.

- Personal: In this case, the employee has chosen not to give a reason they are leaving. In most cases, personal could be related to conflicts faced within the organization. Although this cannot be proven, according to HR, most employees with personal reasons had certain issues within or with the organization.
- Redundancy: This is when the employee's role has been made redundant.
- Resigned: This is a general reason when the employee initiates the exit. However, this reason could be any ranging from personal, career progression or career change. There is no clear distinction here and HR is unable to give a certain reason for using this element.
- Unsuccessful probation: This is for employees that did not meet the requirements of their probation. They are usually dismissed within the first 3 months of their start date in the company.

Table 10

Employee Leaving Reasons

Reason for leaving	No of Employees	Percentage (%)
Career change	13	6%
Career progression	48	23%
Change of personal circumstance	5	2%
Dismissal	36	17%
Dissatisfaction	5	2%
Monetary	8	4%
Performance related	18	8%
Personal	17	8%
Redundancy	2	1%
Resigned	52	25%
Unsuccessful probation	8	4%

From the data of leavers, we find that 'resigned' and 'career progression' are the major reasons for leaving the organization. Both reasons could be because of age norms in the organization or the violation of them. However, there is not sufficient information from the company to determine this.

4.6 Data Triangulation and Consolidation

In this section, we aim to consolidate the information gathered from interviews, observations, and secondary sources. We will analyze and cross-reference all data to illustrate the connections between different data sets and identify any discrepancies that may exist.

4.6.1 Secondary Data

The company started in 2013, but we were only able to collect employee accurate data via a Human Resources Information System (HRIS) that was implemented in 2022. Therefore, the data presented below is only reliable from 2022 onwards. The HRIS utilized by the company is BreatheHR (https://www.breathehr.com).

Based on company records, a total of 317 individuals (including the founders) were hired between 2018 and May 2023, while 212 individuals either left the company or were terminated. As of May 2023, there were 104 employees in the company. Throughout our field research and observation period, we also managed to determine the overall number of starters (new hires) in the company.

Table 11

Total Number of Starters from January 2023 to May 2023

Employee Age Bracket	Number of Employees	Percentage (%)
0-25 years old	1	11%
26-30 years old	2	22%
31-35 years old	3	33%
36-40 years old	0	0%
41-45 years old	1	11%
46-50 years old	0	0%
51+ years old	0	0%
Unknown	2	22%

During our field and observation period, we also conducted an analysis on the number of individuals who left the company (leavers).

Table 12

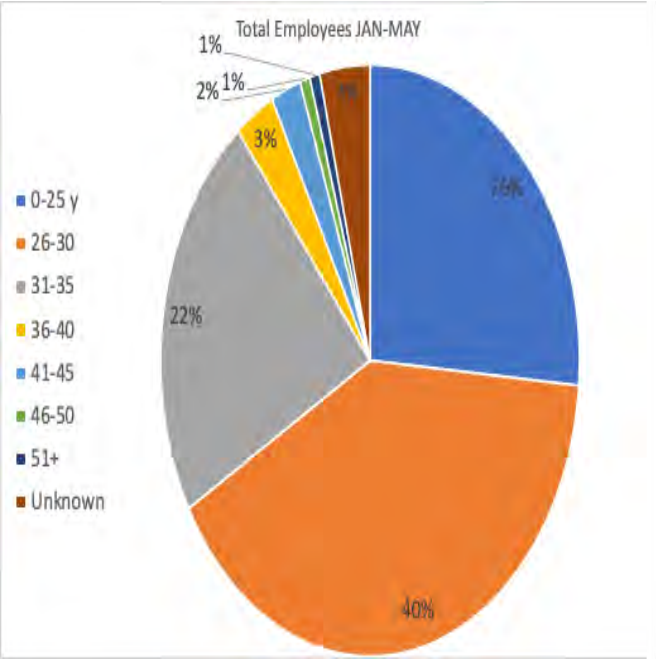
Total Number of Leavers from January 2023 to May 2023

Employee Age Bracket	Number of Employees	Percentage (%)
0-25 years old	5	20%
26-30 years old	11	44%
31-35 years old	5	20%
36-40 years old	1	4%
41-45 years old	1	4%
46-50 years old	1	4%
51+ years old	1	4%
Unknown	0	0%

From January 2023 to May 2023, the company recorded a total number of 129 employees. We categorized these employees based on their age groups. Figure 4 showing the age groups of employees from January 2023 to May 2023.

Figure 4

Age Groups of Employees from January 2023 to May 2023



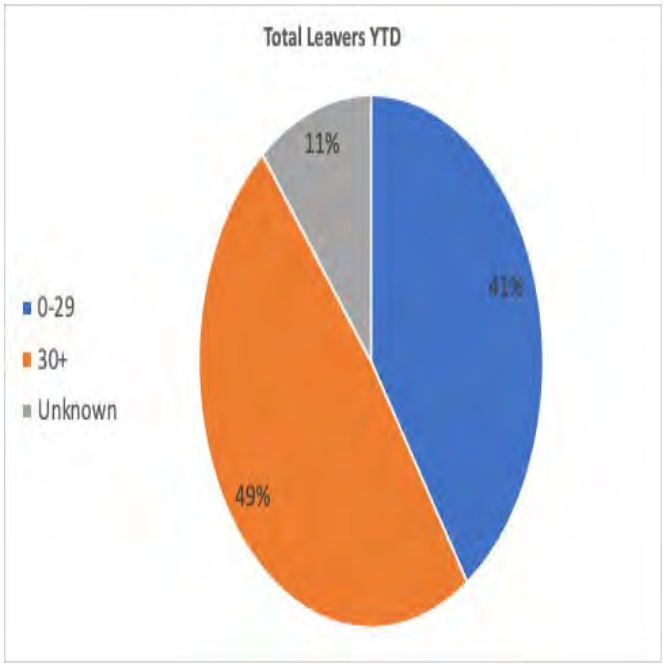
Source: Elaborated by authors through secondary data.

Based on the feedback received, the company categorizes its employees into two groups: older workers (30+) and younger workers 29 and under. The youngest person ever hired by the company was 20 years old, while the oldest was 55 years old.

We demonstrated the percentage of employees leaving the company based on two age groups: older workers (30+) and younger workers (0+). It is evident that older workers have a slightly higher rate of leaving the company. Figure 5 therefore shows the percentage of leavers according to their age range.

Figure 5

Percentage of Leavers According to the Age Ranges



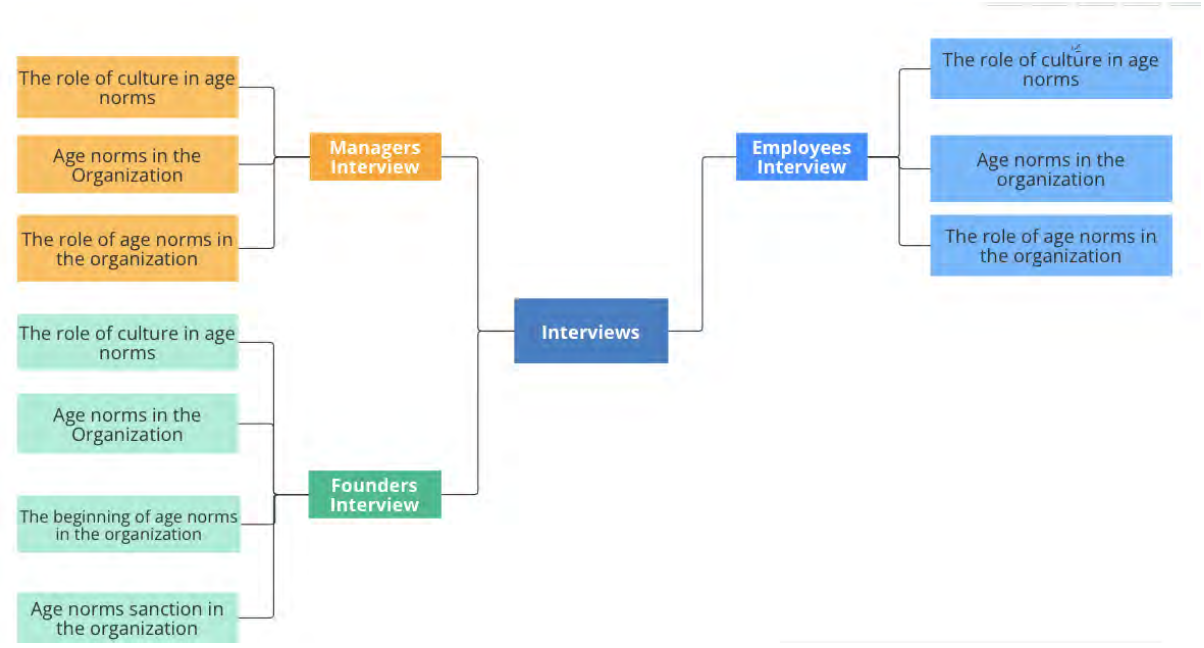
Source: Elaborated by authors through secondary data.

Interviews, Observation and Secondary data

Figure 6 shows the themes derived from our analysis of the data obtained through interviews. Additionally, we have incorporated certain sub-themes that emerged from the secondary data and observation. The figure clearly illustrates the presence of consistent themes across all interview groups, suggesting their persistent and prominent nature within the organization.

Figure6

Themes Derived from all Data Sources



The influence of culture on age norms was evident across all three interview groups. Culture was perceived differently, either as a facilitator or a barrier to the establishment and dissemination of age norms within the organization. Our analysis revealed that when culture serves as a facilitator, it can impact the decision-making process for external candidates' consideration to joining the company. Once onboard, this same culture, acting as a facilitator, plays a crucial role in fostering the sharing of age norms among organization members. Conversely, when culture acts as a barrier, it creates a reluctance to join the organization. While in some instances, this barrier may not deter candidates from joining, it does affect their willingness to embrace the culture and may eventually lead to their departure due to a lack of cultural alignment. Throughout our observation, we identified instances where culture acted as a facilitator. We had the opportunity to witness various organizational activities that incorporated age norms. Events such as happy hours and extracurricular activities were particularly popular among younger employees. Additionally, we noted the use of specific jargon, humor, and recurring stories within the organization. One such story revolved around how the founders met and established the company, often highlighting their young ages at the

time. We also observed shared interests among employees, with some interests being introduced by one individual and adopted by others. It was evident that not all members of the organization actively participated in these activities, but the general and departmental meetings tended to attract the older audience and a much larger attendance in general. Figure 7 illustrates the theme of "the role of culture in age norms" and the corresponding sub-themes identified.

Figure 7

The Role of Culture in Age Norms



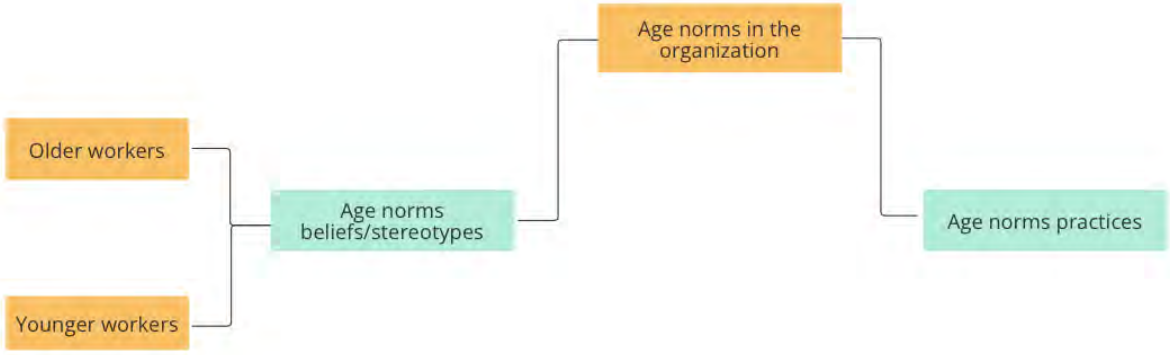
Source: Elaborated by authors through interviews

We categorized age norms in the organization into beliefs/stereotypes and practices. Combining beliefs and stereotypes was necessary as interview respondents did not openly acknowledge holding stereotypes about specific age groups. Through our research, we identified perceived differences between older and younger workers in the organization. According to the interviewees, older workers were typically aged 30 and above, while younger workers were aged 29 and under. Regarding age norms practices, our interviews did not yield substantial evidence. However, founders' interviews suggested that industry-specific age norms practices may exist. Unfortunately, we could not find sufficient secondary data to

support age norms practices within the organization. Figure 8 illustrates the theme of age norms in the organization and the derived sub-themes.

Figure 8

Age Norms in the Organization

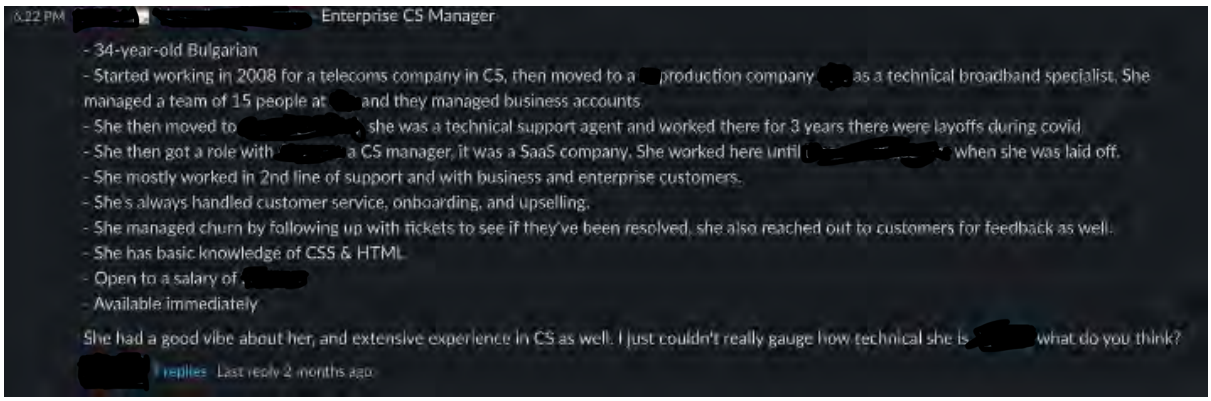


Source: Elaborated by authors through interviews.

The Origin of Age Norms in the Organization: We specifically created this theme for the founder's interview because according to Schein (1990, 2004), who stated that company founders are instrumental in initiating organizational culture based on their personal experiences and values. Our research also revealed that the establishment of age norms within this company originated primarily from the founders and their personal experiences with age-related issues. However, we also observed that managers and recruiters played a role in perpetuating these age norms. Upon analyzing secondary data, we discovered that age could influence the decision-making process when hiring a candidate. It was noted that recruiters often included the age of an applicant in their feedback following an interview with an external candidate. As seen in figure 9, feedback from a recruiter clearly indicating the age of an applicant.

Figure 9

Applicant Feedback

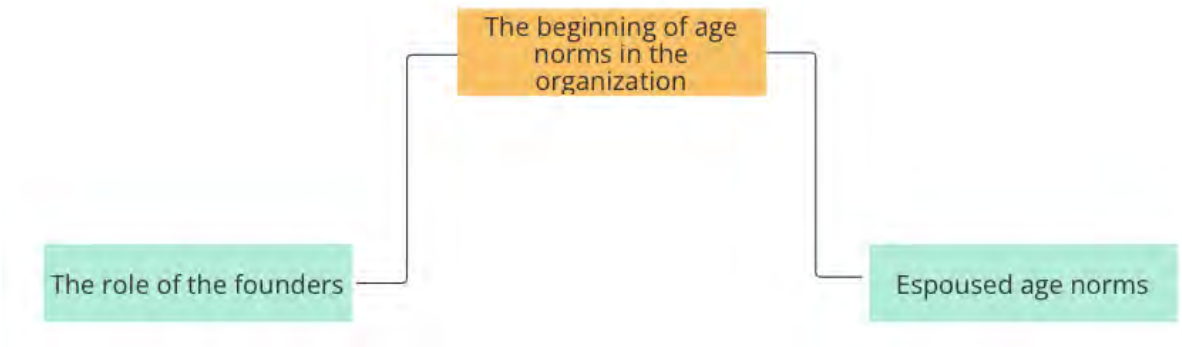


Source: Source: Elaborated by authors through secondary data.

Henceforth, we incorporate in figure 10, the subtheme pertaining to the involvement of managers and recruiters in upholding the age norms established by the founders. Figure 10 illustrates the concept of the initiation of age norms.

Figure 10

The Origin of Age Norms



Source: Elaborated by authors through interviews.

Age norms sanctions in the organization: In this topic, we have only identified instances of positive sanctions. According to the literature, age norms can lead to either positive or negative sanctions. Violating certain norms may result in negative sanctions being imposed. Our study did not definitively determine whether the negative sanction for age norms would result in employee dismissal. Upon examining the reasons for employee departures, we were unable to confirm whether dismissals or personal reasons for leaving were due to violations of age norms. While our interviews revealed that employees may choose to leave if they feel their age no longer aligns with the organization, this alone does not provide sufficient evidence of negative sanctions stemming from age norm violations. Figure 11 illustrates the sanctions related to age norms within the organization.

Figure 11

Age Norms Sanctions in the Organization



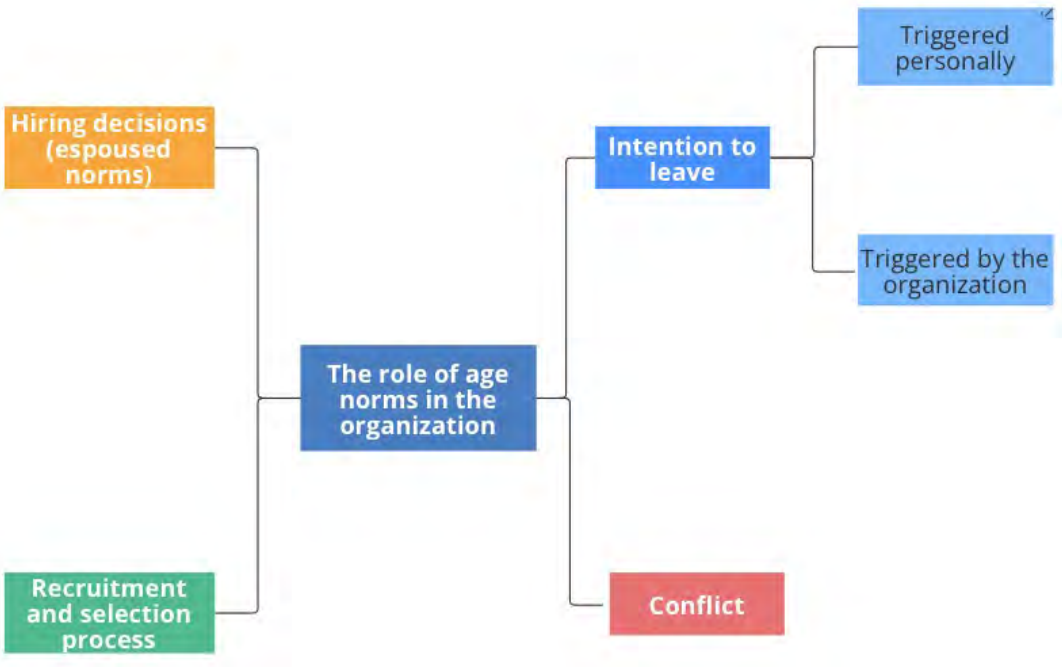
Source: Elaborated by authors through interviews.

The role of age norms in the organization: The data analysis revealed the diverse roles that age norms play within the organization. The company utilizes external channels to communicate their age norms to potential employees. When making hiring decisions, managers and recruiters must consider whether the organization's age norms will influence

the selection of the right candidate. Consequently, employees are assigned specific roles and responsibilities based on age norms. The way in which these employees fulfil their roles and responsibilities is influenced, to some extent, by certain age norms beliefs. Conflict within the organization arises from the differing approaches individuals take in handling their roles and responsibilities. Ultimately, an employee's decision to leave or remain with the organization may be influenced by their adherence to age norms and the organization's structure and policies. The decision to leave the organization, as indicated by our data analysis, may be linked to perceptions of age norms. Figure 12 showing the role that age norms play in the organization.

Figure12

The Role of Age Norms in the Organization

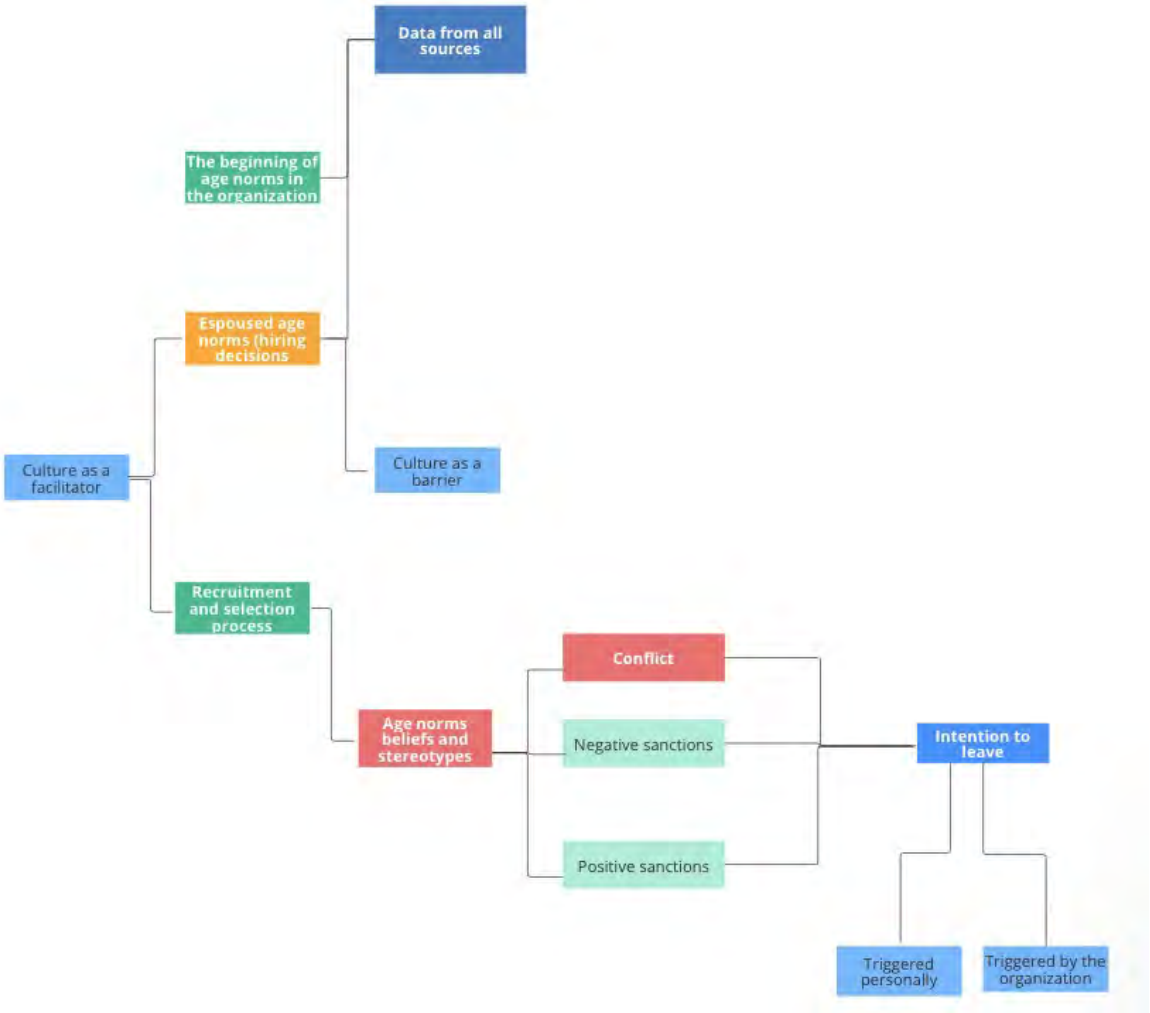


Source: Elaborated by authors through interviews.

To summarize, our data indicates that age norms are created by the founders of an organization and ingrained in the organizational culture. These age norms are then embraced and shared by managers and members of the human resources team as part of the company's culture. An external candidate may perceive (subconsciously or unknowingly), these age norms either as a cultural facilitator or as a barrier. If the age norms culture does not discourage joining the organization, individuals become part of the team and can choose whether to adhere to these age norms or not. As these age norms and beliefs hold significant importance within the organization, employees develop more beliefs and stereotypes concerning the organization’s age norms. Employees then act out and share these beliefs and stereotypes subconsciously. Conversely, age norm practices can also be established. Age norms will then have an impact in other areas within the organization, which may result in conflicts or a sense of belonging. Eventually, due to negative consequences, misalignment with age norms, or violations, employees may develop the intention to leave the company. The intention to leave the organization can be influenced by the organization's age norm practices, policies, and structure, or by personal opinions regarding the age norms adopted by the organization. Figure 13 showing a mind map of how the conclusion from our data sources was derived.

Figure 13

Mind Map of how this Conclusion was Derived



Source: Elaborated by authors.

4.7 Discussion

In this topic, we will discuss our findings with the literature. We will also introduce additional literature that emerged from our data themes. Furthermore, we will include our reflections as part of our discussion.

4.7.1 The Role of Culture in Organizational Age Norms

4.7.1.1 Culture as a Facilitator. In this section, we refer to the literature by Martin (2002), who suggests that cultural manifestations can be used to study culture. These manifestations of culture can offer insights into the thoughts, beliefs, and actions of employees. According to Martin (2002), cultural manifestations encompass cultural forms, informal practices, formal practices, and content themes.

Cultural forms: As described by Martin (2002), include rituals, organizational stories, jargon, organizational humor, and physical arrangements. These cultural forms were extensively studied until the 1980s, when researchers realized the importance of studying them. Today, we examine aspects of these cultural forms and how they influence the establishment and sharing of organizational age norms, both as barriers and facilitators. Other rituals within the organization, such as celebrating birthdays and achievements publicly, were identified through interviews and secondary data. Furthermore, according to Martin (2002), there are two types of jargon found in an organization. The technical and emotional. While the technical is related to the tasks of the organization, the emotional one, as the word implies, is more inclined towards feelings. During the general meetings, we observed many of these organizational technical jargons such as B2B clients, the use of the word latency instead of delay, backend, host and many more. Additionally, we identified some emotional jargon such as the nicknames they give to members of a particular department and the names of individuals that ranked high in their weekly quiz. The technical ones were a bit difficult to understand while the emotional ones were more relatable. One other manifestation of culture we found was the physical arrangements. We found that when the company had a physical office, one candidate

according to the founder, did not like or agree with the physical arrangement of the company. On the other hand, although now a virtual environment, we found that each employee's physical arrangement was relatively like the other. Apart from their physical arrangement, we found that most employees dressed the same way. During the general meetings, we could do a comparison of what the physical arrangements of the founder was like. We also noticed their dress code was a bit on the informal side. Furthermore, all employees are familiar with the organizational story surrounding the company's founding and the story has elements of the characteristics of an organizational story as postulated by Martin (2002). In our research organization, we discovered that there are specific rituals with clear beginnings and endings, where each member plays a designated role (Martin, 2002). During our observation, we noted that employees engage in a monthly ritual to officially welcome new hires to the company. These new hires, who joined the organization three months prior, gather as a group to organize an activity or virtual event that all members must attend. In one instance, the challenge involved dressing up as anime characters due to the common interests of the new starters. While attendance is mandatory for all members, we observed that some individuals choose not to participate. Additionally, the Tuesday general meeting, although somewhat formal, is often preceded by music played by one of the founders.

Formal practices and Informal Practices: According to Martin (2002), informal practices are through individual interactions and are not written down. They focus more on social rules which are not written as this could result in inconsistencies between what is formally required and what goes on. Based on some of the informal practices such as recruitment and selection choices, we found that such informal practices could either facilitate or be a barrier to age norms. On the other hand, formal practices include pay schemes, hierarchies/reporting structures. Formal practices are those written and easily controlled by management. In our research we were unable to find any organizational practices that were directly related to age norms. However, we were able to find that some of the written down policies had no

preparation for the retirement of employees. According to Skuciene and Moskvina (2019), it is argued that most companies are not willing to elaborate on the encouragement of older workers to continue in the company. The retention of older workers is also based on the organization and the type of goals they have (Karpinska et al., 2013). As a startup, we start to wonder about the sort of goals the organization has in terms of keeping or retaining workers that pass a certain age range and if this is the reason there are no formal policies to address this issue.

Content themes: Espoused and inferred: According to Martin (2002), a content theme refers to a thread of concern that focuses on the interpretations of several cultural manifestations. These content themes can either be cognitive (beliefs, assumptions) or attitudinal (values). Most times, these themes are espoused and on other occasions they are inferred by an employee or even a researcher. While the espoused themes are most times superficial, the inferred ones are more focused on bringing out a deeper level of interpretation. Nevertheless, these espoused themes are most times used as an attempt to influence an organization’s reputation. These content themes can either be shared consciously or inferred deductively. This could be because of what people do, how they interpret their surroundings. In the case of our research, we find that employees, depending on their age group, interpret their surroundings differently. The younger workers find their culture more enjoyable and share it while the other ones potentially find the culture and the surroundings as a barrier.

When examining the organizational culture through the lens of employees, it is evident that a significant portion of them found the culture appealing prior to joining the organization. Organizational attractiveness, as defined by Aiman-Smith et al. (2001), refers to the attitude or general sentiment that an individual holds towards an organization. The process of attraction involves a job seeker's assessment of how well their personal needs and values align with the organization's culture (Catanzaro et al., 2010). The organization's recruitment and selection procedures demonstrate that this attraction plays a crucial role in the attraction, selection, and even attrition cycle. If the organization's culture transitions from being a

facilitator to a barrier, the lack of attraction may result in attrition (Schneider et al., 1995). Organizational culture, values and norms significantly impact the likelihood of applicants accepting a job offer from the organization and influences their tenure within the organization post-hiring (Schneider et al., 1995).

4.7.1.2 Culture as a Barrier. When it comes to the sharing of these organizational culture or age norms, Martin (2002) introduces a perspective on organizational culture called the fragmentation perspective. This perfective differs from the integration and differentiation perspective by focusing on the inherent ambiguity and fluidity within organizational cultures (see Martin, 2002). According to Martin (2002), the fragmentation perspective states that there is pervasive ambiguity and the lack of clarity within organizational culture. Furthermore, this perspective emphasizes that relationships and cultural expressions can shift rapidly depending on the situation. For example, in our research we found that relationships between employees and the shared culture change from time to time. Furthermore, according to Martin (2002), organizational events and symbols can have multiple often conflicting interpretations simultaneously. When we look at the role that culture plays in our organization of research, we find that the cultural manifestations in the organization played multiple roles. These manifestations of culture either stood as a barrier or a facilitator to the sharing of age norms. The organizational culture in this instance acted as an obstacle to an individual seeking to join the organization. Prospective employees typically base their decision to join an organization on the perceived organizational culture and values. Research by Judge and Cable (1997), examining the link between organizational culture and an individual's attraction to an organization revealed that job seekers are more drawn to organizations that are seen to possess a similar culture or values that align with their personal requirements and preferences. In the context of our organization, its culture, age norms, or values could pose a potential barrier to those looking to join, particularly if there is a perceived mismatch. Furthermore, considering the candidate's perspective, it is possible that our research CEO violated the age norm the candidate had of who or what founders should be. As indicated in the literature

review, Lawrence (2004) suggests that specific circumstances can shape an individual's perception of age norms in relation to certain professional positions. Lawrence (2004) provides an example of the surprise experienced by some individuals when they encounter a young CEO. In the case of our company of research, the said candidate's behavior and decision to join the company was most likely influenced by the age norms the candidate holds concerning the role of a founder, and the potential violation by our founder, of that norm.

4.7.2 Age Norms Beliefs/Stereotypes and Practices in the Organization

Age Norms Beliefs and Stereotypes: As earlier mentioned, Lawrence (2004) cited the surprise people get when they see a young CEO. Furthermore, following F1s decision to change his attire, Issacson (2011), in his paper gave an example of Steve Job's image not fitting those that started a company. According to Issacson (2011), Steve Jobs did not look like "a serious businessperson". Although Issacson draws on image norms, we posit that age norms create certain stereotypes as we have seen from our research.

We find that younger workers are often perceived as more proficient with new technologies and innovative thinking (Posthuma & Campion, 2009). It has also been observed that older employees are often seen as having reduced motivation and ability to acquire new knowledge and skills (Posthuma & Campion, 2009). This stereotype is also supported by research indicating that younger workers tend to be more comfortable with technology and are often at the forefront of adopting new digital tools (Deal et al., 2010). We also find that younger workers were seen as inexperienced when it came to certain roles and responsibilities despite their said technological savviness. According to Finkelstein et al., (2013), younger workers most of the time face certain judgments when it comes to their competency and reliability. We also found this to be true concerning some of the comments we got from employees about younger workers. On the contrary, when it comes to experience, our research showed that the older workers are seen as more experienced in management and leadership roles. Posthuma and Campion (2009) in their research also show that the older workers are seen as sources of

institutional knowledge and there is an expectation for them to guide the younger employees. Unfortunately, in our research company, we found that the employees complained about not having management that were experienced in certain responsibilities. Furthermore, one reason why the younger ones were preferred in the company of research is due to their flexibility and adaptability to change, according to Rosen and Jerdee (1976), a common stereotype for older workers is that they are resistant to change and less willing to learn new skills. As a result of this resistance, older workers are less likely to be involved in innovative projects or roles that involve swift reactions (Rosen & Jerdee, 1976). However, the research conducted by Ng and Feldman (2012) challenges these notions regarding older workers. Ng and Feldman (2012) investigated six age stereotypes, which imply that older workers are (a) less motivated, (b) less inclined to engage in training and career development, (c) more resistant and less open to change, (d) less trusting, (e) less healthy, and (f) more susceptible to work-family imbalance (Ng & Feldman, 2012). Contrary to these stereotypes, Ng and Feldman (2012) research demonstrates that there is no empirical evidence to support the claim that older workers lack motivation and consistency. In fact, our evidence reveals that younger workers are perceived as less motivated, while older workers exhibit a strong motivation to fulfil their job responsibilities. Additionally, Ng and Feldman (2012) find that the negative stereotype of older workers being resistant to change is not consistent with empirical findings. From our research, this stereotype of resistance to change by older workers hindered the product team from considering older workers for employment. The company posits that older workers would struggle to adapt to the organization's programming language. Likewise, Ng and Feldman (2012) also discover that age has a weak correlation with work-family balance. Our research indicates that our organization holds stereotypes suggesting that older workers may not fully commit to the organization due to their family obligations. Shore et al. (2009) argues that age norms beliefs, and stereotypes can significantly impact organizational culture. Our research thus supports this argument. Age norms beliefs, and stereotypes have permeated our research company’s organizational culture, potentially influencing various factors, including employees' willingness to leave the organization.

Age Norms Practices: Our research did not yield sufficient evidence regarding age norms practices within the organization. However, Karpinska et al. (2013) argue that age-related norms do impact the practices of top managers in terms of recruitment and selection. Additionally, Karpinska et al. suggest that the organizational context can influence age norms practices. For instance, the nature of work within an organization may be perceived as more suitable for either younger or older workers, and managers may show preference towards certain groups based on the existing level of age diversity within their organization as seen in our data evidence. We have observed a tendency in startup environments to hire younger workers for various reasons. We have found that the company prefers to hire younger workers due to their perceived innovation and creativity, their willingness to accept lower salaries, and the cultural values that the company has fostered. Literature indicates that startups offer a flexible work environment, including flexible workplace and schedule arrangements. Startups are known for having a more relaxed office space compared to traditional businesses, they also boast of flexible dress codes and even more recently, remote work. Startups aim to provide their employees with the freedom to work in the most conducive environment possible (Gurianova, 2017).

4.7.3 The Origin of Age Norms

According to Schein (2004), culture is created because of interactions we have with others during our day-to-day life. Furthermore, Schein (2004) argues that culture is built from past experiences and the encounters we face with people and experiences.

Age plays a crucial role in the creation of culture and as we have seen, the age of the founders played a role in how the organizational culture is structured. While Lawrence (1996a) argues that there are different age norms for different social spheres, we see from our research that the age norms that have been created in the organization in question is because of the

environment the company is in, and also the age of the founders. The development of age norms within organizations is a complex process influenced by various social, cultural, and organizational factors. Literature provides a framework for understanding how these norms emerge and become institutionalized within organizational contexts. According to Posthuma and Campion (2009), broader societal stereotypes about different age groups play a significant role in shaping age norms in organizations. Societal views on aging, productivity, and the perceived capabilities of different age groups are often reflected within organizational settings (Posthuma & Campion, 2009). Furthermore, according to social identity theory, employees categorize themselves and others into groups based on age. This categorization leads to in-group (same age range) and out-group (different age range) dynamics, which influence interactions and reinforce age norms (Tajfel & Turner, 1986). As we have seen from our data, the founders were only interested in working with people in their age group or those younger than them due to their personal experiences and beliefs. This contributed to the creation of the age norms they had in the company. Schein (1990) posits that founders and leaders play a crucial role in shaping the initial culture of an organization. Their beliefs, values, and assumptions strongly influence the emerging culture. Founders set the tone for what is valued within the organization through their behaviour and decisions (Schein, 1983). This is also related to the belief they have surrounding age norms. Their experiences and challenges are what help solidify their cultural assumptions and how they reinforce these beliefs in the organization (Schein, 1990). Furthermore, through managers, such beliefs are reinforced. Managers serve as role models that embody the values and assumptions that the founders have put in place (Schein, 2010). As we see, the managers in our research company carry on the age norms set by the founders. They also share in the values and beliefs that the founders have created in relation to age norms. Through these espoused age norms by leadership, we can then find these norms documented in organizational practices such as recruitment and selection and sometimes, corporate philosophies. After this, there is thus the socialization process where new members are socialized into this belief through formal and informal

training. Schein (2004) further mentions that daily interactions also help this process perpetuate the existing culture and, in this case, organizational age norms.

4.7.4 Age Norms Sanctions

4.7.4.1 Positive Sanctions and Negative Sanctions. According to Lawrence (1996a), individuals that violated their age-related norms could be punished. On the other hand, age norms sanctions could either be positive or negative. For example, Lawrence (1996a) mentions that individuals that are perceived as being further in their career schedule may receive higher evaluations than those perceived to be behind. From our data, we did not find any negative sanctions relating to the violation of age norms. We, however, do posit that violating age norms within our organization of study could potentially lead to the individual leaving the company. On the other hand, we were able to find minimal finding on the positive sanction of age norms which includes promotion as cited by one of our founders.

4.7.5 The Role of Age Norms in the Organization

Hiring decision: Our study can make a valuable contribution to the existing body of literature that highlights the impact of age norms on hiring decisions. As noted by Karpinska et al. (2013), there are three key factors that play a role in the recruitment process: organizational characteristics, manager attributes, and applicant attributes. While previous research suggests that age norms and stereotypes play a significant role in hiring choices, we were unable to find sufficient empirical support for this claim. However, our research demonstrates that age norms do indeed factor into hiring decisions through the three intertwined elements identified by Karpinska et al. (2013). Our findings indicate that organizational characteristics, including organizational culture and age norms, influence how managers make hiring decisions. Additionally, manager attributes such as beliefs and stereotypes related to age, preferences, and work models impact the selection and preference of employees based on age. Moreover, applicant attributes, such as their age and the stereotypes related to flexibility, adaptability, and motivation of older workers, also play a role in organizational hiring decisions.

Conflict: Yeung et al (2015) in their article "Managing Conflict at Work: Comparison Between Younger and Older Managerial Employees" explore the conflict management strategies employed by managers of different age groups. The study specifically investigates how older and younger workers handle conflicts in the workplace. The researchers discovered that older and younger managers adopt distinct conflict management approaches. They concluded that older managers tend to prioritize cooperative goals and strive to maintain harmonious relationships, whereas younger managers often prioritize immediate conflict resolution and task completion. Our own research reveals that the relationship between older workers and younger managers is a significant source of conflict within organizations, largely due to age-related norms. Furthermore, our study indicates that younger workers are often perceived as lacking the ability to effectively manage team conflicts due to their limited experience in their roles.

Intention to Leave: The intention to leave an organization can be divided into two categories: the intention triggered by the organizational structure and procedures, and the intention triggered by personal beliefs. According to Skuciene & Moskvina (2019), only 26% of employers in Lithuania claim to encourage their older staff to continue in their professional careers. However, these organizations do not actually provide the necessary motivation for workers to prolong their careers, such as flexible working arrangements and lifelong learning opportunities. Our own research has shown that startups generally do not have long-term plans in place to support workers in pursuing their career paths within the organization. We found that there are no specific organizational structures or policies implemented to encourage older workers. As a result, many workers develop the intention to leave. Warren and Kelloway (2010) suggest that the decision to retire is also influenced by financial factors and social/policy influences. Our research revealed that employees are not willing to retire within the organization due to the lack of benefits, including financial incentives, that would support their long-term career goals and retirement plans. Brown and Medoff (2001) argue that older

organizations are more likely to offer fringe benefits such as pensions and health insurance, and they also have the financial capacity to provide higher wages compared to newly established firms. However, they note that organizations gradually adopt these benefits over time, considering the cost and uncertainty of the organization's survival. In our research, we also encountered concerns about the long-term survival in the organization, which led employees to question their own future within the organization. Furthermore, our findings indicate that due to the absence of proper organizational policies and structures, employees are inclined to have shorter tenures within the organization especially when it comes to the company offering performance management initiatives or training and development plans. The desire to leave the organization due to organizational policies and structure also extends to personal factors. According to our research, we discovered that as time progresses, workers typically do not feel aligned with the company's age norms, leading to a lack of compatibility.

4.8 Chapter Conclusion

This chapter has presented an extensive exploration of the data outcomes, accompanied by a comprehensive evaluation and discussion with literature. Our discussion with literature was able to bring significant understanding to the topic of age norms while we present both theoretical and practical perspectives to the subject matter. Furthermore, by merging our findings with existing literature, we have emphasized the significance and practicality of our research.

Chapter 5: Final Considerations

The objective of this chapter is to present a comprehensive overview of the research conducted within a technology startup and to address our research question while providing a summary of our key findings in relation to our primary and secondary objectives. Moreover, we will emphasize the specific inquiries that emerged during the research on organizational age norms and outline the significance of our research on organizational age norms from both practical and theoretical perspectives. We will also highlight contributions to the existing literature on the subject matter. Lastly, we will acknowledge the limitations of our study and propose recommendations for future research.

There is a lack of empirical studies on age norms within organizations or organizational age norms. Our systematic review revealed a scarcity of research on the development of age norms in organizations and the specific age norms present in certain industries. Additionally, we discovered a gap in understanding the implications of organizational age norms for management. Considering the importance of this topic, the limited literature available, and the need to comprehend how age norms function within organizations, we formulated our research question: "How are organizational age norms developed and what is their influence within organizations?" To address this question, our primary objective was to gain an understanding of the formation and influence of organizational age norms within a tech startup. We also created secondary objectives, which included: a) To explore how age norms are formed in a tech startup, b) to identify the implications of age norms on workers' behavior within a tech startup, c) to identify how age norm violations are sanctioned within the organization and, d) to analyze the extent to which age norms are shared or not within the organization.

In relation to our primary objective, the development of age norms within organizations is a complex process influenced by various social, cultural, and organizational factors. Based on our study, it was evident that age norms within an organization are primarily created by the founders. Drawing from their personal experiences, beliefs, and values, the founders shape

and disseminate specific age norms. Our investigation revealed that the founders' beliefs regarding age norms led them to establish a workplace where younger individuals could thrive. Prior to establishing this environment, their primary concern was ensuring that employees would respect them based on their age. Naturally, one would assume that younger individuals would be more inclined to show respect towards the founders when it comes to age. Similarly, individuals of the same age group would also be expected to demonstrate this sort of respect. As a result of these beliefs, the founders began recruiting individuals within certain age ranges or even younger. In cases where older workers applied, the founders conducted interviews but based on their beliefs, assumed that these individuals did not accept the job due to the founders' age and physical appearance. It is presumed that the company's appearance did not conform to traditional standards. Over time, the founders, with the assistance of managers, ingrained the age norms deeply within the organization. Numerous young employees were hired, and they gradually adopted these age norms as part of their culture and values, eventually becoming a way of life for them. As employees embraced the organization's culture, the age norms became increasingly entrenched. Occasionally, older workers who joined the organization would experience conflicts with the prevailing age norms culture. Our research indicates that age norms are shaped by individuals' beliefs and stereotypes regarding age. In organizational settings, the establishment of age norms heavily relies on the founders, and these norms gradually take root through recruitment and selection processes facilitated by managers and recruiters.

In relation to our secondary objectives, age norms have a significant impact on various aspects of the daily operations within an organization which in turn have an influence in behavior.

Recruitment and selection process: Specifically, we have observed that age norms play a crucial role in the recruitment and selection process. The organizational culture tends to attract individuals who belong to the desired age group. Prospective employees can gauge their compatibility with the organization's age norms through social media, which helps them decide

whether to pursue employment opportunities. Once hired, these employees continue to adhere to and embody these age norms in their daily routines.

Hiring decisions: We observed that founders, managers, and recruiters tend to seek individuals within specific age groups. This is because they believe that a fast-paced, innovative, and flexible technological environment requires such individuals. Particularly in the product department, age preferences based on norms will dominate, as older workers may struggle with programming languages. Additionally, age beliefs vary depending on the department and its specific needs. For instance, the customer service department heavily relies on promptly addressing customer queries and chats. Consequently, younger workers are preferred as they are perceived to respond faster. Although older workers may take more time to provide accurate answers, this is not a major concern as the primary focus is maintaining a significantly low average response time for clients. In departments like marketing, younger workers are preferred due to their proficiency in social media, creativity, and innovation. Similarly, in sales, there is a preference for younger workers who possess technological expertise, as their main responsibility is to sell or demonstrate technological platforms to clients. This raises the question of whether older workers would be preferred in sales roles in other industries due to their extensive sales background. Our research indicates that while sales background is potentially important, there is a shift towards a new approach to sales, different from the traditional methods older workers may be accustomed to.

Conflict: We found that due to the age norms within the organization, there is a form of intergenerational conflict. The conflict in our research arose because employees had reservations about their leaders not being of an appropriate age to hold their positions. There is a presumption that older employees are better equipped to handle team management and conflict resolution within the team. Consequently, when the team leader is perceived as incapable of effectively leading the team and managing various team dynamics, conflict arises. In our case, the conflict stemmed from two main factors: individuals not accepting the age of their team leaders as suitable for their roles, and conflict arising from the presence of two different age groups within the team. This conflict is also fueled by the perception that younger

employees are less dedicated than their older counterparts. Our research indicates that there is a belief that younger individuals lack formal communication skills, which contributes to conflicts within the organization.

Intention to leave: Based on the culture and age norms within the organization, it is evident that employees typically form their intentions to leave based on two main factors: organizational aspects and personal considerations. When the organization itself triggers an employee's intention to leave, it is often due to specific structural practices or the absence of such practices. In line with the age norms present in the organization, there may be a lack of certain fringe benefits, under the assumption that younger individuals do not yet have the same responsibilities that necessitate such benefits. Furthermore, the fast-paced nature of the organization may lead to a lack of performance improvement plans, as these are perceived to be time-consuming. Young and dynamic individuals are expected to quickly adapt to the organizational environment, and those who struggle may not be the right fit for the organization. The absence of long-term structure or plans can also contribute to employees wanting to leave at some point. Most employees seek a workplace where they can envision themselves growing older and eventually retiring. In our research organization, the absence of such provisions can be attributed to the fact that it is a startup still in the process of establishing its longevity. In contrast, personal beliefs also play a significant role in influencing employees' decisions to leave. These beliefs often stem from age-related norms and the perception that certain age groups may not align with the organization's culture. Employees may anticipate additional responsibilities, such as homeownership or starting a family, as they age. Due to the lack of support systems for these individuals, employees may fear being pushed out of the organization as they grow older, either voluntarily or involuntarily.

When it comes to age norms violations and sanctions, according to the literature, deviations from prescribed age norms can occur in both positive and negative ways. Our research yielded limited evidence of age norms violations and corresponding penalties. However, it is crucial to acknowledge that age norms violations and sanctions do exist within the organization.

Unfortunately, our data was insufficient to substantiate these claims or determine the nature of the sanctions.

Through our research, we have also discovered that age norms are typically embraced within an organization. However, there comes a time when an individual may deviate from these age norms due to the belief that they no longer align with the company's expectations concerning age. This deviation can be seen as a violation of the organizational age norms, leading to the individual contemplating leaving the organization. While it may be easy to attribute leaving the organization as a consequence of violating age norms, we prefer to examine the sanctions imposed at a group level. These sanctions are the repercussions that the group enforces on the violator. On the other hand, some employees never shared the organizational age norms, resulting in a fragmented perspective as suggested by Martin (2002). Nevertheless, many employees do adhere to the organizational age norms, which has led us to uncover various rituals, humor, and organizational stories within the company. Hence, we argue that age norms are predominantly shared among individuals, but there comes a point where some individuals no longer fit within the age norms group.

5.2 Contributions to Literature

One of the primary motivations behind conducting this research was the lack of empirical evidence supporting age norms in their entirety. Many articles lack empirical research on age norms and instead focus on age-related elements such as stereotypes and ageism, rather than thoroughly examining the norms and their consequences or characteristics. In the context of organizations, age norms have not received sufficient attention. Considering this, our research makes a significant contribution by conducting empirical research in a technology startup. We can demonstrate how age norms are formed within the organization and the impact they have on organizational behavior. Furthermore, we can add contribution to how age norms in organizations can influence workplace dynamics and organizational culture.

Methodologically, we employed netnographic methods, primarily conducted virtually and often within online communities. This allowed us to closely observe the company and conduct interviews during the observation process. Additionally, combined three data collection sources (observation, interview, secondary data) ensure the depth and reliability of our findings. The integration of these evidential sources was crucial in ensuring the robustness of our data. Furthermore, we have made advancements to literature through our systematic review on organizational age norms, both from a theoretical and empirical standpoint. Our systematic review revealed a lack of evidence on how age norms are formed, their influence on employee behavior, and the positive or negative sanctions associated with age norms within organizations.

5.3 Practical Contributions

From a practical point of view, we have been able to offer a greater understanding and a comprehensive analysis of organizational age norms and their implications such as conflict, recruitment and hiring processes and the intention to leave in an organization. This knowledge can be utilized to enhance organizational culture, refine recruitment processes, and implement effective organizational practices. By understanding how age norms are created in a tech start-up, we can mitigate any negative impact on employee behavior. Our research has uncovered the subconscious development and dissemination of age norms within organizations, shedding light on their detrimental effects on organizational structure and employee behavior. We have also demonstrated the influence of age norms on organizational policies and practices, offering insights into their role in shaping various organizational elements. Furthermore, our research was able to shed more light on the role that age norms play in organizational dynamics, organizational culture and human resources management. We were also able to show that organizational policies and practices or the lack thereof can have a significant influence on employee intention to leave.

5.4 Research Limitations

We believe that a longitudinal study might have been more beneficial for a startup organization. This is because as a startup, many aspects are still being created and developed. Additionally, we believe that as a virtual organization and our observation carried out virtually, we faced some limitations in certain elements that could have been observed. In an in-person environment, we believe that an observation would have been weightier, and interviews would have been carried out in person. We also observed that conducting research in a tech startup with individuals from diverse cultural backgrounds could be complex. This complexity arises from the fact that individuals with different cultural perspectives may have varying views on age norms within the organization. We also discovered that our work could have focused on two aspects: age norms concerning younger employees and age norms concerning older employees. In our organization, we determined that age norms predominantly pertained to younger employees.

5.5 Recommendations for Future Research

Upon reviewing the research work, we have identified gaps that future research can address. It is recommended that our data collection methods be utilized for upcoming research endeavors, or maybe using case studies. On the other hand, we suggest that some quantitative research could be done to highlight a greater number of data sources. Additionally, we propose conducting research in older organizations and different industries, as our current study was limited to a technology environment which influenced the age norms elements observed. Furthermore, we recommend conducting in-depth research on age norms violations and associated sanctions, as these are crucial aspects in understanding organizational age norms. Furthermore, we suggest that the elements of norms such as target, oughtness, expectation and behaviour according to Homans (1971) and Opp (2001) can be researched within organizations. Lastly, exploring the role of management in shaping

organizational age norms and conducting empirical research on the relationship between organizational culture.

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Appendices

Appendix 1: Approved Document from Ethical Committee



contexto organizacional, as normas de idade podem estar intimamente relacionadas aos estereótipos de idade e, em algum momento, normalizadas ou tidas como certas, especialmente como os indivíduos são gerenciados ou autogeridos quando se trata de entender as implicações que sua idade tem no contexto de trabalho (Vickerstaff & Van
der Horst, 2021). Nas organizações, os trabalhadores tentam comparar, avaliar e observar a idade dos outros para ver onde eles estão em suas próprias carreiras ou potencialmente fazer previsões para seu avanço na carreira ou futuro dentro da organização (Kidder, 1981). Existem diferentes efeitos das normas de idade dentro das organizações que surgem como alguns tipos de reações e respostas a certas situações relacionadas com a
idade. Alguns desses efeitos vistos na literatura podem estar ligados ao comportamento no trabalho (Rhodes, 1983), desempenho (Dalton & Thompson, 1971), recrutamento (Skuciene & Moskvina, 2019), aposentadoria (Karpinska et al., 2013), oportunidades de crescimento e processos gerais de tomada de decisão (Waldman & Avolio, 1993). A partir de uma revisão sistemática da literatura, verificou-se que há escassez de pesquisas sobre como as normas de idade são formadas nas organizações e as normas de idade encontradas em determinados setores. Além disso, há uma lacuna nas implicações das normas de idade organizacional para a gestão.

Hipótese

Não se aplica

Objetivo da Pesquisa:

Objetivo Primário:

O objetivo primário desta pesquisa é compreender a formação e influência das normas de idade nas organizações em uma startup de tecnologia.

Objetivo Secundário:

Como objetivos secundários, esta pesquisa pretende:
a) explorar como as normas de idade são formadas em uma startup de tecnologia;
b) identificar as implicações das normas etárias no comportamento dos trabalhadores de uma startup de tecnologia;

(c) identificar como as "violações" das normas de idade são sancionadas dentro da organização;
(d) analisar em que medida as normas de idade nas organizações são compartilhadas ou
não e;
e) compreender os elementos descritivos e normativos das normas etárias em um contexto de start-up de tecnologia.

Avaliação dos Riscos e Benefícios:

Riscos:

Pode haver o risco dos entrevistados ficarem desconfortáveis com algumas perguntas da entrevista. Caso não deseje responder a uma ou mais questões, o participante poderá não responder ou até mesmo retirar seu consentimento em participar da pesquisa. O TCLE já orienta os entrevistados sobre esses desconfortos.

Benefícios:

Os resultados da pesquisa contribuirão para o avanço nos conhecimentos sobre normas etárias nas organizações. Eles permitirão entender como as normas de idade na organização pesquisada se desenvolvem e suas implicações no comportamento dos empregados, tópicos pouco estudados na literatura de gestão. Em termos de benefício prático, a partir do conhecimento de como as normas de idade se formam os gestores da startup estudada podem minimizar o efeito negativo das normas de idade no comportamento de seus empregados. Os participantes não terão nenhum benefício imediato de participarem da pesquisa, mas podem solicitar a devolutiva dos resultados, pelo contato do pesquisador. A devolutiva será
feita por meio de relatório a ser encaminhado aos interessados após a defesa da tese (outubro/2023).

Comentários e Considerações sobre a Pesquisa:

Trata-se de respostas das pendências solicitadas no parecer anterior.

Considerações sobre os Termos de apresentação obrigatória:

Os documentos foram apresentados.

Recomendações:

1) Com base na Norma Operacional do CNS n 001/2013 e como um item obrigatório para ser apresentado no projeto de pesquisa, recomenda-se que o mesmo cronograma apresentado nas



informações básicas seja inserido no projeto de pesquisa

2) Nas informações básicas do projeto há itens específicos para preenchimento dos critérios de inclusão e exclusão, recomenda-se que estes itens sejam preenchidos.

Com base na Norma Operacional do CNS n.001/2013 e como um item obrigatório para ser apresentado no projeto de pesquisa, recomenda-se que os critérios de inclusão e exclusão sejam inseridos no projeto de pesquisa

3) Recomenda-se que o local de realização da pesquisa seja inserido nas Informações Básicas e no projeto de Pesquisa

4) Recomenda-se que seja numerada a primeira página do TCLE, só consta numeração 2/3 e 3/3.

5) Recomenda-se que no TCLE seja inserida a opção de que o participante poderá imprimir o TCLE como comprovante. Deve constar o link da página de onde poderá ser impresso, juntamente com o timbre e logotipo da instituição proponente;

6) Com base na Norma Operacional do CNS n.001/2013 e como um item obrigatório para ser apresentado no projeto de pesquisa, recomenda-se que os riscos sejam inseridos no projeto de pesquisa.

Conclusões ou Pendências e Lista de Inadequações:

Trata-se de análise de resposta ao parecer pendente nº 5.827.961 emitido pelo CEP em 19/12/2022

PENDÊNCIA 1 - Alterar o cronograma, uma vez que a coleta de dados somente pode ser efetuada após a aprovação do protocolo de pesquisa por esse comitê.

RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: O cronograma está atualizado na Plataforma Brasil.

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA Vide Campo "Recomendações item 01

PENDÊNCIA 2 - Indicar os critérios de inclusão e exclusão dos(as) participantes: não há indicação explicita se trata-se de indivíduos com mais de 18 anos tanto do sexo masculino quanto feminino, não há indicação se trata-se de indivíduos.

UNIVERSIDADE
PRESBITERIANA MACKENZIE

Continuação do Parecer: 5.874.537

RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: Critérios de inclusão: Funcionários maiores de 18 anos, homens ou mulheres, que atuam em diversos departamentos da empresa e em cargos de diferentes níveis hierárquicos.

Critérios de exclusão: Funcionários com idade inferior à 18 anos (se tiver).

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA – Vide Campo "Recomendações item 02

PENDÊNCIA 3 - Explicitação do local da pesquisa (entrevistas e observação não participante) – on line ou presencial. Caso seja on line indicar quais os cuidados serão tomados para garantir a privacidade do(a) participante da pesquisa. Caso seja presencial indicar igualmente se serão realizadas entrevistas em locais adequados na empresa garantindo-se a privacidade e sigilo das informações.

RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: Todas as entrevistas serão online. As observações serão online também participando como ouvinte de algumas reuniões gerais.

Entrevistas: Será solicitada aos participantes autorização para gravação de áudio e vídeo das entrevistas

Observação: É importante notar que nas observações não terão gravação de imagem e áudios, apenas notas de campo dos pesquisadores

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA - Vide Campo "Recomendações item 03

PENDÊNCIA 4 - Explicitação no TCLE que haverá a garantia de manutenção do sigilo e da privacidade dos participantes da pesquisa seja pessoa ou grupo de pessoas, durante todas as fases da pesquisa.

RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: Foi feita a adequação do TCLE

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA



PENDÊNCIA 5 - Adequação do TCLE - Papel timbrado deve ser o do Mackenzie, instituição que realiza a pesquisa e não da empresa de tecnologia.

RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: A Será utilizado papel timbrado do Mackenzie no TCLE . Foi realizada alteração no TCLE.

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA

PENDÊNCIA 6 - De forma a garantir sua integridade o Termo de Consentimento Livre e Esclarecido deve apresentar a numeração das páginas. Solicita- se que esta seja inserida de forma a indicar, também, o número total de páginas, por exemplo 1 de 2; 2 de 2.
RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: O número das páginas foi incluído no TCLE

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA - Vide Campo "Recomendações item 04

PENDÊNCIA 7 - Se for presencial incluir igualmente espaço para rubricas em cada página (pesquisador (a) responsável e participante da pesquisa)
RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: Todas as entrevistas e observações serão online.

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA - Vide Campo "Recomendações it, 05

PENDÊNCIA 8 - Alteração da redação do TCLE para que sejam observados os arts. 11 e art. 28, IV da Resolução CNS 510/2016 retirando-se as seguintes frases (i) « É importante que você autorize os pesquisadores para gravação de voz e/ou imagem ». (ii) « Depois das transcrições, as gravações serão descartáveis de forma consciente e responsável.»
RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: As frases mencionadas foram retiradas do TCLE, conforme pode ser visto no documento "TCLE modificado"

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA

PENDÊNCIA 9 - Há necessidade de garantir o acesso aos resultados da pesquisa dando-se uma devolutiva aos participantes. Nesse sentido não deve ser indicado que os participantes podem



PENDÊNCIA 5 - Adequação do TCLE - Papel timbrado deve ser o do Mackenzie, instituição que realiza a pesquisa e não da empresa de tecnologia.

RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: A Será utilizado papel timbrado do Mackenzie no TCLE . Foi realizada alteração no TCLE.

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA

PENDÊNCIA 6 - De forma a garantir sua integridade o Termo de Consentimento Livre e Esclarecido deve apresentar a numeração das páginas. Solicita- se que esta seja inserida de forma a indicar, também, o número total de páginas, por exemplo 1 de 2; 2 de 2.
RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: O número das páginas foi incluído no TCLE

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA - Vide Campo "Recomendações item 04

PENDÊNCIA 7 - Se for presencial incluir igualmente espaço para rubricas em cada página (pesquisador (a) responsável e participante da pesquisa)
RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: Todas as entrevistas e observações serão online.

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA - Vide Campo "Recomendações it, 05

PENDÊNCIA 8 - Alteração da redação do TCLE para que sejam observados os arts. 11 e art. 28, IV da Resolução CNS 510/2016 retirando-se as seguintes frases (i) « É importante que você autorize os pesquisadores para gravação de voz e/ou imagem ». (ii) « Depois das transcrições, as gravações serão descartáveis de forma consciente e responsável.»
RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: As frases mencionadas foram retiradas do TCLE, conforme pode ser visto no documento "TCLE modificado"

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA

PENDÊNCIA 9 - Há necessidade de garantir o acesso aos resultados da pesquisa dando-se uma devolutiva aos participantes. Nesse sentido não deve ser indicado que os participantes podem



entrar em contato para obter informações dos resultados, mas sim indicar que eles terão acesso aos resultados da pesquisa (art. 17, VI da Resolução CNS 510/2016). Nas informações básicas consta que «Os participantes não terão nenhum benefício imediato de participarem da pesquisa, mas podem solicitar a devolutiva dos resultados, pelo contato do pesquisador. A devolutiva será feita por meio de relatório a ser encaminhado aos interessados após a defesa da tese (outubro/2023).». Deve constar no TCLE que os(as) participantes terão acesso aos resultados da pesquisa, sendo a devolutiva efetuada por meio de relatório a ser encaminhado após a defesa de tese (outubro/2023).

RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: Atualizado e anexado no sistema

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA

PENDÊNCIA 10 - Apresentação dos roteiros de entrevistas específicos para cada grupo de participantes

RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: Serão anexados no sistema os roteiros específicos para os fundadores, empregados e gerentes.

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA

PENDÊNCIA 11 - Explicitar se os riscos a que estão submetidos os(as) participantes da pesquisa são semelhantes ao da vida cotidiana. Em caso negativo, indicar quais as medidas a serem adotadas para evitar essas situações de risco (quer dizer, as providencias cabíveis) (cf. art. 17, II e arts 18 e 19 da Resolução CNS 510/2016).
RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: Consta no TCLE o seguinte trecho: "O risco envolvido na participação da pesquisa é mínimo. Eventualmente, você pode se sentir desconfortável em responder alguma pergunta da entrevista. Caso na o deseje responder a uma ou mais perguntas, você podera decidir na o responde-las ou ate mesmo retirar o seu consentimento em participar da pesquisa, em qualquer momento, sem nenhum prejuízo. Havera a garantia de manutenção do sigilo e da privacidade dos participantes da pesquisa durante todas as fases da pesquisa.

Se ocorrer qualquer problema ou dano pessoal comprovadamente decorrente da participação nesta

UNIVERSIDADE
PRESBITERIANA MACKENZIE

pesquisa, lhe será garantido o direito à solicitação de indenização determinada por lei."

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA Vide Campo "Recomendações it. 06

PENDÊNCIA 12 - Solicita-se esclarecimentos se a pesquisa é de cooperação internacional? Caso a resposta seja sim, deve ser alterada a menção de "Necessita Apreciação da CONEP?: de Não para Sim" pois esta condição pode se tratar de uma área temática especial que deve tramitar também pela CONEP - Comissão Nacional de Ética em Pesquisa.

RESPOSTA DA PENDÊNCIA: Não, A pesquisa não é de cooperação internacional

ANÁLISE DO CEP: PENDÊNCIA ATENDIDA

Todas as pendências foram respondidas adequadamente. Recomendando-se igualmente que seja observado o disposto no campo "Recomendações", bem como todas as normas federais de ética em pesquisa em humanos.

Considerações Finais a critério do CEP:

Ressalta-se que cabe ao pesquisador responsável encaminhar os relatórios parciais e final da pesquisa, por meio da Plataforma Brasil, via notificação do tipo "relatório" para que sejam devidamente apreciadas no CEP, conforme Norma Operacional CNS nº 001/2013,item XI.2.d.

Salienta-se que quando for realizada a apresentação do relatório final, é necessário documentar como a efetuada a devolutiva, o relatório final, deve ser apresentado após a conclusão da pesquisa e da etapa de fornecimento de devolutiva aos participantes.

Este parecer foi elaborado baseado nos documentos abaixo relacionados:

Tipo Documento	Arquivo	Postagem	Autor	Situação
Informações Básicas do Projeto	PB_INFORMAÇÕES_BÁSICAS_DO_PROJETO_1968447.pdf	20/01/2023 23:06:26		Aceito
Outros	CARTA_RESPOSTA_AS_PENDENCIAS_Modificado.pdf	20/01/2023 23:06:12	Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan	Aceito

UNIVERSIDADE
PRESBITERIANA MACKENZIE

Continuação do Parecer: 5.874.537

Outros	Roteiro_Entrevista_Fundadores.docx	20/01/2023 23:04:36	Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan	Aceito
Outros	Roteiro_Entrevista_Gerentes.docx	20/01/2023 23:03:56	Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan	Aceito
Outros	Roteiro_Entrevista_Empregados.docx	20/01/2023 23:03:36	Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan	Aceito
TCLE / Termos de Assentimento / Justificativa de Ausência	TCLE_Modificado.pdf	18/01/2023 17:39:35	Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan	Aceito
Outros	Projetodetalhadoportuguese.pdf	25/11/2022 04:05:57	Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan	Aceito
Outros	cartaencaminahemtocep.pdf	20/10/2022 10:39:52	Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan	Aceito
Declaração de Instituição e Infraestrutura	[redacted]	21/09/2022 13:51:25	Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan	Aceito
Projeto Detalhado / Brochura Investigador	Projetodetalhado.pdf	21/09/2022 13:23:34	Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan	Aceito
Folha de Rosto	FolhaDeRosto_Darcy_2022_assinada.pdf	20/09/2022 03:21:54	Christiana Adebukola Adegbesan	Aceito

Situação do Parecer:
Aprovado

Necessita Apreciação da CONEP:
Não

SAO PAULO, 02 de Fevereiro de 2023

Assinado por:
Fernanda Bellicieri
(Coordenador(a))

Endereço: Rua Da Consolação nº896 - Ed João Calvino 4º andar sala 400
Bairro: HIGIENOPOLIS **CEP:** 01.302-907
UF: SP **Município:** SAO PAULO
Telefone: (11)2768-7615 **E-mail:** cep@mackenzie.br

Appendix 2: Free and Informed Consent Form

Universidade Presbiteriana Mackenzie

CCSA - Centro de Ciências Sociais e Aplicadas
Programa de Pós-Graduação em Administração de Empresas

FREE AND INFORMED CONSENT TERMS (TCLE)

This is an invitation for you to participate in the research "Exploring organizational age norms in a technology startup", to be carried out by the researchers: CHRISTIANA ADEBUKOLA ADEGBESAN and DARCY MITIKO MORI HANASHIRO from Universidade Presbiteriana Mackenzie.

Research Objective

This research aims to understand the formation and influence of age norms in organizations in a technology startup. The reason that leads us to carry out this study is to understand the age norms that exist in organizations and how they influence organizational practices and behaviors.

Target Audience (Participants)

Professionals in the areas of technology, human resources, customer support, marketing, sales. Other professionals with knowledge relevant to the research may also participate.

Your Participation

If you agree to participate, you will be interviewed by the researchers. Interviews can last approximately one hour. The interviews will be online, via Zoom or Microsoft Teams. At the end of this document, we ask for your authorization to record your voice and/or image during the interviews.

Benefits of Research

The research results will contribute to advancing knowledge about age norms in organizations. They will allow us to understand how age norms in the researched organization are developed and their implications for employee behavior, topics little studied in management literature. In terms of practical benefit, based on the knowledge of how age norms are formed, managers of the studied organization can act with the aim of minimizing the negative effect of age norms on the behavior of their employees.

Research Risks

Universidade Presbiteriana Mackenzie

CCSA - Centro de Ciências Sociais e Aplicadas
Programa de Pós-Graduação em Administração de Empresas

The risk involved in participating in research is minimal. Occasionally, you may feel uncomfortable answering some interview questions. If you do not wish to answer one or more questions, you may decide not to answer them or even withdraw your consent at any time, to participate in the research, without any prejudice.
The confidentiality and privacy of research participants will be guaranteed during all phases of the research.
If any problem or personal injury occurs as a result of participating in this research, you will be guaranteed the right to request compensation determined by law.

Confidentiality

The analysis will be carried out in aggregate (your answers will be analyzed together with the interviews of other participants), at no time will your identity be revealed. The premises of the Brazil General Data Protection Law – no. 13,709, of August 14, 2018, which provides for the processing of personal data, including in digital media, will also be safeguarded. You have the guarantee that the information obtained in the interviews will only be used in this study, in conferences and academic and professional journals.
All information collected in this research will be stored for a minimum period of 5 years, so that you can freely decide about your participation and the use of your data now and in the future.

Access to Research Results

Survey participants will have access to survey results. Participants can acess the research results through the Mackenzie public library after October, 2023.

Contact

At any stage of the study, you will have access to the researchers responsible for clarifying any doubts at (Rua da Consolação, 930 - Prédio 45, ground floor | São Paulo | SP | telephone: (11)2114-8597, and contact details below), and you will have the right to withdraw your consent to participating in the study at any time, without any penalties.
If you have any questions about the ethics of this research, you should contact the Research Ethics Committee of Universidade Presbiteriana Mackenzie – CEP/UPM. This committee is an interdisciplinary board, with a public role, of a consultative, deliberative and educational nature, created to defend the interests of research participants in their integrity and dignity, and to contribute to the development of research within ethical standards. The CEP/UPM is

CCSA - Centro de Ciências Sociais e Aplicadas
Programa de Pós-Graduação em Administração de Empresas

located at Rua da Consolação, 896 Ed João Calvino, 4th floor, room 400, telephone (55)(11) 2766-7615 and e-mail: cep@mackenzie.br. The CEP's opening hours are Monday and Wednesday from 3:00 pm to 6:00 pm and Tuesday and Thursday from 9:30 am to 12:30 pm, there is no service on Fridays.

Decision on your Participation

After reading this Informed Consent Form (TCLE), please select the option that represents your desire to participate in this research.

Thank you very much for your time and opportunity to contribute to the generation of knowledge.

Appendix 3: Interview Questions Guidelines

Interview Questions Guidelines

Employees

- Tell me about your selection process
  Describe any occurrences or patterns you saw that made you believe you were a fit for the company
- Relate an experience you had in the company that made you feel like the age of an individual had a part to play in certain elements within the company.
- Talk about the perception you have of people's age and their current position in the organization.
- Give account of any reactions you have had when it comes to the age of your colleagues (older or younger) especially within this tech startup's context.
- What are the things (practices) you like the most and least like about the company?
- Is there any point where you think your age may not fit into the company anymore? If yes, can you explain this? And how does this make you feel?
- At what age would you want to be promoted or move to a different position? And why?
- Is there anyone you think should be in a different/higher position and they are not yet in? Why do you think this way and how does this make you feel?
- Can you identify any difference between an older and younger colleague?
- What behavioral patterns relating to work do you identify in a younger colleague and older colleague?
- What perception do you have of those that are older and younger than you in this organization?
- What perception do you have of people's age and their positions in this organization?

Managers

- Tell me about any selection process (what do you usually look out for and what sticks to you in an applicant)
- What are the patterns or occurrences that you find in a candidate that makes you think they are the perfect fit for the company
- Explain any differences and behavioral patterns that you can identify between the older and younger workers
- Explain any differences and behavioral patterns that you can identify between the older and younger workers
- Are there any trainings or practices that can help with these behavioral patterns?
- What are the things (practices) you like the most and least like about the company?
- Is there any point where you think your age may not fit into the company anymore? If yes, can you explain this? And how does this make you feel?
- Is there any point where you think your age may not fit into the company anymore? If yes, can you explain this? And how does this make you feel?

Founders

- Tell me about the process of founding this organization
- Describe any situations where people have had to compare your age with what you currently do in this organization
- Describe any preparations you have for your workers 10 years for now. What are those things you are putting into consideration and how will you deal with them?
- Comment on any age preferences you have for certain roles in your company
- What experiences would you say helped in shaping any age norms you have in this company